

## **Resource: Study Notes - Themes (Tyndale)**

### **Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)**

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## Study Notes - Themes (Tyndale)

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*Temple Design as a Picture of God's Truth, Temple Legislation as Theology, Temple Worship, The Antichrist, The Ark of the Covenant, The Birth of Christ, The Blessings of Jesus, The Broken Covenant, The Bronze Snake, The Central Sanctuary, The Choice of Life or Death, The Christ Hymn: Christ's Divine Nature, The Church, The Church as a Living, Active Body, The Church as God's Temple, The Cities of Refuge, The Climax of Scripture, The Cloud and Fire, The Collapse of Culture, The Coming of God's Kingdom, The Coming of the Lord as Judge, The Coming of the Spirit of God, The Creation, The Creator-King, The Cross and Passover, The Dangers of Sin, The Day Is Coming, The Day of the Lord, The Exodus as History, The Family Redeemer, The Gift of Prophecy, The Glory of God, The Good News Message, The Grace of God, The Growth of the Church, The Heart in the Psalms, The Holiness of God's People, The Holy One of Israel, The Holy Spirit's Presence, The Holy Spirit's Work, The Household, The Land, The Last Things and the Thessalonians, The Law and the Spirit, The Limitations of Law, The Little Horn, The Lord of Nations, The Message of Reconciliation, The Messiah, The Messianic Banquet, The Mystery of the Good News, The New Community, The New Covenant, The New Order, The Old Life and the New Life, The Old Realm and the New, The Passover, The Plagues, The Poor and Needy in the Psalms, The Priestly Blessing, The Promise of a Second Exodus, The Promise of Dynasty, The Promise of New Life, The Purpose of the Judgments, The Purpose of the Sinai Covenant, The Remnant, The Resurrection of Jesus, The Resurrection of the Dead, The Return of God's Presence with His People, The Righteous Suffer, The Secret of the Messiah, The Servant-Leader, The Seventy Sets of Seven, The Shepherd, The Son of God, The Son of Man, The Sovereignty of God, The Spirit of the Law, The Spirit's Presence, The Stone the Builders Rejected, The Suffering Prophet, The Superiority of the Son, The Tabernacle, The Theater and Revelation, The Thousand Years (The Millennium), The Unknown God, The Word, The World, The Worship of Angels, The Written Word, Tolerance, True Justice, True Success, Trusting God in Isaiah, Trusting God in the Psalms, Trusting in Human Strength*

### Temple Design as a Picture of God's Truth

The temple plan in [Ezekiel 40-43](#) does not seem possible to build, nor was it meant to be. The plan lacks enough detail for construction, as shown by the different diagrams scholars have created. Unlike the tabernacle, the plan does not specify materials ([Exodus 25:10-40:33](#)). There is also no evidence that anyone tried to build the second temple using this plan. Therefore, Ezekiel's temple plan is not a blueprint for future construction.

Ezekiel's temple vision shows God's message through a building design. It intends to shame Ezekiel's generation for their past and encourage future faithfulness ([Ezekiel 43:10-12](#)). The vision describes a new world where obvious boundaries between the holy and unholy exist, and standards are higher. This allows God to return to his temple and live among his people again (see [10:3-4](#), [18:11:22-23](#)).

Access to the holy area is much more limited. Faithful individuals from the past gain renewed access, while God rejects unfaithful people. There is a stronger focus on sacrifices for atonement and purification for the people.

This new temple represents Jesus Christ, who reveals God's glory. His body was a temple that others would destroy and he would rebuild in three days ([John 2:19](#)). In Jesus, God's holiness shone brightly in the darkness, and the darkness could not overcome it ([John 1:5](#)). His body was the perfect, one-time sacrifice that purified the people ([Hebrews 10:12](#)).

Those united to Christ now have the privilege of accessing the Most Holy Place in heaven in the new Jerusalem. Its doors are always open to those who "have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb" (see [Revelation 21](#); [22:14](#)).

Since God unites us Christians with Christ and we are part of his body, the new temple, we cannot live as we did before. The Holy Spirit lives in and among us, and our bodies now belong to him as parts of his

new temple ([1 Corinthians 6:15-20](#)). A holy life is proof that we are God's children ([1 Peter 1:13-16](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 25:10-40:33](#); [Leviticus 10:9-11](#); [Ezekiel 22:26](#); [40:1-43:27](#); [John 2:19](#); [1 Corinthians 6:15-20](#); [Hebrews 9:22-10:19](#); [1 Peter 1:13-16](#); [Revelation 21:1-27](#)

## Temple Legislation as Theology

The religious teachers of Judaism (called "rabbis") spent much time trying to make the laws of [Ezekiel 44-48](#) agree with those laws of the Torah (the law given to Moses). They failed because these chapters do not intend to match the law of Moses. This is similar to how the vision of the temple building was not designed to look like the tabernacle or Solomon's Temple ([Ezekiel 40-43](#)). The temple rules describe a theological message of change, similar to the earlier description of the temple's architecture.

These rules emphasized the need to separate the temple from the palace. Sacrificial ceremonies would increase and focus more on purification. Holy people would again make offerings to the holy God. These practices intended to separate the holy from the unholy and purify God's people. Pollution of the temple and idol worship had caused the Lord to leave ([Ezekiel 8-11](#)).

So, they needed a new situation for God to live among his people again. These rules intended to make the prophet's listeners aware of their past wrongs that confused what was holy and unholy. It also encouraged them that God would restore their worship to its proper condition.

These rules also put the prince, the king descended from King David, in a position of submission to the Lord. The arrival of Jesus fulfills this element. Jesus came as a servant king who was happy to do what the Father wanted ([Matthew 4:1-11](#); [20:25-28](#)). He offered the perfect sacrifice that cleanses sin, purified the heavenly sanctuary once for all time, and ensured that God could live among his people forever ([Hebrews 9:11-12, 23](#)). His blood cleanses us from all sin. It allows sinners to confidently enter most holy place of heaven without fear of rejection or punishment.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 56:7](#); [Ezekiel 8:1-11:25](#); [40:1-43:27](#); [44:1-46:18](#)

## Temple Worship

In the ancient Near East, kings had to provide for their nation's temple. King David, who started the family line (dynasty) of Judah's kings, made Jerusalem the capital of Israel ([2 Samuel 5:4-10](#)). He also made it the main place of worship. King Solomon built the temple, but David prepared for its construction and worship practices.

Solomon took seven years to build the temple in Jerusalem. He started in the fourth year of his rule (967 BC). The temple was large. It was 27 meters long (90 feet), 9 meters wide (30 feet), and almost 13 meters high (45 feet). Its entrance court (portico or vestibule) was 4.5 meters deep (15 feet), spanning the width (see [1 Kings 6:2-10](#)).

He used the most advanced building techniques of the time. The cost was not a concern for construction, decoration, or equipment. Even so, Solomon admitted it was not good enough to house the eternal God ([1 Kings 8:27](#)).

The temple, next to the king's palace, represented God's rule over creation and all nations. "The LORD is in His holy temple; let all the earth be silent before Him" ([Habakkuk 2:20](#)). It taught Israel about God's unique rule and their complete reliance on him. Although no building can contain God, he chose the temple as the main place for his presence on earth. Thus, the temple was central to Israelite worship and the personal relationship between God and his people.

God gave the kings the task of committing themselves to him and promoting proper worship at the temple. The temple confirmed that God authorized the human king to represent divine rule. [Psalm 132](#) expressed this role by celebrating David's return of the ark of the covenant to Jerusalem ([Psalm 132:6-12](#)). Solomon used this psalm at the end of his prayer when he established the temple ([2 Chronicles 6:41-42](#)).

Later, Christ and the church fulfilled the temple's role in showing God's presence. Jesus indicated the shift from the temple buildings to his own body as the spiritual temple (see [John 2:19](#)). The disciples began to understand this change after Christ's resurrection ([John 2:21-22](#)).

The apostle Paul described the church as the new holy space where Jews and non-Jews (gentiles) are reconciled. Using temple imagery, he explained how Jesus "has torn down the dividing wall of

hostility" in the body of Christ (the church) to create one people ([Ephesians 2:14-15](#)). The church is God's holy temple, built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets ([Ephesians 2:20-22](#)). It is made from "living stones," Christians, who God joins together around Jesus Christ, the cornerstone ([1 Peter 2:4-5](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 8:27-53](#); [1 Chronicles 22:1-19](#); [2 Chronicles 5:2-14](#); [6:41-42](#); [7:12-16](#); [Psalm 48:9](#); [65:4](#); [66:13](#); [138:2](#); [Jeremiah 7:3-11](#); [11:15](#); [Ezekiel 8:6-16](#); [44:1-31](#); [Joel 1:14](#); [2:17](#); [Habakkuk 2:20](#); [Haggai 2:7](#); [John 2:19-22](#); [Ephesians 2:14-15](#), [20-22](#); [1 Peter 2:4-5](#)

## The Antichrist

The term *antichrist* appears only in the apostle John's letters ([1 John 2:18, 22](#); [4:3](#); [2 John 1:7](#)). John believed many antichrists would appear throughout history ([1 John 2:18](#)). These antichrists would deny that Jesus is both divine and human ([1 John 2:22](#); [4:2-3](#); [2 John 1:7](#)).

The apostle Paul mentions "the man of lawlessness" who will appear in the last times to start a rebellion against God ([2 Thessalonians 2:1-12](#)). This person will "will be accompanied by the working of Satan." This is mainly through deception. Revelation does not specifically call him "antichrist." But this "man of lawlessness," like the "antichrists" in John's letters, will oppose the truth.

In [Revelation 13](#), a spirit opposing Jesus Christ is "another beast" serving the dragon (Satan) and the first beast. The number of this antichrist, 666, probably represented Emperor Nero and possibly Emperor Domitian (see study note on 17:8). Emperor worship, which declared "Caesar is Lord!" was a false religion opposing the proclamation of Jesus Christ as Lord.

It is uncertain if John expected a final antichrist even greater than leaders like Nero or Domitian. Nevertheless, Christians must recognize the presence of evil. They must also recognize its opposition to Christ in people and power structures worldwide. Resisting these enemies may lead to persecution and even death. But our hope is in ultimate victory through Christ.

#### Passages for Further Study

[2 Thessalonians 2:3-10](#); [1 John 2:18, 22](#); [4:2-3](#); [2 John 1:7](#); [Revelation 13:11](#)

## The Ark of the Covenant

The ark of the covenant was a wooden chest covered with gold, located in the Most Holy Place of the Jewish tabernacle, and later the temple. It reminded Israel of God's covenant with them. Inside were the tablets of the covenant, known as the "Ten Commandments." On the day of atonement, the high priest sprinkled blood on the ark's cover to purify the people ([Leviticus 16:2-17](#)).

During Israel's time in the wilderness, God's glory appeared over the ark, where he met with his people (see [Exodus 25:22](#)). Throughout Israel's history, the ark represented God's presence. The people carried it as they traveled ([Numbers 10:33-36](#)). When they brought it to the Jordan River, the water stopped so the Israelites could cross on dry ground ([Joshua 3:4-6](#)). They carried the ark around Jericho before the city was invaded. It was present during the siege of the Ammonite city of Rabbah in King David's time ([2 Samuel 11:1-11](#)).

The Philistines considered the ark as equal to Israel's God ([1 Samuel 4:6-8](#)). This made sense because the Philistines took images of their gods into battle ([2 Samuel 5:21](#)). The Israelites did not use images of God. So they considered the ark as God's "footstool" and temporary home, not his image (see [1 Chronicles 28:2](#)).

Yet, the Israelites developed a false view of the ark. They treated this holy object like a magic box and tried to use God's presence for their own gain. They thought "it may go with us to save us from the hand of our enemies" (see [1 Samuel 4:3](#)). Their defeat that day showed that no one can control God ([4:1-11](#)). He is the leader of his people, and they must obey and trust him (compare [Joshua 5:13-15](#)).

King David eventually moved the ark to Jerusalem ([2 Samuel 6:1-17](#)). When King Solomon built the temple, he placed the ark in the most holy place. It remained the center of Israelite worship ([1 Kings 8:1-11](#)).

The Hebrew scriptures do not mention the ark after the early kingdom or monarchy. It was probably destroyed by the Babylonians along with the temple in 586 BC. Yet, a tradition from the apocrypha (or deuterocanon) claims that the prophet Jeremiah hid the ark during the exile in

Babylon ([2 Maccabees 2:4–8](#)) (The apocrypha is a set of ancient texts not included in the Hebrew Bible but accepted by some Christian groups as Scripture.) Still, God's presence through Jesus Christ and his complete sacrifice made the ark unnecessary (see [Hebrews 9:1–10:18](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 25:10–22](#); [40:20–21](#); [Leviticus 16:2](#); [Numbers 10:33–36](#); [Deuteronomy 31:25–26](#); [Joshua 3:4–6](#); [6:6–13](#); [Judges 20:26–28](#); [1 Samuel 4:3–11](#); [5:1–7:2](#); [2 Samuel 6:1–17](#); [Jeremiah 3:16–18](#)

## The Birth of Christ

The stories of the birth of Jesus show contrasts show a clear contrast between humble circumstances and divine importance ([Matthew 1:18–2:12](#); [Luke 2:1–20](#)).

On one side, we see the humble nature of his birth. A poor couple travels to Bethlehem, the home of their ancestors. They go to register for a census (a government count of all the people living in a country or region) ordered by the Roman Empire, which ruled over their land at that time. Their journey from Galilee to Bethlehem was long and difficult. When they arrived, they could not find any place to stay. They had to use a place where animals were kept.

The whole situation showed poverty, rejection, and lack of attention from others. When Jesus was born, the news was not sent to important kings or wealthy people. Instead, the announcement went to simple shepherds who were watching their sheep in a field nearby.

Yet beside this humble setting is a message of amazing power and greatness. The baby placed in a feeding trough (manger) is the Messiah, the long-awaited descendant of King David. He will rule victoriously over the people of Israel, and his kingdom will never end.

He is the one all the prophets spoke about. All of history had been pointing forward to its most important moment in him. A group of wise men from eastern countries traveled to honor him. And an army of powerful angels came from heaven to announce his birth.

These contrasts give us a first look at what will come later. In Jesus, the God of Israel and Lord of all the earth has come to visit and save his people. God

comes down from heaven to meet people in their everyday lives and circumstances. Throughout the Gospels, Jesus shows special concern for the humble, the poor, the rejected, and sinners. He comes to save them because they recognize their need for him. They receive the message of salvation with joy and happiness.

The contrast between humility and greatness also connects to Jesus' mission. Evil people reject him and kill him. Yet, God proves Jesus right at his resurrection and raises Jesus to his "right hand."

There at his throne, he rules as Lord and Messiah. From there, he sends the Spirit of God to lead and guide his church. Through his life, death, resurrection, and rise to glory, Jesus offers forgiveness of sins. He gives eternal life to all who respond to him with a faithful life.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 1:18–2:12](#); [Luke 2:1–20](#)

## The Blessings of Jesus

The Beatitudes are the blessings Jesus gave to his followers. They get their name from the word *beati* (which means blessed) in the Latin translation of the Bible (the Vulgate). No single word can fully express what Jesus means here. He describes God's special favor toward his people, both physically and spiritually, and the outcomes of living in that favor.

The Beatitudes describe how a follower of Jesus should live and behave. Jesus invites people to follow him as he shares the message of the kingdom with Israel (see also [Matthew 11:6](#); [13:16](#); [16:17](#); [24:46](#)). Those who Jesus blesses have repented from their sins in response to the kingdom's message ([Matthew 4:17–22](#)). The Beatitudes relate to [Isaiah 61:1–3](#). The Holy Spirit gives power and leads people to share the good news about Jesus. The Holy Spirit blesses the poor, the humble, and the righteous.

In the Bible, the word "blessed" suggests:

- These blessings come from God and show his approval (see [Matthew 25:34](#)).
- The blessings show God's promises coming true (see [Matthew 11:6](#); [13:16](#); [16:17](#)).
- The blessings change things in surprising ways, making life better for those who trust God (see [Luke 1:1-2:52](#); [6:20-26](#)).
- To receive these blessings, people need to obey God (see [Psalms 1:1](#), [3-6](#); [106:3](#); [112:1-2](#); [119:1-2](#); [Proverbs 8:32](#); [Isaiah 56:2](#)).

These blessings began when Jesus the Messiah came to earth. Christians can be confident that they will enjoy these blessings fully and forever.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 1:1-3](#); [106:3](#); [112:1-2](#); [119:1-2](#); [Isaiah 56:1-2](#); [Matthew 5:3-12](#); [11:6](#); [13:16](#); [16:17](#); [24:46](#); [25:34](#); [Luke 6:20-26](#)

## The Broken Covenant

After God rescued the Israelites from Egypt, he made a special agreement (called a covenant) with them (see [Exodus 20-24](#)). In this covenant, God gave them the Ten Commandments and other laws. The people promised to follow these laws, and God promised to bless them if they did. But the Israelites broke the terms of the covenant.

A central issue in God's relationship with Israel was whether the covenant made at Mount Sinai was still valid after the people had broken it. In ancient Near Eastern politics, covenants were common. When one of the partners in a covenant broke the terms of the agreement, the result was usually war.

The covenant was special because God was one of the partners. It followed the pattern of non-religious covenants and required both God and Israel to confirm the agreement with oaths promising to be faithful ([Exodus 24:1-11](#); [Deuteronomy 29-30](#); [Joshua 8:30-35](#); [24:1-28](#)).

God always remained faithful to his covenant, but the Israelites continued to break it. Canaanite worship of many gods tempted them away from the Lord. They worshipped idols and engaged in

immoral sexual ceremonies. They treated the poor and needy badly and ignored God's rules for righteousness.

For centuries, the Israelites either worshiped God (Yahweh) or Canaanite gods. Whenever they repented and obeyed God, he mercifully accepted them back into the covenant relationship. Yet, by the mid-700s BC, the Israelites of the northern kingdom of Israel had become stubbornly committed to idol worship. So God allowed the Assyrians to destroy the kingdom and take many people into captivity.

The prophet Jeremiah's ministry was over one hundred years later. Now Judah was committing idolatry. Jeremiah compared this situation to a marriage divorce, similar to Hosea's earlier story about Israel ([Jeremiah 2-3](#); compare [Hosea 1-2](#)). The Scriptures compare Israel's relationship with God to a marriage where the bride committed adultery.

God accused his people of breaking the marriage bond and behaving like a prostitute ([Jeremiah 3:1](#)). He warned them to repent or encounter destruction. God could no longer say of the Israelites, "I will be their God, and they will be My people" (see [Jeremiah 31:33](#); see also [Exodus 6:7](#); [Hosea 1:9](#)).

Breaking the covenant led to the northern kingdom's destruction and later the destruction of the kingdom of Judah. Babylon destroyed Jerusalem and the temple. This punishment deeply pained God. The ever-merciful God promised a new covenant to replace the Sinai covenant that Israel had broken ([Jeremiah 31:31-34](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 6:7](#); [Jeremiah 2:1-3:10](#); [4:4](#); [22:8-9](#); [31:31-34](#); [Ezekiel 16:1-63](#); [Hosea 2:2-13](#); [3:1](#); [4:1-5:15](#)

## The Bronze Snake

[Numbers 21:4-9](#) describes an event where the Israelites complained against God and Moses. They were unhappy about the food and water and said, "We detest this wretched food!" ([21:5](#)). In response, the Lord sent poisonous snakes that bit and killed many people (see [Deuteronomy 8:15](#)). Realizing their mistake, the Israelites asked Moses to pray for the removal of the snakes. God told Moses to make a bronze snake. Anyone bitten could

look at it and God would heal them ([Numbers 21:8](#)).

This was not a typical medical treatment. The healing came from God and required faith to look at the bronze snake and trust in God's healing power. The snake bites were a result of God's punishment. But he also provided a way for their salvation through his mercy (see *Wisdom of Solomon* 16:5-7).

When Hezekiah became king of Judah in 715 BC, the Israelites started using Moses' bronze serpent as an idol (see [2 Kings 18:1-4](#)). They probably kept the image to remember God's power. This was similar to other holy things from the wilderness period (see [Deuteronomy 10:5](#); [Hebrews 9:4-5](#)). Yet, they began worshiping it as another god. So they had to destroy it like other pagan worship items and pillars. Such idolatry threatens the worship of the one true God (compare [Exodus 32](#)).

Jesus mentioned the bronze snake incident to prophesy how he would die. He would "be lifted up" on the cross like Moses lifted the snake on a pole ([John 3:14-15](#); see also [8:28](#); [12:32-33](#)). The metal snake image acted as a cure for snake bites. Similarly, those who look to Christ's cross and accept Jesus' sacrifice receive an eternal promise ([John 3:14-16](#)).

The Lord sent snakes to punish Israel for complaining about the manna in the wilderness ([Numbers 21:4-9](#)). Jesus called himself "the true bread from heaven," the spiritual manna that gives eternal life to his people ([John 6:32-40](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 21:4-9](#); [2 Kings 18:1-4](#); [John 3:14-15](#); [6:32-40](#); [8:28](#); [12:30-34](#)

## The Central Sanctuary

God wanted people to worship where he had chosen to put his name. For Israel, this was first the tabernacle and later the temple in Jerusalem.

God is *transcendent* (above all things) and *omnipresent* (present everywhere). Yet he chose a specific place for Israel to worship him. King Solomon later asked how the God of heaven could live in a building made by humans ([1 Kings 8:27](#)). The answer is that God's name represents himself.

The tabernacle and later the temple belonged to him and his name marked them. So they were, in a

way, his homes. In the ancient Near East, names were more than just labels. They showed the character and nature of the person (for example, Jacob, [Genesis 27:36](#); Jesus, [Matthew 1:21](#); Barnabas, [Acts 4:36](#); Peter, [Matthew 16:17-19](#)). Thus, Solomon could advise, "A good name is more desirable than great riches" ([Proverbs 22:1](#)).

God lived in a holy place that carried his name. His glorious presence appeared as fire and cloud during the time Israel lived in the wilderness. This acted as a constant reminder that he was with his people ([Exodus 40:34-35](#)). Similarly, when Solomon established the temple, God's presence was also evident ([1 Kings 8:10-11](#)).

God later lived among his people as Jesus Christ ([John 1:14](#)). This removed the need for a central holy place (see [John 4:19-24](#)). Now, because the Holy Spirit lives within them, all Christians can "house" God's presence ([1 Corinthians 3:16-17](#); [6:19-20](#); [2 Corinthians 6:16](#); [Ephesians 2:21](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 25:8-9](#), [22](#), [40](#); [26:30](#); [33:7-11](#); [40:34-35](#); [Numbers 7:1](#); [11:16](#); [Deuteronomy 12:4-7](#); [31:14-15](#); [1 Kings 8:10-11](#), [27](#); [John 1:14](#); [2:19-21](#); [Acts 7:44](#); [1 Corinthians 3:16-17](#); [6:19-20](#); [2 Corinthians 6:16](#); [Ephesians 2:21](#); [Hebrews 8:2](#), [5](#); [Revelation 21:22](#)

## The Choice of Life or Death

Moses instructed the Israelites as they were about to enter the promised land. They had a choice. They could obey the covenant, which is life as God designed it, and live. Or they could refuse to obey the creator's design and die ([Deuteronomy 30:19](#)). This choice and its consequences continued throughout the time of God's covenant with Israel.

The specific language of Deuteronomy 30 appears again in the prophecy of Jeremiah during the Babylonian invasion. God said, "Behold, I set before you the way of life and the way of death" ([Jeremiah 21:8](#)). The prophet warned King Zedekiah and his people to obey the Lord's instruction. If they obeyed, they would live, if not, they would die.

Earlier in Jeremiah's prophetic ministry, the Lord gave the people of Judah a chance to repent ([Jeremiah 3:12-4:4](#)). They must stop idol worship, admit their guilt, and confess their rebellion. Then God would cleanse their minds and hearts. He would allow them to live peacefully in the land. Yet,

the people continued to reject this offer ([Jeremiah 7:5-7](#); [18:8-11](#); [23:22](#); [26:13](#); [27:12-13](#); [29:32](#); [35:15](#); [36:3-7](#); [44:5](#)). So the Lord continued to warn them that rejecting the path of life would lead to judgment.

In Jeremiah's time, only a few chose life. Most rebelled and died. Ultimately, the people led by King Zedekiah ignored the Lord. They rebelled against the Babylonian army, and suffered judgment. They deliberately rejected the gift of life.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 11:26-29](#); [30:15-20](#); [Proverbs 9:1-18](#); [11:19](#); [18:21](#); [Isaiah 1:19-20](#); [Jeremiah 3:12-15](#); [4:3-4](#); [7:5-7](#); [18:7-11](#); [21:8-9](#); [23:22](#); [26:13](#); [27:12-18](#); [35:15](#); [36:3-7](#); [44:5](#); [Ezekiel 18:23-24](#); [Romans 6:23](#); [8:6](#); [Revelation 2:10](#)

## The Christ Hymn: Christ's Divine Nature

The passage in [Philippians 2:6-11](#) is often called the Christ Hymn. This section reveals what early Christians believed about Jesus Christ. The hymn shows that early Christians believed Jesus existed before his birth on earth and that he has a divine nature (see also [Colossians 1:15-20](#); [2:9](#); compare [John 1:1-2](#); [Hebrews 1:1-3](#)).

The hymn teaches that Christ is not just another human prophet. He was with God the Father from the beginning. He is the one through whom God created the universe. As the Son of God, Jesus shares God's own nature.

This claim about Jesus being divine caused major disagreements between Jesus and the religious leaders of his time. They accused Jesus of blasphemy (speaking in a way that dishonors God) when he claimed to be equal with God ([John 5:16-18](#); [8:54-59](#); [10:30-39](#)).

The hymn also teaches that Jesus Christ came to earth in an act of great humility. The infinite God (who is eternal and not bound by time) took on human nature in the person of Jesus Christ and entered human history ([Philippians 2:7](#); see [Colossians 1:15](#); [John 1:10-14](#); [Hebrews 2:14, 17](#)). Jesus Christ, the glorious Creator of the universe, died as a sacrifice for the sins of human beings. This was to secure forgiveness and reconcile humanity with God ([Philippians 2:8](#); see [John 3:14-17](#); [Romans 5:9-10](#); [Colossians 1:20, 22](#); [2:13-14](#);

[Hebrews 1:3](#); [10:9-14](#)). The Scriptures had prophesied this very thing (see [Isaiah 53:3-12](#)).

This hymn states that God raised Jesus from the dead and gave him the highest honor in heaven ([Philippians 2:9](#)). God also gave him the title "Lord" ([Philippians 2:11](#); compare [Colossians 1:18](#)). One day, all created beings will bow before him and acknowledge him as Lord of the universe ([Philippians 2:9-11](#)). He deserves the worship that only God is worthy to receive (see [Revelation 5:8-14](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 53:3-12](#); [John 1:1-2, 10-14](#); [3:14-17](#); [Romans 5:9-10](#); [Philippians 2:6-11](#); [Colossians 1:15-22](#); [2:9, 13-14](#); [Hebrews 1:1-3](#); [2:14, 17](#); [10:9-14](#); [Revelation 5:8-14](#)

## The Church

The church is the community of people who acknowledge Christ as Lord and obey him ([Ephesians 5:21-24](#)). The New Testament word for "church" comes from the Greek word *ekklēsia* (meaning "a group of people who gather together"). In the Greek-speaking world, this word was used for different types of meetings. It could mean a formal political meeting or just an informal gathering of people (for example, [Acts 19:32, 39, 41](#)). In the Septuagint (the Greek translation of the Old Testament), the term refers to when the community of Israel met (for example, [Deuteronomy 31:30](#)).

In the New Testament, *ekklēsia* refers to:

1. The entire body of Christ worldwide (for example, [Matthew 16:18](#); [Ephesians 1:22](#))
2. All Christians in a specific area (for example, [Acts 9:31](#); [1 Corinthians 1:2](#))
3. A local community that meets regularly for worship, teaching, fellowship, and prayer (for example, [Romans 16:5](#); see [Acts 2:42](#))

The New Testament uses several concepts to describe the church:

1. *The Israel of God* ([Galatians 6:16](#)): Those who are "God's own possession" ([1 Peter 2:9-10](#)). They serve as "a holy priesthood, offering spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God" ([1 Peter 2:5, 9](#)).
2. *God's family* ([Ephesians 2:19](#); [1 Timothy 3:15](#)): This consists of those adopted as God's spiritual children and named as his heirs.
3. *A holy temple*: The place God lives by his Spirit ([Ephesians 2:21-22](#); [4:6](#); [1 Corinthians 3:16-17](#); [2 Corinthians 6:16](#); [Colossians 1:27](#)).
4. *Body of Christ*: They represent Christ fully in the world, with Christ as the leader ([Ephesians 1:23](#); [4:15](#); [5:23-24](#); [1 Corinthians 12:12-27](#); [Colossians 1:18, 24](#)).
5. *Christ's pure bride*: The one he died for, cares for, and cherishes. She will live with him forever in unity. ([Ephesians 5:25-29](#)).

The church is part of God's plan to unite everything in heaven and on earth under Christ's authority ([Ephesians 1:9-10](#)). Through Jesus Christ, God has called people from both Judaism and the non-Jewish world (gentile) to become one new people of God ([Galatians 6:16](#)). They are empowered by his Spirit to be present in the world, worship him, and share the good news (gospel) of his unconditional love ([Ephesians 2:11-22](#)).

The spiritual roots of the church are in Judaism. The church fulfills God's intention for Israel to be "a light for the nations" and to "bring My salvation to the ends of the earth" ([Isaiah 49:6](#); see also [Romans 11:1-5](#)). In this new community of Jewish and non-Jewish believers, Jesus breaks down all the old divisions between people. No one is considered better or worse than others because of their ethnic background, social position, or whether they are male or female ([Galatians 3:28](#)).

Those united with Christ are members of his body. Paul describes the close connection between Christ and his people as similar to the unity of a physical body ([Romans 12:4-8](#); [1 Corinthians 12:12-27](#)). Being "in Christ" means "baptized into one body" ([1 Corinthians 12:12-13](#)). As a result, "you are the

body of Christ, and each of you is a member of it" ([1 Corinthians 12:27](#)).

Christians connect with God as part of a new family. Being "in Christ" means being part of the church. Being a Christian means joining a community committed to express Christ's reality in its shared life.

Since the church is one body, unity is necessary. Paul often encouraged Christians to stay united and not let differences separate them.

The church includes people from different ethnic groups, so it should be a community of harmony and peace. Christians should live together in love, united by their shared experience of the Holy Spirit ([Ephesians 4:2-6](#)). God's goal for the church is to reach complete unity, faith, spiritual understanding, and Christian maturity. He intends for the full perfection of Christ ([4:13, 15](#); compare [Romans 8:29](#)). The church must reflect God's likeness ([Ephesians 4:24, 32](#); [5:1](#)).

Just like each part of the human body has a role, each church member has a function. God has given people in the church various gifts to strengthen the community and help it reach its full potential ([Ephesians 4:11-16](#); [Romans 12:6-8](#); [1 Corinthians 12:7-11, 28](#)).

God intends for the church to display his forgiving grace ([Ephesians 2:7](#); [3:10](#)). It should be a community where people can see God's glory, committed to praising that glory ([3:21](#); [5:18-20](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Romans 8:29](#); [12:6-8](#); [1 Corinthians 3:16-17](#); [6:16](#); [12:7-28](#); [Galatians 6:16](#); [Ephesians 1:9-10](#), [23](#); [2:7](#); [2:14-3:13](#); [4:2-6](#), [11-16](#); [5:18-20](#), [23-29](#); [Colossians 1:18, 24, 27](#); [1 Timothy 3:15](#); [1 Peter 2:5, 9-10](#)

## The Church as a Living, Active Body

The apostle Paul considered the church as the living body of Jesus Christ made up of believers. Paul did not make any formal difference between professional church leaders and ordinary members, where only the leaders did the ministry work. The community had leaders (see, for example, [1 Timothy 3:1-13](#)). But every Christian could contribute to building up the body ([1 Corinthians 12:12-31](#)). The early Christians usually gathered together in someone's home, and

everyone could share a gift from God with others ([14:26-33](#)).

Paul understood that God's Spirit gives people special gifts for their specific ministries ([1 Corinthians 2:7-11](#), [28](#); [Romans 12:6-8](#); [Ephesians 4:11](#)). The Holy Spirit leads them when they come together for worship. Guided by the Spirit, every believer should use their spiritual gifts to help the church. Paul wanted believers to be aware of the Spirit's power in everything they did ([1 Corinthians 14:26-33](#)).

When Christians gather, every person is important and has an active role to play. Christians must listen for God speaking his word and be ready to speak it in all their relationships. Paul also calls for others to "weigh carefully" (or evaluate) what is said ([1 Corinthians 14:26](#), [29](#)). Every Christian is a necessary part of the group. Each person is called to actively help it grow.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Romans 12:4-8](#); [1 Corinthians 12:7-31](#); [14:26-33](#); [Ephesians 1:23](#); [4:11-13](#); [Colossians 1:24](#); [2:18-19](#); [1 Timothy 3:1-16](#)

## The Church as God's Temple

The idea of the church as God's temple comes from the Old Testament. The kings David and Solomon received a promise that the temple in Jerusalem would be where God lived among his people (see [2 Samuel 7:12-16](#); [1 Kings 9:1-9](#)). Solomon finished the temple in 960 BC. The Babylonians destroyed it in 586 BC. But the prophets of Israel anticipated a new temple. They shared a hopeful message that God would live among his people again (see, for example, [Isaiah 56:7](#); [Ezekiel 40-43](#)).

The Israelites rebuilt the temple in Jerusalem after the exile when they returned from Babylon. It reached its peak during Herod the Great's additions. But the arrival of Jesus Christ truly fulfilled the hopes of God's people (see [John 1:14](#); [2:19-22](#); [4:21-24](#)). Jesus is God's temple, where God's holiness lives. God invites his people to join him. Therefore, God's people should be a holy temple, a home for the Holy Spirit (see [1 Corinthians 3:16-17](#); [6:19](#); [2 Corinthians 6:16](#); [Ephesians 2:21](#); [1 Peter 2:5](#); [Revelation 3:12](#)).

The apostle Paul urged Christians to understand their identity as God's holy people (called "saints" in [2 Corinthians 1:1](#)). They should avoid moral evil

and commit themselves to holy living and service to God. Paul encourages Christians to "cleanse ourselves from everything that defiles body and spirit, perfecting holiness in the fear of God" ([7:1](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[2 Samuel 7:12-16](#); [1 Kings 8:12-53](#); [2 Chronicles 6:20](#); [Psalms 11:4](#); [27:4-6](#); [Zechariah 6:12-15](#); [Matthew 18:20](#); [John 2:18-22](#); [14:20](#); [17:23](#); [Romans 8:10](#); [1 Corinthians 3:10-17](#); [6:18-20](#); [9:11-14](#); [2 Corinthians 6:14-7:1](#); [Galatians 2:20](#); [Ephesians 2:20-22](#); [3:17-19](#); [Colossians 1:27](#); [Hebrews 3:6](#); [12:18-24](#); [1 Peter 2:4-9](#); [Revelation 1:12-16](#); [3:12](#), [20](#); [21:22](#)

## The Cities of Refuge

The Israelites built the cities of refuge to protect innocent people from blood revenge. An avenger had the legal right to kill a murderer ([Numbers 35:19](#); see [Genesis 9:6](#)). If someone accidentally caused a death, the person fled to a city of refuge for temporary safety while awaiting trial ([Numbers 35:22-28](#)). The six cities of refuge spread across Hebrew territory so any Israelite could seek refuge.

After the trial, if the elders of the city found the person guilty of murder (instead of accidental killing), they handed him over to the avenger for punishment ([Deuteronomy 19:12](#)). If they found the person innocent, the killer stayed in the city of refuge for safety. When the high priest died, the killer could return home without fear of blood revenge. This compassionate law prevented the land from pollution by innocent blood (see [Numbers 35:33](#)).

Paying a fine to repay the death of a person was not acceptable, even if the death was accidental ([Numbers 35:31-33](#)). Human life was too valuable for money to purchase it. When someone killed another person, whether on purpose or by accident, it led to alienation or exile.

Atonement is not easy, whether in ancient Israelite times or today. Everyone needs atonement to restore their relationship with God (see [Romans 3:23-26](#)). Jesus, the Son of God, offers this reconciliation. He acts as the great high priest and died as the ultimate sacrifice (see [Hebrews 4:14-10:18](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 35:6-34](#); [Deuteronomy 19:1-13](#); [Joshua 20:1-9](#); [21:13](#), [21](#), [27](#), [32](#), [38](#); [1 Kings 1:50-53](#); [2:28-34](#)

## The Climax of Scripture

The gospel story of the two disciples on the road to Emmaus is important. It shows Jesus' victory over death and reveals his role as the Messiah (God's chosen one). It also connects to Old Testament prophecies about him.

The two disciples told their unknown traveling companion that Jesus was a great prophet because of his teachings and miracles. They had hoped he was the Messiah. When the Jewish leaders arrested and crucified him, these two disciples became desperate and discouraged.

Jesus scolded them for not reading the Scriptures carefully. The Scriptures had always prophesied the Messiah's suffering. The apostle Luke then describes how Jesus guided the two disciples through the Scriptures, explaining "explained to them what was written in all the Scriptures about Himself" ([Luke 24:27](#)).

Jesus does not indicate which Old Testament passages talk about the suffering Christ. But other passages from Luke's writings refer to various texts:

- Jesus is "the stone the builders rejected" that "has become the cornerstone," for a new temple of God ([Psalm 118:22](#), cited in [Luke 20:17](#)).
- He is the suffering servant of the Lord, treated like a common criminal ([Isaiah 53:12](#), cited in [Luke 22:37](#)).
- His opponents mock, insult, and spit upon him ([Isaiah 50:6](#), suggested in [Luke 18:32](#)).
- He is the anointed king rejected by the leaders and the people of Israel, but declared innocent by God ([Psalm 2:1-2](#), cited in [Acts 4:25-28](#)).
- He is the descendant of King David who God will not abandon to the grave ([Psalm 16:8-11](#), cited in [Acts 2:25-28](#)).

According to [Luke 24:27](#), Jesus reviewed Israel's history and showed how it anticipates and achieves its purpose (climax) with Jesus the Messiah, God's agent of salvation. This is similar to how the apostle Paul describes Christ as "the end of the law" ([Romans 10:4](#)). All the Old Testament Scriptures, including the law of Moses, the prophets, and the Psalms, show God's story of salvation ([Luke 24:44](#)). This story achieves its purpose in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus.

### Passages for Further Study

[Luke 24:13-49](#); [Romans 10:4](#)

## The Cloud and Fire

When Israel was in the wilderness, God guided them with a pillar of cloud and fire. The pillar appeared to the Israelites immediately after the first Passover, when they left Egypt ([Exodus 13:20-22](#)).

The pillar had many roles:

1. When the Egyptians chased the Israelites as they left Egypt, the pillar moved behind the Israelites and stopped the Egyptians ([Exodus 14:19-20](#)).

2. During Israel's travels, the pillar showed that "the Lord went before them" ([Exodus 13:21](#)).
3. When the pillar settled over the tabernacle and Israel's camp, it represented the Lord's presence and protection.
4. The cloud and fire also guided the Israelites when traveling ([Exodus 40:36-38](#); [Numbers 9:17-23](#)). When the pillar stayed still, Israel remained in place. When it lifted and moved, the Israelites followed. They camped in different places for various lengths of time, sometimes brief and sometimes long. Thus, Israel "camped at the LORD's command, and they set out at the LORD's command" ([Numbers 9:23](#)).
5. The pillar of cloud and fire was like a divine flag over the tribes as they marched (compare [Numbers 10:14, 18, 22, 25](#)).

The pillar appeared as a cloud during the day and as a pillar of fire at night ([Numbers 9:15-16](#); [Exodus 13:21](#)). In the Bible, fire and clouds often show God's presence and glory (for example, [Exodus 19:16-18](#); [24:15-18](#); [Matthew 17:5](#); [24:30](#); [Acts 1:9](#); compare [Psalm 18:8-13](#)). The cloud and fire showed that God's presence and glory traveled with Israel through the wilderness. This special appearance of God (a *theophany*) stayed with them during all their travels in the wilderness ([Exodus 40:38](#); see also [Exodus 13:22](#)).

Sometimes, the cloud covered the tabernacle, and the glory of the Lord filled it, so Moses could not enter ([Exodus 40:34-35](#)). Other times, the cloud came down and stayed near the entrance of the Tent of Meeting, showing that the Lord was speaking directly with Moses ([Exodus 33:7-11](#); compare [Numbers 11:25](#); [12:5](#); [Deuteronomy 31:15](#)). The pillar of cloud and fire was a constant reminder of the Lord's presence.

We do not have a detailed description of the fire and cloud, except that it had the shape of a pillar. Yet, it was a powerful symbol of God's special care for Israel (see [Nehemiah 9:19-21](#); compare [Psalms 46:1](#); [139](#); [John 1:14](#); [Romans 8:31-39](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 13:20-22](#); [14:19-24](#); [16:10](#); [19:16-18](#); [24:15-18](#); [33:7-11](#); [40:34-38](#); [Leviticus 16:2](#); [Numbers 9:15-23](#); [10:11-12](#), [34](#); [11:25](#); [12:5](#), [10](#); [14:14](#); [16:42](#); [Deuteronomy 31:15](#); [1 Kings 8:11](#); [2 Chronicles 5:14](#); [Nehemiah 9:19-21](#); [Psalms 78:14](#); [99:7](#); [104:3](#); [Ezekiel 1:4-5](#); [10:3](#); [Matthew 17:5](#); [24:30](#); [26:64](#); [Luke 9:34-35](#); [Acts 1:9](#); [1 Corinthians 10:2](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:17](#); [Revelation 1:7](#); [14:14-16](#)

## The Collapse of Culture

Impressive cultures with creative and skilled people sometimes come to an end suddenly and completely. When digging, archaeologists often find a layer of ash between layers of impressive artifacts. The ash shows the culture's destruction. This is one of the most troubling parts of human history.

Israel's history includes cycles of bravery and success, followed by disaster. Leaders like Joshua, Samuel, David, and Solomon brought Israel to power. Yet, the nation often worshiped other gods instead of the one true God. As a result, God's people experienced judgment, and their culture failed.

They lost political independence and became slaves treated badly. The northern kingdom of Israel was particularly attracted to worshiping idols like Baal and Asherah. Thus, God allowed the Assyrians to conquer the northern kingdom, destroying it in 722 BC.

During the prophet Jeremiah's time, the spiritual and political culture in Judah was collapsing. Some kings, like Josiah, followed the covenant ban against idol worship and brought the people back to God. Yet, many rulers, including King Josiah's sons, did not continue these changes.

For instance, King Jehoiakim ignored his father's renewed commitment to God. He considered it as a threat to his political power. He became so opposed to the Lord that he tried to kill Jeremiah, the Lord's messenger. King Zedekiah was more fearful than opposed to change, but he also refused to obey the Lord.

God's messages through Jeremiah strongly criticize Judah's worship of Baal ([Jeremiah 2:8](#); [7:9](#); [11:13, 17](#); [12:16](#); [19:5](#); [23:13, 27](#); [32:29, 35](#)). He also criticized the immorality linked to this idol worship. Judah's moral decay and spiritual corruption, shown by its greed, hate, and violence,

were obvious to everyone. The people stubbornly refused to abandon idol worship and return to the worship of the one true God. Yet, the people of Judah hoped God would perform a miracle by defeating the Babylonian army and sending it away.

They believed the temple would magically protect them. They did not realize that God hated their actions there. This quickened their destruction instead of protecting them ([Jeremiah 7:4-15](#)). They were completely unprepared for the horror of defeat in war and the destruction of their nation, capital, and temple. They did not understand that their spiritual and moral failure had already made their destruction certain.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Joshua 1:1-9; 11:16-23; 1 Samuel 4:1-22; 2 Kings 17:6-18; 23:1-25:30; Jeremiah 7:4-15; 19:1-7; 24:1-10; 28:10-17; Daniel 7:1-8:27](#)

## **The Coming of God's Kingdom**

A key part of Jesus' message was that God's kingdom had come. The people of Israel eagerly awaited this reality. It would fulfill God's many promises that had not yet become a reality:

- The Holy Spirit would return, as the Spirit had in the past. And God would "pour out" his Spirit on each Christian, fulfilling [Joel 2:28-32](#) (see [Acts 2:16-21](#)). This means that the Holy Spirit would be given to all believers, not just to special leaders as in Old Testament times.
- Jesus would defeat Satan ([Mark 3:27; Luke 10:17-18](#)). This was already being shown when Jesus cast out demons ([Mark 1:21-28; 5:1-20; Luke 11:20](#)). Jesus' power over demons was a sign that he was beginning to overcome Satan's influence in the world.
- The new covenant promised in [Jeremiah 31:31-34](#) would begin ([Mark 14:24](#)). This new agreement between God and his people would replace the old covenant made at Mount Sinai.
- The resurrection from the dead would produce its "firstfruits" ([Mark 8:31; 9:9, 31; 10:33-34; 16:6; 1 Corinthians 15:20, 23](#)). This means that Jesus would be the first to rise from the dead with a glorified body, beginning the process that will eventually include all believers.
- God's Anointed, the promised Son of David would come ([Matthew 2:1-12; Luke 2:25-38](#)). This refers to the Messiah (or Christ), the special leader God promised to send who would be a descendant of King David.

Jesus's birth, ministry, death, resurrection, and ascension fulfilled these aspects of God's kingdom. People must repent and trust in the gospel (good news) because God's kingdom has come in Jesus ([Matthew 4:23; 6:10; Mark 1:14-15; 4:26-32; Luke 4:42-43](#)).

When Jesus began the kingdom, everything changed in Israel. The Holy Spirit was active again, working through John the Baptist and Jesus. For those who understood, the promised Christ, or Messiah, had arrived. Because God's kingdom was present in Jesus, the disciples did not fast like the Pharisees and John's disciples ([Mark 2:18-20](#)).

Fasting was not suitable because Old Testament promises were becoming fulfilled.

It was a time for celebration and feasting ([Mark 2:19-20](#)). This was because God's rule had started. People were already entering the kingdom and experiencing its signs ([10:23-31](#); [9:1](#)).

A future aspect of God's kingdom will happen when Jesus returns ([Mark 14:25](#)). At that time, God will judge evil and fully establish justice. Disease, poverty, and death will end. Jesus, the Son of Man, will return in glory and gather his chosen ones ([Mark 13:24-27](#); [Titus 2:11-14](#)).

He will judge the world ([Mark 8:38](#); [14:62](#); [Matthew 25:31-46](#); [2 Timothy 4:1](#); [Revelation 14:14-20](#)). He will resurrect the dead ([1 Corinthians 15:12-57](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:13-5:11](#)). No one knows when Jesus will return ([Mark 13:32](#)). His followers should stay spiritually alert and watch for his coming as they await "the blessed hope" ([13:33-37](#); [Titus 2:13](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Jeremiah 31:31-34](#); [Joel 2:28-32](#); [Matthew 4:23](#); [5:3](#); [6:10](#); [25:31-46](#); [Mark 1:14-15](#); [4:11](#), [26-32](#); [8:31-38](#); [9:1](#), [47](#); [10:23-25](#), [29-31](#); [13:24-27](#), [32-37](#); [14:25](#), [62](#); [Luke 2:25-38](#); [4:18-19](#), [42-43](#); [6:20](#); [10:18-20](#); [11:20](#); [Acts 1:6-8](#); [2:16-21](#); [1 Corinthians 15:22-28](#); [Titus 2:11-14](#)

## **The Coming of the Lord as Judge**

The Bible tells us there will be a day of judgment. The book of James provides followers of Jesus with a warning and a promise about that day. James announces the Lord's future coming as Judge ([5:7-9](#); see also [Isaiah 26:21](#); [Micah 1:3](#)). God, who gave the law, is the "Judge, the One who is able to save and destroy" ([James 4:12](#)). Those who oppose Jesus Christ and oppress his followers will experience severe consequences (see [James 2:6-7](#); [5:5-6](#)).

God will judge followers of Jesus if they do these wrong things:

- if they fail to show mercy ([2:13](#));
- if they become friends with the world and its values ([4:4](#));
- if they sin with their words ([4:11](#); [5:9](#)); or
- if they live to satisfy evil desires ([4:1](#), [16](#)).

God will judge them according to the law that was meant to set them free ([2:12](#)).

The Lord's future coming affects our lives now. God already honors the faithful poor and humbles the rich who treat them badly ([James 1:9-10](#); [5:2-3](#)). Followers of Jesus are already God's special people as God is restoring all things ([1:18](#)). James says we should obey "the royal law" of the kingdom of Jesus the Messiah ([2:8](#)). Followers of Jesus will one day inherit this kingdom ([2:5](#)).

The return of Jesus might not happen soon. So James encourages Christians to endure and wait patiently for Jesus' return ([James 1:3-4](#); [5:7-8](#)). They will "receive the crown of life" ([1:12](#)). And they will gather the rewards of righteousness, which come from a life that is faithful to God ([3:18](#)).

Since judgment is coming, James commands followers of Jesus to "resist the devil" and "submit" themselves to God ([James 4:7](#)). We should "mourn" our sin and live with pure intentions and actions ([4:8-9](#)). We must help any Christian brother or sister who is moving away "from the truth" toward eternal death ([5:19-20](#)). Like the prophet Elijah, we must have faith, and practice prayer and confession ([5:13-18](#)). Like Job, we must endure suffering. Eventually, we will understand the extent of God's kindness and mercy ([4:10](#); [5:11](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 2:10](#); [Psalms 2:7-12](#); [96:11-13](#); [Isaiah 26:21](#); [Micah 1:3](#); [Matthew 16:27](#); [Luke 12:35-48](#); [18:8](#); [John 5:22-30](#); [Acts 10:42](#); [1 Corinthians 4:5](#); [James 5:7-9](#); [1 John 2:28](#)

## **The Coming of the Spirit of God**

In the Old Testament, the Spirit of God sometimes "came upon" people to give them power for God's work and to prophesy ([Numbers 24:2](#); [Judges 3:10](#); [1 Samuel 10:10](#); [16:13](#); [Ezekiel 11:5](#)). During Jesus' time, many people believed that the Spirit of prophecy had left Israel after the last Old

Testament prophets. Yet, the prophets predicted that when God's salvation came, he would "pour out" his Spirit on everyone ([Isaiah 32:15](#); [Ezekiel 36:26-27](#); [Joel 2:28-32](#)).

This prophecy first comes true in the birth story of Jesus in Luke's Gospel. The Holy Spirit inspired prophets to witness and guided the events of Jesus' birth.

The Spirit filled John the Baptist even before birth ([Luke 1:15, 41](#)). His father Zechariah sang a Spirit-filled hymn of praise to God ([1:67](#)). Mary, the mother of Jesus, became pregnant with Jesus and prophesied through the Spirit's power ([1:35](#); [1:46-55](#)). The Spirit led the elderly Simeon to the temple to see the Christ ([2:25-27](#)). Later, the Spirit anointed Jesus at his baptism and empowered him to fulfill his role as the Christ ([3:21-22](#); [4:1, 18](#)).

After Jesus ascended to heaven, he fulfilled Old Testament prophecies by sending his Spirit to his disciples on the day of Pentecost. This empowered them to spread the good news (gospel) of salvation worldwide ([Luke 24:49](#); [Acts 1:8](#); [2:4, 17-18](#)). In the book of Acts, the church completed its mission with the Holy Spirit's guidance, power, and direction. The Spirit's arrival marks the start of a new era of God's salvation. God's presence and power are now within and among his people through the Holy Spirit.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 24:2](#); [Judges 3:10](#); [1 Samuel 10:10](#); [16:13](#); [Isaiah 32:15](#); [Ezekiel 11:5](#); [36:26-27](#); [Joel 2:28-32](#); [Luke 1:15, 35, 41, 67](#); [2:24-27](#); [3:22](#); [4:1, 18](#); [24:49](#); [Acts 2:4, 17-18](#)

## The Creation

The story of the creation of the universe is key to the Bible's message. Understanding the first chapters of the book of Genesis is important for developing a biblical perspective of the world (worldview).

The opening chapters of the Bible address key questions: Who created the world, and why? Why is the world as it is now? Genesis answers these questions. It counters the idol worship that Israel learned from their pagan rulers in Egypt.

In the promised land, the Israelites would again be close to people who trusted in false gods and worshiped created things instead of the creator. Genesis taught Israel that the one true God created

everything and has complete authority over all things. He alone deserves worship.

God changed chaos and made it the orderly universe we see today. In the first three days, he shaped the formless void into the structured universe. He created the heavens, water and sky, and the earth. In the next three days, he filled each area with life. On the seventh day, God's day of rest, he set a weekly pattern for human activity. This rest also points to the future spiritual rest God promised to those who trust in him (see [Hebrews 3:7-4:11](#)).

The creation story teaches that when God finished the creation, it was "very good" ([Genesis 1:31](#)). In this setting, humans had a perfect relationship with their creator until they sinned and violated that bond. This rebellion against God introduced evil into human souls (see chapters [3-6](#)). The world's evil does not result from a flaw in creation. Instead, it comes from rebelling against God's design and purposes.

Since the first rebellion, humans have separated themselves from the creator. They often do not acknowledge his presence and authority.

[Genesis 3:7-19](#) shows what this separation causes:

- shame,
- failed relationships with God and others,
- disconnection from the rest of creation, and
- death.

Since then, God has actively worked in history to restore humans to a relationship with him through Jesus Christ. Restored humans become a new creation (see [Galatians 6:15](#)). Through Jesus, eternal life is available to everyone. God will renew everything one day (see [Isaiah 65:17-25](#); [Romans 8:19-22](#)). The entire universe will be made new ([Revelation 21:1](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:1-2:3](#); [Psalm 33:6-9](#); [Proverbs 3:19](#); [8:22-31](#); [Isaiah 40:26-28](#); [45:11-12](#), [18-19](#); [Jeremiah 10:11-16](#); [John 1:1-4](#); [Romans 8:18-25](#); [2 Corinthians 5:17](#); [Colossians 1:15-20](#); [Revelation 4:11](#); [21:1-5](#)

## The Creator-King

God created and established the world. All of creation is his work ([Genesis 1-2](#); [Psalm 24:1-2](#); [95:4-5](#)). He also rules over his creation, managing and caring for everything he has made ([95:6-7](#); [96:10](#)).

Several psalms celebrate God's glory in creation ([Psalms 8](#); [19](#); [28](#); [33](#); [89](#); and [104](#)):

1. [Psalm 8](#) emphasizes how God gives humans splendor and makes them rulers of creation.
2. [Psalm 19](#) encourages us to think deeply about creation to gain wisdom.
3. [Psalm 29](#) shows God's power and the stability of his creation.
4. [Psalm 33](#) praises God's rule, order, and wisdom in creation, emphasizing the importance of respecting the Lord.
5. In [Psalm 89](#), God's bases his promise to David on his commitment to creation ([89:9-18](#)).
6. [Psalms 93-100](#) reflect on God's rule over the world. The earth belongs to him, and he has shown his power throughout history.
7. [Psalm 104](#) is a hymn about creation. It turns the six days of creation into a beautiful song praising God's wisdom.

Scripture commands all nations to acknowledge and praise God, accepting his supreme authority (see [Psalm 9:11](#); [47:1-2](#), [7-9](#); [66:8](#); [117:1](#)).

### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:1-2:4](#); [Psalms 8](#); [19](#); [28](#); [29](#); [33](#); [89](#); [93-100](#); [104](#); [Ecclesiastes 12:1-7](#), [13-14](#); [Isaiah 40:25-28](#); [43:15](#); [44:24](#); [51:13](#); [Jeremiah 10:16](#); [Acts 4:23-31](#); [Colossians 3:10](#)

## The Cross and Passover

At the start of John's Gospel, John the Baptist introduced Jesus as "the Lamb of God" ([John 1:29](#), [36](#)). This phrase might refer to the sacrificial lamb killed daily in the temple ([Exodus 29:38-46](#)). Or it might refer to the sacrificial lamb mentioned in [Isaiah 53:7](#) (see [Acts 8:32-35](#); [Revelation 5:5-14](#)).

Both sacrifices represent rescue and forgiveness from sin.

Yet, this was not all that the apostle John intended. John presented Jesus as the Passover lamb. This lamb's death is the central event of the Passover season (see [Exodus 12:43-47](#); [Luke 22:7](#); [1 Corinthians 5:7](#)).

In the first century, Jews traveled to Jerusalem each spring to celebrate Passover and once again read the story of the exodus from Egypt (see [Exodus 12-15](#)). When God rescued Israel from Egypt, the Israelites sprinkled lamb's blood on their doorposts. This act saved those inside each home from death ([Exodus 12](#)). Jews who came to Jerusalem for Passover needed to provide a perfect young lamb for sacrifice. The lamb could have no disease or broken bones.

Jesus used his last Passover meal to show that his sacrificial death would give new meaning to the feast ([Mark 14:17-25](#)). At his crucifixion, they did not break Jesus' legs, which was often done to fulfill a Passover rule ([John 19:31-33](#); see [Exodus 12:46](#)). Blood flowed freely from his wound ([John 19:34](#)). This showed that he was giving his life for others. A lamb died to save Jewish families during Passover in Egypt. Similarly, the death of the Son of God on the cross brings salvation to the world.

### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 12:1-13:16](#); [29:38-46](#); [Numbers 9:1-14](#); [Deuteronomy 16:1-8](#); [2 Kings 23:21-23](#); [2 Chronicles 30:1-27](#); [Ezra 6:19-21](#); [Isaiah 53:7](#); [Ezekiel 45:21-22](#); [Matthew 26:2](#), [17-19](#); [Mark 14:17-31](#); [Luke 22:14-30](#); [John 1:29](#), [36](#); [John 19:17-36](#); [Acts 8:32-35](#); [12:3-4](#); [1 Corinthians 5:7-8](#); [Hebrews 11:28](#); [Revelation 5:5-14](#)

## The Dangers of Sin

Choosing sin instead of remaining faithful to the one true God leads to disaster. This has been true since the beginning, when Adam and Eve's disobedience brought curses and separation from their first home ([Genesis 3](#)). It was also true throughout Israel's history (see, for example, [Numbers 16](#); [Joshua 7](#); [2 Samuel 11:1-12:19](#)). The New Testament gives many warnings about the eternal consequences of not repenting for sinful behavior ([1 Corinthians 6:9-10](#); [Galatians 5:19-21](#); [Revelation 22:15](#)).

During the late period of the Israelite kingdom, God's people often committed sinful acts. Words like *sin* and *evil* frequently describe the kings of Israel ([2 Kings 3:2](#); [13:2, 11](#); [14:24](#); [15:9, 18, 24, 28](#); [17:2](#)). This was true about the kings of Judah as well. They "did evil in the sight of the LORD" ([8:18, 27](#); [21:2, 16, 20](#); [23:32, 37](#); [24:9, 19](#)).

The northern kingdom of Israel was especially guilty. The Scriptures consistently criticize the kings and people for their lack of faith ([2 Kings 17:16-17, 22](#)). The main sin of false worship, started by Jeroboam I, continued in Israel until the end ([10:29](#); [17:21-23](#); [23:15](#)). God gave repeated warnings to the people through his prophets ([17:13](#)). He allowed foreign invaders to punish them ([13:3, 7](#)).

The Israelites did not change their behavior ([13:6](#); [17:14-17](#)). Eventually, God let foreign invaders defeat them and capture their land. The Assyrians took many people away into exile ([17:18, 20-23](#)).

The people of Judah were not innocent either. Many of their kings were guilty of serious evil. Judean society became more rebellious, and "lived according to the customs Israel had introduced" ([2 Kings 17:19](#)). But God showed repeated kindness (for example, [19:32-36](#)). His prophets warned the people ([21:8-15](#)). Yet, the people continued to sin, and God judged them again ([21:10-15](#); [23:26-27](#); [24:1-4](#); [25:1-21](#)).

When people truly repent, God will graciously forgive them and remove sin's penalty. Yet, it is better to remain faithful to God's commands ([2 Kings 18:5-6](#); [23:25](#); [Psalm 119:9-11, 33-37](#); [2 Timothy 4:7](#); [Revelation 2:10](#)). Then God's blessings can lead to success ([Psalm 112:1](#); [119:1-2](#); [144:15](#); [2 Kings 18:7](#); see also [2 Chronicles 26:4-5](#); [Proverbs 3:1-10](#); [2 Corinthians 3:5](#)). God's people should give God priority in their lives ([1 Kings 18:21, 36-39](#); see [Deuteronomy 6:13](#); [10:12-13](#); [Micah 6:8](#); [Matthew 6:33](#)). They should pray for God's enduring grace ([Psalm 19:13](#)). They should let the word of God guide them ([Psalm 119:9](#); [Colossians 3:16](#); [2 Timothy 3:16](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 18:20-21](#); [Exodus 34:7](#); [Leviticus 26:14-46](#); [Numbers 15:30-31](#); [Deuteronomy 31:16-18](#); [1 Kings 8:46-51](#); [2 Kings 8:18, 27](#); [2 Kings 13:1-7](#); [14:23-24](#); [17:13-23](#); [18:9-12](#); [21:8-16](#); [23:25-27](#); [24:1-3](#), [19-25:21](#); [2 Chronicles 7:14](#); [33:12-13](#); [Psalm 119:9-11, 33-37](#); [Jeremiah 44:2-6](#); [Micah 6:8](#); [Matthew 6:33](#); [Colossians 3:16](#); [2 Timothy 3:16](#); [4:7](#); [Revelation 2:10](#)

## The Day Is Coming

Jesus prophesied three future events in the Synoptic Gospels:

1. One event was his own death and resurrection ([Mark 8:31](#); [9:31](#); [10:33-34](#)). This had already happened before the Gospels were written.
2. The second event Jesus prophesied was the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 ([Matthew 24:1-28](#); [13:1-23](#); [Luke 19:41-44](#); [21:5-24](#)). This event was probably about to happen when Mark wrote his Gospel (see Mark Book Introduction, "Date"). Yet, this event would not mark the absolute end. So the Christian community must continue to live faithfully and be spiritually watching for the return of the Son of God in glory, which could be soon ([Mark 13:34-37](#)).
3. The third event Jesus prophesied was his own future return ([Matthew 23:39](#); [24:3, 29-31, 24:36-25:46](#); [Mark 8:38](#); [13:24-27, 32-37](#); [Luke 21:25-36](#); [John 14:1-3](#)). The New Testament frequently mentions Jesus' second coming (see, for example, [1 Corinthians 1:7-8](#); [3:13](#); [5:5](#); [2 Corinthians 1:14](#); [Philippians 1:6, 10](#); [2:16](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:1-11](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:2](#); [2 Timothy 1:12, 18](#); [4:1, 8](#)).

When Jesus returns, God's kingdom promises will come true. Jesus will judge and destroy Satan and his angels ([Romans 16:20](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:3-12](#)). Those who refuse to trust in Jesus will experience eternal judgment ([Matthew 13:40-42](#); [25:31-46](#); [Luke 6:24-26](#); [16:19-31](#); [Acts 10:42](#); [Ephesians 5:6](#); [Colossians 3:6](#); [Hebrews 10:25](#); [2 Peter 3:7](#); [Jude 1:6](#); [Revelation 1:7](#); [6:14, 17](#)). Meanwhile, the faithful will resurrect to enjoy eternal life ([1 Thessalonians 4:13-18](#)). God will gather his chosen people for salvation ([Mark 13:27](#); [Hebrews 1:14](#); [9:27-28](#)), grace ([1 Peter 1:13](#)), and glory ([1 Thessalonians 2:12](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:14](#); [1 Peter 1:7](#); [5:1, 4](#)).

He will give his people an endless inheritance and new eternal bodies ([1 Peter 1:4](#); [1 Corinthians 15:35-57](#); [Philippians 3:21](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:13-18](#)). God will free all of creation from its curse and transform it ([Genesis 3:17-18](#); [Romans 8:20-23](#); [2 Peter 3:12-13](#); [Revelation 21:1-22:5](#)). Sorrow, tears, mourning, and death will no longer exist ([Revelation 21:4](#)). Those who were faithful to Christ in this life "will see God" ([Matthew 5:8](#); [Revelation 22:3](#)).

Because of these promises, Christians must pray and wait for his return ([Matthew 6:10](#); [Revelation 22:20](#)). We must not try to guess the dates of his coming ([Mark 13:32](#); [Acts 1:7](#)). Instead, we must live honorably and stay prepared ([1 John 2:28](#); [Matthew 24:36-25:30](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:1-11](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 5:8](#); [6:10](#); [13:41-42](#); [23:39](#); [24:3-25:46](#); [Mark 8:38](#); [13:1-37](#); [14:25](#); [Luke 6:24-26](#); [16:19-31](#); [19:41-44](#); [21:5-36](#); [John 14:1-3](#); [Acts 1:6-7](#); [10:42](#); [Romans 8:20-23](#); [16:20](#); [1 Corinthians 1:7-8](#); [15:35-58](#); [2 Corinthians 1:14](#); [Philippians 1:6](#); [10](#); [2:16](#); [3:21](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:13-18](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:2-14](#); [2 Timothy 4:1-8](#); [Titus 2:11-13](#); [Hebrews 9:28](#); [10:25](#); [37](#); [1 Peter 1:7](#); [13](#); [5:1-4](#); [2 Peter 3:7-13](#); [1 John 2:28](#); [Revelation 1:7](#); [6:15-17](#); [21:1-22:7](#); [22:12](#), [20](#)

## The Day of the Lord

The phrase *Day of the Lord* describes a time when God judges his enemies with righteous punishment. The ungodly receive the punishment they deserve, while the righteous gain their complete salvation (see [Isaiah 3:16-4:6](#)). On this day, God shows his powerful control over creation. When God appears in glory, people feel fear ([2:10](#), [19](#), [21](#)). This is because he examines all human support systems. This includes religious, economic, military, and social structures.

This phrase first appears in the prophecy of Amos ([Amos 5:18](#)). But it did not start with him. Amos corrected a common misunderstanding among the Israelites. They thought the day of the Lord would be a joyful day of salvation. They believed God would judge Israel's enemies and restore Israelite rule over greater Canaan.

Yet, Amos warned that the day of the Lord would bring darkness, not light. This was because the people were rebelling against God (see [Amos 5:10-12](#), [21-27](#)). The Israelites were confident that God

was always on their side. But their sins made them God's enemies, deserving full punishment.

The prophets often used the phrase "that day" to describe an important event (see [Isaiah 2:11](#); [27:1](#); [Zephaniah 1:8](#)). Because of God's warnings and the people's sins, the prophets saw "that day" as near (see [Joel 1:15](#); [2:1](#)). They hoped their warnings would cause God's people to repent (see [Zephaniah 2:1-3](#)). Unfortunately, most people ignored these warnings.

The day of the Lord arrived for the northern kingdom when Assyria destroyed Samaria. It came for the southern kingdom when Babylon invaded and destroyed Jerusalem between 605 and 586 BC.

The day of the Lord is disastrous for ungodly people. The prophet Joel compares its destruction to a locust plague ([Joel 1:1-2:11](#)). Yet, this day guarantees God's people that he is sovereign and just. It is a day of salvation for those who obey the prophets and "everyone who calls on the name of the LORD" (see [Joel 2:31-32](#)).

The same God who brings destruction to his enemies will be a refuge and stronghold for his people ([Joel 3:16](#)). Nations used by God to judge Israel and Judah will later experience their own "day of the Lord" (see, for example, [Isaiah 13:4-22](#); [Ezekiel 30:1-5](#); [Obadiah 1:15-16](#)).

The Old Testament prophets mostly regarded judgment as happening during the exile of the Israelites to Babylon. New Testament writers use the phrase *Day of the Lord* to describe Jesus' return as the judge of the world. That day "will come like a thief" ([2 Peter 3:10](#); see also [1 Thessalonians 5:2-4](#)). Therefore, God's people must be ready, or they will experience an end similar to those who ignored the prophets' warnings.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 2:10-22](#); [4:1-6](#); [13:4-12](#); [Ezekiel 30:1-5](#); [Joel 1:13-15](#); [2:1-11](#), [28-32](#); [3:9-16](#); [Amos 5:18-24](#); [Obadiah 1:15-16](#); [Zephaniah 1:2-18](#); [Malachi 4:1-5](#); [1 Corinthians 1:8](#); [5:5](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:2](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:2](#); [2 Timothy 1:18](#); [2 Peter 3:10](#); [Revelation 20:1-15](#)

## The Exodus as History

Israel's view of reality was very different from other ancient cultures. Other major cultures around Israel, from Sumer in southern Mesopotamia in 2000 BC to Rome in AD 200,

developed their perspectives by observing creation. They believed in many gods and thought events happened in endless cycles. In contrast, ancient Israel believed in one God, separate from the world. He created the world with a purpose and guides events to fulfill that purpose.

How did the Israelites develop this unique view? Was it through encounters with the true God in historical events? The most reasonable explanation for Israel's distinct understanding is that, as the Bible describes, God revealed himself to them through events recorded as history.

Egyptian texts do not mention the events described in the Bible, which makes some people doubt. Yet, it was uncommon for a powerful nation to record their defeat by slaves. The Bible's historical accounts, including stories of Israel's own failures, are unique in the ancient Near East.

Archaeology cannot prove specific events happened. But it can show that conditions allowed them to occur. This is true for the book of Exodus and the Bible in general. Egyptian records and archaeology do not confirm or contradict the Bible's account. Yet, the text of Exodus shows a deep understanding of Egyptian thought and culture, similar to a historical record.

The Bible's writers believed they were describing real events. They expected readers to regard them that way. [Exodus 18:8-12](#) shows the first example of someone who trusted God because of a true story.

Faith in God and in the Bible has a strong historical foundation. God has acted in history to save humanity. His actions include Israel's escape from Egypt. These actions achieve their goal in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 14:15-15:21](#); [18:8-12](#); [Judges 11:12-27](#); [Acts 7:1-56](#)

## The Family Redeemer

The idea of the family redeemer was established in the law of Moses. The story of Ruth shows us an example of this idea. In that book, this term has a specific legal meaning. In other places, the Hebrew term *go'el* translates as "next of kin" ([Numbers 27:11](#); [35:19, 24](#)).

According to the Moses' law, family redeemers had three main duties in Israel:

1. [Leviticus 25:23-34](#) explains that if an Israelite became very poor and had to sell his land, a family member should pay off the debt to keep the land in the family. If no relative could buy the land and the seller could not buy it back, the land would still return to the seller or his heirs in the Jubilee year (fiftieth). Two examples of family redeemers buying land for their relatives are Boaz and Jeremiah ([Ruth 4:1-12](#); [Jeremiah 32:6-15](#)).
2. Similarly, if an Israelite became very poor and had to sell himself into debt-slavery, a family redeemer had an obligation to release him from service to a non-relative ([Leviticus 25:35-55](#)). The poor Israelite would repay his debt by working for his relative. He would probably treat him better than a stranger would.
3. The family redeemer was responsible for seeking justice if someone killed an Israelite, as described in [Numbers 35:9-34](#).

The idea of the family redeemer shows us that God owns everything. He tells us to love our neighbors as ourselves ([Leviticus 19:18](#); [Matthew 22:39-40](#)). The New Testament describes Jesus as the perfect family redeemer. He frees us from the slavery of sin and death, which we chose for ourselves ([Matthew 20:28](#); [Romans 3:24-25](#); [Ephesians 1:7](#); [Titus 2:14](#); [Revelation 5:9](#); compare [Exodus 6:6](#); [15:13](#); [Psalm 130:8](#); [Isaiah 44:22](#); [59:20](#); [63:9](#); [Jeremiah 31:11](#)).

Like the Old Testament family redeemer, such as Boaz, and following our great redeemer's example, we must show love and kindness to others ([Leviticus 19:11-18](#); [Matthew 5:43-48](#); [19:19](#); [22:37-40](#); [Romans 13:8-10](#); [Galatians 5:14](#); [James 2:8-9](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 25:23-55](#); [Numbers 35:9-34](#); [Ruth 2:20](#); [3:9](#), [12](#); [4:1-10](#); [Isaiah 59:20](#); [Jeremiah 32:6-15](#); [Matthew 20:28](#); [Romans 3:24-25](#); [Ephesians 1:7](#); [Titus 2:14](#); [Revelation 5:9](#)

## The Gift of Prophecy

As the apostle Peter stated on the day of Pentecost, prophecy was a result of God's Holy Spirit poured out ([Acts 2:17-21](#); see [Joel 2:28-32](#)). The book of Acts mentions a few Christian prophets ([Acts 11:27-28](#); [13:1](#); [15:32](#); [21:9-11](#); see also *The Martyrdom of Polycarp* 12:3; 16:2). One of these prophets was Agabus, who acted like an Old Testament prophet by performing symbolic acts ([Acts 21:10-11](#); see [1 Kings 11:29-32](#); [Isaiah 20:2-6](#); [Jeremiah 13:1-11](#); [Ezekiel 4:1-5:17](#)). He also prophesied future events ([Acts 11:28](#); [21:10-11](#)).

Philip the Evangelist had four daughters "who prophesied" ([Acts 21:9](#)). The apostle Paul also recognized that some Christian women had this prophetic gift ([1 Corinthians 11:5](#)). In the Old Testament, most prophets were men, but some women were also prophets, like Miriam, Deborah, and Huldah ([Exodus 15:20](#); [Judges 4:4](#); [2 Kings 22:14-20](#); [2 Chronicles 34:22-28](#)). In the New Testament, both men and women, young and old, receive the gift of prophecy, as Peter mentioned in his sermon on the day of Pentecost ([Acts 2:17-18](#)).

Prophecy sometimes involves predicting the future ([Acts 20:22-23](#); [21:10-11](#); see [Romans 9:24-33](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:13-17](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:3-4](#)). At its core, prophecy is about sharing God's message by preaching, urging, and explaining God's will ([Acts 15:32](#); [19:6](#); [Romans 12:6](#); [1 Corinthians 14:3-4](#), [29-33](#); [Revelation 19:10](#)). The gift of prophecy is plainly mentioned in the letters of 1 Corinthians and Ephesians as one of the gifts of the Holy Spirit and Jesus to his church ([1 Corinthians 12:4-11](#); [Ephesians 4:11-13](#)). It is intended to benefit Christians ([1 Corinthians 14:22](#)).

Prophecy needs testing ([1 Thessalonians 5:19-21](#)). The church receives strong warnings about false prophets ([1 John 4:1](#); see also [Revelation 2:20-23](#)). Christians must use this gift faithfully and as the Scriptures and God's Spirit instruct. Boldly sharing God's truth helps the church understand God's will and motivates people to obey it.

### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 15:20](#); [Deuteronomy 13:1-5](#); [Judges 4:4](#); [1 Kings 11:29-32](#); [2 Kings 22:14-20](#); [Isaiah 20:2-6](#); [44:25](#); [Jeremiah 13:1-11](#); [23:25-32](#); [Ezekiel 4:1-17](#); [13:2-9](#); [Joel 2:28-32](#); [Matthew 7:15](#); [24:24](#); [Acts 2:17-21](#); [11:27-28](#); [13:1](#); [15:32](#); [19:6](#); [20:23](#); [Acts 21:9-11](#); [Romans 12:6](#); [1 Corinthians 11:5](#); [12:4-11](#); [14:1-40](#); [Ephesians 4:11-13](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:19-21](#); [2 Peter 2:1](#); [1 John 4:1-3](#); [Revelation 2:20-23](#); [19:10](#)

## The Glory of God

*Glory* in the Old Testament means something different than in English. In English, it often describes something temporary, like a sunset or last year's winning team.

The Hebrew word for *glory* means what is "heavy" or "solid." It implies "importance" or "worth." This is the opposite of "temporary" or "empty." When God's glory appears, it is not just a bright light or a shining cloud. It is a visible sign of his absolute reality.

God's glory shows his presence, power, and majesty (see [Ezekiel 1:28](#); [10:4](#)). God's glory may appear in nature, like during a thunderstorm or in the plagues on the Egyptians ([Job 37:2-5](#); [Psalm 29:3](#), [7](#); [Numbers 14:21-22](#)). God's glory can also be a special event, like the revelation on Mount Sinai ([Deuteronomy 5:24](#)). When God established the tabernacle and King Solomon's temple, God's glory filled them ([Exodus 40:34-35](#); [1 Kings 8:10-11](#)). This showed his approval and presence there. Similarly, the glory of the Lord sent the fire that started the first sacrifices in the holy place ([Leviticus 9:22-24](#)).

When God shows his glory to his creation, it is often called a *theophany* (see, for example, [Exodus 24:16-18](#)). God provides limited views of his glory because he says, "no one can see Me and live" ([Exodus 33:18-23](#); see also [Isaiah 6:5](#)). To "give glory" to God means to speak or act in a way that acknowledges who God is ([Joshua 7:19](#); [Isaiah 24:15](#); [Jeremiah 13:16](#)).

Jesus Christ reflects God's glory and image ([2 Corinthians 4:4](#)). Through his death and resurrection, God glorified him ([John 17:1-5](#)). When Jesus returns, he will show God's glory in his restored kingdom ([Revelation 21:11](#), [23](#)). The apostle Paul says that Christ's presence in Christians' lives guarantees us that we will share in that glory ([Romans 5:2](#); [Colossians 1:27](#)).

### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 14:17-18](#); [16:6-12](#); [33:17-23](#); [40:34-38](#); [Leviticus 9:23-24](#); [10:1-3](#); [Numbers 14:21-22](#); [Deuteronomy 5:24](#); [Joshua 7:19](#); [1 Kings 8:11](#); [2 Chronicles 7:1-3](#); [Job 37:2-5](#); [Psalms 3:3](#); [8:4-6](#); [19:1](#); [29:3](#), [7-9](#); [48:8](#); [Isaiah 6:3-5](#); [42:8](#); [43:7](#); [66:18-19](#); [Jeremiah 13:16](#); [Ezekiel 1:28](#); [10:4](#); [Hosea 4:7](#); [John 17:1-5](#); [Romans 5:2](#); [2 Corinthians 4:4](#); [Colossians 1:27](#); [Revelation 21:10-11](#), [23-25](#)

## The Good News Message

The apostles shared the good news about Jesus (or "gospel") in a specific order, with these parts:

1. The Old Testament promises came true through Jesus Christ's life, death, and resurrection.
2. God has lifted up Jesus by raising him from the dead to be the leader of the new people of God as the Messiah chosen by God.
3. The apostles witnessed God's work in Jesus Christ. They saw his public ministry and resurrection ([Acts 2:32; 3:15; 4:33; 5:30-32; 13:30-31](#)). They served as his chosen messengers ([10:39-43](#)).
4. The right response to this good news is to repent (turn away from sin) and trust in Jesus ([Acts 2:38; 3:19; 13:39, 48; 17:30; 20:21; 26:20](#)).
5. God promises to give the Holy Spirit to those who accept God's forgiveness and salvation from sin through Jesus Christ.

The apostles often shared this basic message with both Jews and non-Jews (called gentiles) across the Mediterranean region (see [Acts 1:8; 9:15](#)). You can find it in the speeches of Peter and Philip in [2:14-41; 3:12-26; 4:8-12; 5:29-32; 8:4-13, 26-40](#); and [10:34-43](#). Paul's preaching also includes these themes (for example, [Acts 13:16-49; 1 Corinthians 15:1-11](#)).

This powerful message of God's saving grace changes people's wills and minds to obey him. Receiving this message is the first step towards salvation. God calls everyone to repent from sin and trust in the saving power of Jesus ([Acts 4:12; 13:38; 16:30-31](#)). Through Jesus, God continues to make everyone right with him who continues to trust in him ([13:39](#)).

### Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 4:23-24; 24:14; Mark 1:1, 14-15; Luke 4:18-21; Acts 2:14-40; 3:12-26; 8:25-40; Acts 10:34-43; 13:16-41; 16:31; 17:16-31; 20:21; Romans 1:1-5, 15-17; 10:15-17; 16:25-27; 1 Corinthians 1:18; 15:3-8; 2 Corinthians 4:3-7;](#)

[Ephesians 1:13; 2:4-18; 2 Thessalonians 2:13-14; 2 Timothy 1:9-10; 2:8-13; Hebrews 4:1-16; 1 Peter 1:3-12; Revelation 14:6-7](#)

## The Grace of God

*Grace* is an important word in the Bible. It shows God's kindness and favor. It is often related to how he saves those who do not deserve it. The New Testament emphasizes that grace came through Jesus Christ ([John 1:14-17](#)). This does not mean God's grace was absent in the Old Testament. Instead, God's grace toward humanity achieved its goal through his Son.

According to the book of Acts, the Jewish community was the first to experience God's great favor (see [Acts 11:19-21; 13:43-49](#)). Later, it became obvious that God's grace through Jesus Christ also extends to non-Jewish people (gentiles) ([Acts 15:8-9; Ephesians 2:11-18; Titus 2:11](#)). Miraculous signs and wonders confirmed God's grace at work among the gentiles ([Acts 14:3](#)).

The apostle Paul shared the good news (the gospel) about God's wonderful grace ([Acts 20:24](#)). He did not try to prove God's grace. He assumed it as true when sharing the good news (see, for example, [Romans 3:24; 5:15-21](#)). Paul made it plain that we do not earn our salvation.

God acts only through his grace ([Romans 4:4-5; Ephesians 2:4-9](#)). People cannot do good works to earn us favor with God. If they did, God would have to reward them like a worker earns a wage (see [Romans 11:5-6](#)).

God's grace affects Christians throughout their lives, not just at conversion. The letter of 2 Peter ends with a command for Christians to "grow in the grace" of "Jesus Christ" ([2 Peter 3:18](#)). Paul "urged them to continue in the grace of God" as they remained faithful to their Lord ([Acts 13:43](#)).

When Paul left the leaders of the church at Ephesus, he entrusted them "to God and to the word of His grace." This was a divine message that could strengthen and support them ([Acts 20:32](#); see [15:40](#)). God's grace is central to the Christian message and experience, from start to finish. It is no surprise that grace is a common theme in the writings of Jesus' early followers.

### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 34:5-7; Numbers 6:22-27; Ezra 9:8; Psalms 30:5; 31:16; Psalm 84:11; Isaiah 60:10;](#)

[61:1-3](#); [Hosea 14:1-9](#); [Luke 4:18-19](#); [Acts 15:11](#); [20:24](#); [Romans 5:15-17](#), [20-21](#); [12:6](#); [2 Corinthians 6:1](#); [8:9](#); [12:9](#); [Galatians 2:21](#); [4:10](#); [5:3-6](#); [Ephesians 1:3-8](#); [2:4-10](#); [2 Timothy 1:9](#); [2:1](#); [Titus 2:11](#); [3:7](#); [Hebrews 2:9](#); [4:16](#); [13:9](#); [James 4:6](#); [1 Peter 5:5-6](#), [12](#); [2 Peter 3:17-18](#)

## The Growth of the Church

The book of Acts describes the church's growth after the day of Pentecost. Initially, the church increased in numbers. After Jesus' ascension to heaven, only 120 Christians attended the first prayer meeting to seek divine guidance ([Acts 1:12-15](#)). After the Holy Spirit's powerful arrival on Pentecost, the number of Christians increased to about 3,000 ([2:41](#)). Many more accepted Peter and John's preaching of the good news about Jesus (the gospel), increasing the number to about 5,000 ([4:4](#)). The church continued to increase ([5:14](#); [6:1](#); [9:31](#); [21:20](#)).

There is also plain evidence of geographical spread (see [Acts 1:8](#); [9:15](#)). The church was not only in Jerusalem. The gospel message spread to Lydda, Sharon, and Joppa on the Mediterranean coast ([9:32-43](#)). The message of salvation in Christ also expanded from its Jewish base into Samaria ([8:4-12](#)).

Then it spread into Phoenicia, Cyprus, and Antioch ([11:19-26](#)). As Peter declared to the household of the Roman centurion Cornelius, "God does not show favoritism" ([10:34](#)). The message of "the gospel of peace through Jesus Christ" is for everyone ([10:36](#)).

As the Christian faith increased in numbers and spread geographically, Christian communities also experienced deeper spiritual growth. [Acts 2:42-47](#) shows this development in the church's inner life. It emphasizes united prayer during crises, generous sharing, courage in persecution, and bold witnessing ([4:23-31](#), [32-37](#); [5:27-33](#), [40-42](#); [16:19-25](#)). The preaching of the deacon and evangelist Philip, the deacon Stephen's manner of dying, and the behavior of the apostles Paul and Silas in prison showed great spiritual maturity ([7:59-60](#); [8:4-40](#); [16:19-25](#)).

Church leaders encouraged Christians, strengthened their faith, and helped them endure persecution ([14:22](#); [15:32](#), [41](#); [18:23](#); see [2 Timothy 1:8](#); [2:1-9](#); [3:12](#)). They lived by the standards they set for others ([1 Corinthians 4:16](#),

[20](#); [Philippians 4:9](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:5-8](#); [2 Thessalonians 3:9](#)). The church's careful inclusion of non-Jewish people (gentiles) caused important spiritual and numerical growth. "So the churches were strengthened in the faith and grew daily in numbers" ([Acts 16:5](#)).

### Passages for Further Study

[Acts 1:8](#), [13-15](#); [2:41-47](#); [4:4](#), [23-37](#); [5:14](#), [27-33](#), [40-42](#); [6:1](#); [7:59](#); [8:4-40](#); [9:15](#), [31](#), [35](#), [42](#); [10:34](#), [36](#); [11:19-26](#); [14:22](#); [15:32](#), [41](#); [16:5](#), [19-25](#); [18:23](#); [21:20](#); [1 Corinthians 4:16](#), [20](#); [Philippians 4:9](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:5-8](#); [2 Thessalonians 3:9](#); [2 Timothy 1:8](#); [2:1-9](#); [3:12](#)

## The Heart in the Psalms

The Hebrew words *leb* and *lebab* both mean "heart." But these words are difficult to translate. They rarely refer to the physical human heart. Instead, these terms usually refer to the center of a person's being. They represent a person's thoughts, reflections, will, and motives. The story of someone's heart shows their commitment and the direction of their life.

The psalms speak a lot about the heart. The hearts of evil people are clever and full of schemes ([Psalm 58:2](#); [64:6](#); [140:2](#)). They are deceptive, hypocritical, greedy, jealous, and lack honesty ([10:3](#); [28:3](#); [41:6](#); [55:21](#); [62:4](#); [141:4](#)). Over time, they become more arrogant, careless, and stubborn ([14:1](#); [17:10](#); [73:7](#); [78:8](#); [81:12](#); [95:8](#), [10](#); [101:5](#); [119:70](#)). Evil people are only loyal to themselves ([78:37](#)). Their harmful way of life leads to their own destruction ([5:9](#)).

Meanwhile, the writers of the psalms openly express their sorrow, trouble, suffering, and desperation ([13:2](#); [22:14](#); [25:17](#); [38:8](#), [10](#); [40:12](#); [55:4](#); [61:2](#); [69:20](#); [73:21](#), [26](#); [109:22](#); [143:4](#); [147:3](#)). Through their pain, their hearts grow. Their character becomes stronger, and their relationship with God deepens because of these painful experiences. They pray intensely ([62:8](#); [119:145](#)). They desire God ([84:2](#)). They trust in him ([28:7](#)). They invite God to examine their hearts or motives ([7:9](#); [17:3](#); [26:2](#); [139:1-6](#), [23](#)). Their commitment remains steady, and they have "a pure heart" ([24:4](#); [51:10](#); [73:1](#), [13](#)). They are content, even when humbled ([131:1](#)).

As God heals their broken hearts (their deep emotional pain, sorrow, or distress), they become strong and confident ([34:17-18](#); [51:17](#); [27:3](#), [14](#); [31:24](#); [57:7](#); [108:1](#); [112:7-8](#); [138:3](#)). They are full

of life ([22:26](#); [69:32](#)). In the end, God satisfies them and fulfills what their hearts desire ([20:4](#); [21:2](#); [37:4](#)). This brings joy and praise to godly people ([4:7](#); [9:1](#); [13:5](#); [16:7](#); [9](#); [19:8](#); [30:11-12](#); [33:21](#); [86:12](#); [89:50](#); [102:4](#); [105:3](#); [111:1](#); [119:7](#); [111](#); [138:1](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 7:9](#); [9:1](#); [13:2](#); [14:1](#); [16:7-9](#); [17:3](#); [19:8](#); [20:4](#); [21:2](#); [22:14](#); [26](#); [24:4](#); [26:2](#); [27:3](#); [14](#); [28:3](#); [7](#); [33:21](#); [34:17-18](#); [37:4](#); [38:8](#); [10](#); [51:10](#); [17](#); [55:4](#); [21](#); [57:7](#); [58:2](#); [61:2](#); [62:4](#); [8-10](#); [64:6](#); [69:20](#); [73:1](#); [7](#); [13](#); [21](#); [26](#); [78:8](#); [37](#); [81:12](#); [84:2](#); [86:12](#); [89:50](#); [95:8](#); [10](#); [102:4](#); [108:1](#); [109:22](#); [111:1](#); [119:70](#); [111](#); [145](#); [131:1](#); [138:1](#); [139:1-24](#); [140:2](#); [147:3](#)

## The Holiness of God's People

God called the people of Israel "to be holy" because he freed them from slavery in Egypt (see [Leviticus 11:45](#)). He also freed humanity through Jesus Christ, who paid the price to release us from slavery to sin and death ([1 Peter 1:18](#)). God paid the ultimate price to set humanity free, redeeming us "with the precious blood of Christ, a lamb without blemish or spot" ([1:19](#)). Through this sacrifice, God has purchased our freedom from the empty way of life that people experience before coming to Christ.

Holiness was at the center of the lifestyle that God required from his people under the old covenant (the agreement God made with Israel through Moses at Mount Sinai). God commanded them to "Be holy because I, the LORD your God, am holy" (see [Leviticus 19:2](#)). God had rescued his people from the control of a cruel, foreign nation that worshiped other gods. Now they were to live as God's people in the new land where he was bringing them.

The apostle Peter applies this same requirement to God's people of the new covenant (the agreement God made through Jesus Christ). This includes all who have come to God through faith in Jesus Christ. Peter writes, "just as He who called you is holy, so be holy in all you do," ([1 Peter 1:15](#)). This holiness has both a negative and a positive side.

Negatively, to be holy means to separate *from* this world. This means avoiding the ways of thinking and acting that are common among people who do not know God. We turn away from our old sinful lifestyle that we lived before becoming Christians. Because of their new identity in Christ, believers

live as foreigners in this world ([1 Peter 1:17](#)). Their values are shaped by God's kingdom rather than earthly culture.

Positively, to be holy also means to be separate *for* God. This means we try to be like our Father in heaven and live according to the values of our new homeland, the kingdom of God.

Believers in Christ have been set free from the old, meaningless life and its values. We are to live as obedient children of our heavenly Father ([1 Peter 1:14](#)). Our Father has not only saved us because he loves us, but he also disciplines his children, just like a human father would. He will judge "each one's work impartially" ([1:17](#)).

Therefore, we must live before God "in reverent fear" ([1:17](#)). We must acknowledge his holiness and majesty and strive by faith to reflect his holy character in our lives. Holiness is an essential part of the Christian life. While we are justified by faith, true faith naturally expresses itself in a life that reflects God's holiness (see [James 2:14-26](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 10:3](#); [11:44-45](#); [19:2](#); [Isaiah 29:17-24](#); [1 Corinthians 6:9-20](#); [Hebrews 12:1-13](#); [1 Peter 1:15-18](#); [Revelation 21:5-8](#); [22:14-15](#)

## The Holy One of Israel

The phrase *The Holy One of Israel* appears in the prophecy of Isaiah about 24 times. The Holy One is "the King" ([Isaiah 6:5](#)). The righteous and just one is the God without equal ([26:7](#); [40:25](#)). He is the redeemer of his people ([41:14](#)).

Anyone approaching the Holy One must worship him with reverence and awe. The Holy One associates himself with Mount Zion. It is holy because it is his symbolic home (see [18:7](#); [24:23](#); [27:13](#); [56:7](#); [60:1-22](#)).

The Holy One of Israel is different from all creation because he is morally perfect creator. Sinful people cannot live with him (see [Isaiah 1:4](#)). God's holiness requires ceremonial purity and moral perfection. God is like a consuming fire that removes anything not connected to his holy will (see [33:14](#)).

Yet the Holy One of Israel reserves a small group of people for himself ([Isaiah 4:2-3](#); [6:13](#)). He spiritually cleanses them and promises to be with his own redeemed people ([12:6](#); [35:8-9](#); [62:12](#); see also [49:7](#)). He shows his holy power by helping

sinful and weak humans. He saves them from the exile caused by their sin, and opening the new creation for them.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 71:22-23](#); [78:41](#); [Proverbs 9:10](#); [Isaiah 6:1-5](#); [10:17](#), [20](#); [17:7](#); [29:17-24](#); [30:15](#); [41:14](#), [17-20](#); [43:1-4](#), [10-21](#); [48:17-18](#); [54:4-5](#); [55:5](#); [57:15](#); [Jeremiah 50:29](#); [51:5](#); [Ezekiel 39:7-8](#); [Hosea 11:8-9](#); [Habakkuk 3:3-6](#); [John 6:66-69](#); [Acts 2:27](#); [13:35](#); [Revelation 16:5-7](#)

## The Holy Spirit's Presence

The book of Acts emphasizes the presence and power of the Holy Spirit. Before the Spirit came, Jesus spoke about the Spirit's influence on his followers ([1:8](#); see [John 14:15-17](#), [26](#); [15:26](#); [16:7-15](#)). The Spirit clearly guided the early church in selecting Spirit-filled leaders to care for the needs of the Hellenistic widows ([Acts 6:1-7](#)). These were Greek-speaking Jewish widows who needed help in the daily distribution of food. The Holy Spirit chose the apostles Barnabas and Saul for missionary work ([13:1-5](#)). When the first church council met to discuss the membership of non-Jewish people (gentiles), they followed the Spirit's direction ([15:28](#)).

The Holy Spirit filled Christian workers Stephen and Philip to preach with the Spirit's power ([Acts 6:1-8:40](#)). The Spirit energized the apostle Paul's ministry from the start ([9:17](#)). In the book of Acts, the church increased and expanded under the Holy Spirit's guidance and power (for example, [2:4](#), [41-47](#); [4:31](#); [5:32](#); [8:15](#), [17](#), [29](#); [9:31](#)). Because of the Spirit's important role in Acts, people often call it "the Acts of the Holy Spirit."

The Holy Spirit acts in many ways:

- The Holy Spirit gives and restores life ([Genesis 2:7](#); [Psalm 104:24-30](#); [Ezekiel 37:1-14](#); [Joel 2:28-32](#); [Romans 8:9-11](#)).
- The Holy Spirit calls and chooses workers for Christ's service ([Acts 13:2](#); [20:28](#)).
- The Holy Spirit directs God's servants where and when he wants them to act ([Acts 8:29](#); [9:15](#); [10:19-20](#); [11:12](#); [16:6](#); [1 Corinthians 2:13](#); [1 Peter 1:12](#)).
- The Holy Spirit inspired the writing of Scripture ([2 Timothy 3:16-17](#); [2 Peter 1:20-21](#)).
- The Holy Spirit teaches the church Christ's message ([John 14:26](#); [1 Corinthians 12:3](#)).
- The Holy Spirit shows the power of the good news about Jesus (the gospel) through miraculous signs and wonders ([Acts 14:3](#); [Hebrews 2:4](#)).
- The Holy Spirit teaches God's people the truths of Scripture ([Acts 1:16](#); [Hebrews 9:8](#); [10:15-17](#); [1 Peter 1:11-12](#)).
- The Holy Spirit testifies about Jesus and brings him glory ([John 15:26](#); [16:13-14](#)).
- The Holy Spirit makes people aware of their sins and their need for the good news ([John 16:8](#)).
- The Holy Spirit warns them against becoming stubborn ([Hebrews 3:7-11](#), [15](#)).
- The Holy Spirit gives gifts to God's people ([1 Corinthians 12:4-11](#)).
- The Holy Spirit empowers them to share the good news, serve the Lord, and work for God's kingdom.

#### Passages for Further Study

[John 14:15-17](#), [26](#); [15:26](#); [16:7-15](#); [Acts 1:8](#), [16:2-4](#), [41-47](#); [4:31](#); [5:32](#); [6:1-7](#); [8:15](#), [17](#), [29](#); [9:15](#), [17, 31](#); [10:19-20](#); [11:12](#); [13:1-5](#); [14:3](#); [15:28](#); [16:6](#); [20:28](#); [1 Corinthians 2:13](#); [12:1-11](#); [Ephesians](#)

[1:13-14](#); [2 Timothy 3:16-17](#); [Hebrews 2:4](#); [3:7-11](#), [15](#); [9:8](#); [10:15-17](#); [1 Peter 1:11-12](#); [2 Peter 1:20-21](#)

## The Holy Spirit's Work

Different New Testament writers emphasized various aspects of the Holy Spirit's work. The apostle John, for example, emphasized the Spirit's role as a teacher and revealer of God's thoughts and ways ([John 14:17](#), [26](#); [15:26](#); [16:13-15](#); [1 John 2:20](#), [27](#)). The apostle Luke focused on the Spirit's guidance and power for spreading the Christian message ([Acts 1:8](#); [4:8-12](#), [31](#); [8:29-40](#); [13:9-12](#)). Meanwhile, the apostle Paul provided a broad perspective of the Spirit's work.

Paul teaches that God gives the Holy Spirit to everyone enters a saving relationship with Jesus Christ ([1 Corinthians 6:19](#); [Galatians 3:2-5](#); [Ephesians 1:13-14](#)). The Spirit brings new life in Christ and confirms the salvation of Christians and their identity as God's children ([1 Corinthians 6:11](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:13](#); [Romans 8:9](#), [14-17](#)).

The Holy Spirit gives Christians:

- power over sin ([Romans 8:1-4](#));
- power to live the Christian virtues ([Galatians 5:22-23](#)); and
- power to serve in Christian ministry ([1 Corinthians 12:1-31](#)).

Christians must "be filled with the Holy Spirit" ([Ephesians 5:18](#)). They may encounter a struggle between their human desires and the Spirit. But, they can please God by obeying the Spirit's guidance and strength ([Galatians 5:16-18](#)).

The Holy Spirit helps Christians understand God's thoughts and ways ([1 Corinthians 2:9-16](#)). He provides spiritual gifts to Christians to support the church's overall health ([12:1-31](#)). The Spirit guides and strengthens worship as Christians use the gifts given by him ([14:26-33](#), [39-40](#)).

The Holy Spirit guarantees that Christians will receive all the blessings God has promised ([2 Corinthians 1:21-22](#); [5:1-5](#); [Ephesians 1:13-14](#)). The Spirit supports Christians and prays for them when they are weak ([Romans 8:26-27](#)). The Spirit's goal is to make Christians "conformed to the image of" God's Son ([Romans 8:28-29](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[John 14:15-17](#), [26](#); [15:26](#); [16:7-15](#); [Acts 1:8](#); [2:4](#); [5:32](#); [6:1-7](#); [8:29](#), [39](#); [9:31](#); [13:1-5](#); [14:3](#); [15:28](#); [16:6](#); [20:28](#); [Romans 8:1-4](#), [9](#), [14-17](#), [26-29](#); [1 Corinthians 2:9-16](#); [6:11](#), [19](#); [12:1-31](#); [14:1-33](#), [39-40](#); [2 Corinthians 1:22](#); [5:5](#); [Galatians 3:5](#); [5:16-18](#), [22-23](#); [Ephesians 1:13-14](#); [5:18](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:13](#); [2 Timothy 3:16-17](#); [Hebrews 2:4](#); [3:7-11](#), [15](#); [9:8](#); [10:15-17](#); [1 Peter 1:11-12](#); [2 Peter 1:20-21](#); [1 John 2:20](#), [27](#)

## The Household

The household was the basic family unit of Greco-Roman society. People believed that if households were stable, the state would also be stable. In these households, everyone had clear roles and responsibilities that were deeply embedded in their culture. The main goal was to keep the "natural" order of authority and obedience. Breaking this order would lead to dishonor and corruption.

In this system, the husband-father-master was in charge of everyone. Men controlled public spaces and government, while women managed the home. Greco-Roman speakers often accused new foreign religions, like Christianity, of corrupting society by threatening the household structure.

The New Testament household codes were not new ideas (see [Ephesians 5:21-6:9](#); [Colossians 3:18-4:1](#); [1 Timothy 2:8-15](#); [5:1-2](#); [6:1-2](#); [Titus 2:1-3:8](#); [1 Peter 2:18-3:7](#)). The apostles adapted them to fit the Christian faith and address specific needs. The Christian faith often made major changes to the normal practices of culture. Yet, wisdom and carefulness were necessary. Ignoring the normal practices of culture could cause severe problems. This could bring dishonor, disgrace, and shame on the entire household—including Jesus, the head of the Christian household.

This was the effect of some false teachers in Ephesus, as discussed in the first letter to Timothy in the New Testament. In this context, the New Testament household codes helped Christian communities live in a way that:

1. stopped accusations that Christianity threatened the state; and
2. served as a strong, attractive witness to the truth.

Passages for Further Study

[Ephesians 5:21-6:9](#); [Colossians 3:18-4:1](#); [1 Timothy 2:8-15](#); [3:5](#), [12](#), [15](#); [5:1-2](#), [8](#); [6:1-2](#); [Titus 2:1-3:8](#); [1 Peter 2:13-3:7](#); [4:17](#); [5:1-5](#)

## The Land

The land was very important to ancient Israel because agriculture was the main way people made a living. Most Israelites were farmers or herders, and their survival depended on the land's ability to produce crops and support livestock.

God gave the Israelites the privilege and responsibility of living in Canaan. This was part of God's covenant with Israel ([1 Kings 8:33-40](#); see also [Deuteronomy 28](#)). The land was central to Israel's relationship with God, who promised it to Abraham and his descendants ([Genesis 12:1-3](#); [13:14-17](#)). The nation of Israel lived as those who tended and owned the land. The land was Israel's "inheritance" ([Deuteronomy 4:21](#)). God gave it to them and required their loyalty ([Deuteronomy 4:40](#)). God expected the people to manage the land well and serve him faithfully.

Sadly, God's people chose their own way to live. They worshiped pagan gods and themselves ([2 Kings 17:7-17](#)). So, God allowed foreign nations to gradually take Israel's land (for example, [2 Kings 8:20-22](#); [13:1-3](#); [17:3](#)). Eventually, Assyria invaded the northern kingdom, sending the Israelites into exile ([17:5-6](#), [22-23](#)).

Through these events, God warned Judah, the southern kingdom, that they would lose their land if they did not change ([2 Kings 21:8](#)). Unfortunately, they did not listen ([21:9](#)). Their unfaithfulness led to them being forced out of the land by the Babylonians ([25:1-21](#)).

Israel's rebellion and failure to manage the land God gave them is a warning to us. God has redeemed us through Christ Jesus so we can live faithful and productive lives ([John 15:16](#); [Ephesians 2:4-10](#)). If we are unfaithful and unproductive, we might lose our role in serving Christ ([John 15:1-2](#), [6](#)). By remaining connected to him, we "bear much fruit" and grow in our faith ([John 15:5](#)).

God's people always have a tendency to sin (see [Romans 3:23](#); [1 John 1:8](#), [10](#)). But God is always ready to forgive and restore those who repent and to renew the blessings of his covenant (see [1 John 1:9](#)). Jesus, who mediates the new covenant between God and his people, is also their advocate

in heaven ([Matthew 26:27-28](#); [1 John 2:1](#)). In the end, those who remain faithful to God will receive the blessings of the new heaven and the new earth ([1 Peter 1:3-5](#); [Revelation 21:1-7](#)).

### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:1-3](#); [13:14-17](#); [Leviticus 26:1-46](#); [Deuteronomy 28:1-68](#); [1 Kings 8:29-51](#); [9:3-9](#); [2 Kings 17:18-23](#); [Psalms 24:1](#); [89:11](#); [1 Peter 1:4](#); [Revelation 21:1-7](#)

## The Last Things and the Thessalonians

The Christians in Thessalonica eagerly accepted the apostle Paul's teachings about the day of the Lord and Jesus' second coming. Yet, this led to questions and guesses about the end of time.

They wondered what would happen to Christians who died before Jesus returned ([1 Thessalonians 4:13-18](#)). They also asked when "the Day of the Lord" would come ([5:1-11](#)). They wondered if Christians would experience God's wrath ([1:10](#); [5:9](#)). Paul reassures the church by explaining these topics and reminding them of the teachings they had already received ([4:13-5:11](#)).

Paul probably expected Jesus to return during his lifetime ([4:15](#)). Yet, he also knew the final event would occur unexpectedly, "like a thief in the night" ([5:2](#)). The way to be ready for the end is not by knowing the date but by living with Christian alertness. This means keeping a constant spiritual watchfulness and being ready to meet Jesus.

The Thessalonians needed to understand the deaths of fellow Christians. Paul does not discuss the state of Christians between their death and Jesus' return. Instead, he focuses on the resurrection. Just as God raised Jesus from the dead, Christians who die will also be raised when he returns. They will rise from the dead first, then join the living Christians to meet Jesus at his royal coming.

Paul tried to explain the Christian hope. But the Thessalonian Christians became confused by false teachings that said, "the Day of the Lord has already come" (see [2 Thessalonians 2:2](#)). To correct this misunderstanding, Paul discussed this topic further in his second letter to the young church (see [2 Thessalonians 2:1-12](#)).

### Passages for Further Study

[Mark 13:1-37](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:13-5:11](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:1-12](#)

## The Law and the Spirit

A common question many Christians ask is whether Christians need to follow Old Testament laws to spiritually grow in their faith. Does obeying God's law help Christians become more holy?

When the Christians in Galatia heard and accepted the good news about salvation through faith in Christ, they also received the Holy Spirit. This Holy Spirit served as proof that they were true believers. God not only gave his Spirit to them but also performed miracles among them ([Galatians 3:5](#)). The Christians in Galatia knew from their own experience that the Holy Spirit has the power to transform them into new people. The apostle Paul had taught them to depend on the Spirit for guidance in their lives.

After Paul left Galatia, Jewish-Christian teachers came to the area. These teachers taught something different. They said people needed to follow God's law both to be accepted by God and to become holy and mature. These teachers claimed that Paul's teaching about becoming more holy by the Holy Spirit (instead of carefully obeying God's law) would lead people to break God's laws and commit sins.

Paul answered these teachers by saying God does two important things through faith:

1. God *counts* or *considers* us righteous because of our faith.
2. God actually makes us righteous through faith by the work of the Holy Spirit ([Galatians 5:16-26](#)). Paul explained that people who depend on the Spirit and follow the Spirit's guidance will not sin. This is because God's Spirit will never lead people to do wrong things.

The real problem is not that people do not understand what is right and wrong. Our conscience, which God gave us, tells us when we are doing something wrong. God's law makes his standards for right living even clearer ([Romans 7:7-12](#)). The real problem is that our hearts are often stubborn and sinful. We also lack the wisdom to know the right thing to do in different situations. Because of sin's effects on human nature, we

struggle to apply God's word in a way that matches what God truly wants.

The law cannot improve our condition. But when the Holy Spirit guides and controls us, he transforms our desires so that we do things that please God ([Galatians 5:22-23](#); [Romans 8:5-14](#)). God's Spirit helps his people fulfill the true meaning and purpose of his law. But following the law should not be our main goal or focus. The law is just our "guardian" ([Galatians 3:24-25](#)). Instead, we should focus on trusting God, relying on the Spirit, and loving others. God's Spirit gives us the desire and strength to do these things in a way that pleases God.

### Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 11:16-17, 24-30](#); [Jeremiah 31:33-34](#); [Ezekiel 36:26-27](#); [Luke 24:49](#); [Acts 5:32](#); [Romans 7:1-8:17](#); [12:2](#); [2 Corinthians 3:7-18](#); [Galatians 3:2-5](#); [5:5](#), [16-26](#); [Hebrews 12:14-29](#)

## The Limitations of Law

The law was central to God's special agreement (the covenant) with the people of Israel. Many Jews in the apostle Paul's time, including Jewish Christians, still considered it as essential for living. Therefore, Paul often addresses questions about the law, especially in his letters to the Romans and the Galatians. He explores this deeply in [Romans 7](#). There he argues that the law of Moses, instead of improving people's lives, caused sin and brought death (see [7:5](#)).

Paul wants his readers to understand that the law is not to blame. God's law is good and holy ([Romans 7:12](#)). But it cannot change the human heart or will. Whether Paul describes a non Christian, a mature Christian, or an immature Christian, the message is the same. The law cannot defeat human sin (see [Romans 7:14-25](#)).

God gives the law to people who, because of their link to Adam's curse, are already easily controlled by sin's power. We may want to obey God's commands, but we find it impossible. Only a new and powerful experience of God's power and grace in Jesus Christ can rescue us ([Romans 7:25](#)). Through God's Spirit, Jesus set us free "from the law of sin and death" ([Romans 8:2](#)).

If God's good and holy law cannot save us, human laws are even less helpful for spiritual health. Whether these laws come from a religious leader, a

tradition, or a church, they cannot change the human soul. They can instruct us, but they cannot give us the strength to follow them. God's law offers a guide for the new life given by grace. But it cannot replace the power of God's grace, which comes through Christ's work.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 5:1-33](#); [6:17-25](#); [Joshua 24:19-27](#); [Ezra 7:25-26](#); [Psalms 1:1-3](#); [19:7-14](#); [78:56-59](#); [119:144](#); [Isaiah 24:5](#); [26:4-8](#); [Jeremiah 31:33-34](#); [Hosea 4:6](#); [8:12](#); [Habakkuk 1:4](#); [Matthew 5:17-20](#); [7:12](#); [Mark 7:8-9](#); [Luke 16:16-17](#); [John 1:16-17](#); [7:19](#); [Acts 13:38-39](#); [Romans 2:13-29](#); [3:19-21](#); [27-28](#); [4:13-16](#); [7:1-25](#); [8:3-4](#); [9:4](#); [31-32](#); [10:3-5](#); [Galatians 2:16-21](#); [3:2](#); [10-13](#); [17-25](#); [5:1-4](#); [1 Timothy 1:5-11](#); [Hebrews 8:7-13](#); [10:1-18](#); [1 John 3:4-6](#)

## The Little Horn

In the vision of the prophet Daniel, the little horn represents a king. It has human-like features, such as eyes and a mouth. This imagery is typical of apocalyptic literature.

"Apocalyptic" is from a Greek word meaning "reveal." So, this kind of message or writing reveals the hidden plans of God. Apocalyptic writings often using mysterious language and images. The little horn draws Daniel's attention because of its boastful speech and violent actions against other kings, God's people, and the Most High God.

What or who is the little horn? The little horn in [Daniel 7:8](#) links to evil figures in [9:27](#) and [11:40-45](#). Antiochus IV Epiphanes shares qualities with the little horn in [7:8](#), but they are not the same ([8:9-14](#), [23-25](#); [11:21-39](#)).

Both ancient and modern interpreters believe the little horn represents the future antichrist (a powerful leader who will strongly oppose God and God's people). Some think certain historical figures from the Greek and Roman empires, like Antiochus IV Epiphanes, Nero, Caligula, and Domitian, have partially fulfilled this vision. According to this perspective, this future person will be a man, not a demon or Satan.

Some see the little horn as a symbol of evil opposing God and his people. Some interpreters think no single person will fulfill this vision. Instead, they believe it represents evil forces in the world. Others believe the antichrist has already

appeared. The New Testament suggests the idea of the antichrist will have a final fulfillment (see [2 Thessalonians 2:3-12](#); [1 John 2:18](#); [4:3](#); [2 John 1:7](#); [Revelation 13:1](#), [5](#); [16:13-14](#); [17:11](#); [19:20-21](#); [20:10](#)).

This little horn reminds God's people that evil strongly opposes God and his people. The king mentioned here takes over the world's kingdoms ([Daniel 7:8](#)). But his evil system will not win because God will destroy evil. God's people can find comfort in knowing this time of evil will not last long ([Revelation 12:12](#)). God will destroy the works of this evil kingdom ([Daniel 7:11-12](#)).

God's chosen ruler, who appears "like a son of man" (looking like a human being), is given authority by God (called "the Ancient of Days" in this vision; [Daniel 7:13-14](#)). He will rule with God's approval and power, and his rule will last in a kingdom that cannot be destroyed. God encourages his people to endure and remain faithful. They live in hope of a righteous kingdom where God will live among them (see [Revelation 21:3](#)). "The zeal of the LORD of Hosts will accomplish this" ([Isaiah 9:7](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Daniel 7:8](#), [11](#), [20-21](#), [24-26](#); [8:9-12](#); [9:26-27](#); [Mark 13:14](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:5-12](#); [2 John 1:7](#); [Revelation 13:1-10](#); [20:10](#)

## The Lord of Nations

Both the Old Testament and the New Testament state that the Lord is the one true God. God is supreme over all nations and peoples at all times. Even if rulers do not believe in or acknowledge him, God remains in control. Kings and emperors might think they control everything in their lands, but they are mistaken. The Lord God is ultimately in charge.

The Old Testament prophets said that the Lord God of Israel chose the kings or emperors of each nation. God held rulers accountable for the morality of their policies and how they practiced them. This idea is clear in [Jeremiah 18](#), [25](#), and [46-51](#).

Nations that did not acknowledge the one true God would encounter severe judgment. For some nations, God promised that a small group (called a remnant) would survive (see [Jeremiah 46-51](#)).

The Lord wants people from every nation to turn to him and follow him with sincere hearts and

complete dedication. He has always wanted all people to live righteous lives and experience the joy of truly worshiping him. The book of Revelation describes people from every nation, tribe, and language worshiping God in the future ([Revelation 7:9-10](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 8:20-22; 9:29; 2 Kings 19:22-37; Jeremiah 18:5-11; 25:15-29; 46:1-51:64; Daniel 2:19-21; 4:34-37; Haggai 2:7; Matthew 28:18-20; Acts 12:21-23; Romans 13:1-7](#)

## The Message of Reconciliation

*Reconciliation* is a term found throughout the New Testament. It means making peace and repairing broken relationships. When two people reconcile, they stop being enemies and become friends again. In the same way, through Jesus, people can have their relationship with God restored.

In [Romans 5:1-11](#), the apostle Paul focuses on the cost of God's reconciling work through the death of his son.

[Colossians 1:15-20](#) is a hymn that praises Jesus Christ. It tells how he brings all of creation (everything in heaven and on earth) back into a right relationship with God. The passage shows that Jesus is Lord over all things that exist.

In [Ephesians 2:11-22](#), the focus is on reconciliation that includes both Jews and non-Jews (gentiles). They form a united church with all opposition removed.

Paul explains reconciliation in detail when discussing the meaning of Jesus' death in [2 Corinthians 5:18-21](#). Earlier, Paul reminded the Corinthians about the importance of the cross ([1 Corinthians 15:3-5](#)). But he did not explain much about its meaning then. Now, he clarifies that Christ's death on the cross means Christ "became" sin so sinners could reconnect with God.

This reconciliation changes enemies into friends. The cost of this exchange is that "God made Him who knew no sin to be sin on our behalf, so that in Him we might become the righteousness of God" ([2 Corinthians 5:21](#)).

With Jesus' resurrection and his victory over death, a new world begins. In this new era, God's people have the promise of eternal union with him (see [2 Corinthians 4:14-5:10](#)). Those who trust in Jesus

for salvation receive the Holy Spirit, which guarantees future salvation ([5:5](#)). They know that God accepts them and will welcome them forever.

Those who have made peace with God should help others find their way back to him ([2 Corinthians 5:18-21](#)). Since Christians have experienced this peace, they should also try to restore their personal relationships (see [Matthew 5:24; 18:15; Romans 12:18](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Ezekiel 45:15; Daniel 9:24; Matthew 5:24; 18:15; Acts 10:36; Romans 5:1-2; 8:6-9, 15-16; 12:18; 15:13; 2 Corinthians 5:18-21; 13:11; Ephesians 2:11-18; Colossians 1:19-22; Hebrews 2:17](#)

## The Messiah

The Greek word *christos* has the same meaning as the Hebrew word *mashiakh*. It means "anointed one" (or "chosen one"). Both words translate as "Messiah" or "Christ." In the Bible, the Messiah is someone chosen by God for a special purpose. In ancient times, people poured oil on a person's head to show that God had chosen them for an important task. This act was called anointing.

In Judaism, the term *messiah* had different meanings. The Old Testament refers to different people who received special anointing from God. God chose these people for different tasks and reasons. Not all of these people did good things, but God still selected them for his purposes ([Exodus 28:41; 1 Samuel 9:16; 1 Kings 19:16; Isaiah 45:1](#)).

The prophets expected a future Messiah who would begin God's kingdom ([Daniel 9:25-26; Zechariah 9:9-10](#)). During Jesus' time, many Jews expected the Messiah to be a political warrior. He would lead Israel to victory over its oppressors and restore Israel as an independent kingdom (see *Psalms of Solomon* 17-18).

Some Jews viewed the Messiah as a person who would come before the kingdom of God. The community at Qumran, where they found the Dead Sea Scrolls, expected a Messiah who would serve as both a priest and a political warrior.

Because of this confusion, it is not surprising that Jesus avoided the title. He taught his followers that he would suffer as Isaiah prophesied ([Isaiah 52:13-53:12](#)). The Jews interpreted this passage to refer to Israel. Jesus emphasized suffering and

service as the path to victory ([Matthew 16:21-28](#); [20:25-28](#)). This was opposite of the popular Jewish view of the Messiah as a royal conqueror. Yet, this was God's way of establishing his kingdom (see [Luke 2:25-32](#); [John 12:37-50](#); [Acts 2:29-36](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 17:6](#); [Exodus 28:41](#); [1 Samuel 9:16](#); [Isaiah 52:13-53:12](#); [Daniel 9:25-26](#); [Zechariah 9:9-10](#); [Matthew 2:4-6](#); [11:2-6](#); [16:13-20](#); [17:10-12](#); [22:41-46](#); [24:23-27](#); [26:62-65](#); [Luke 2:8-11](#), [25-35](#); [3:15-18](#); [23:35-43](#); [24:26-27](#), [46-47](#); [John 4:21-29](#); [7:25-27](#), [31](#), [40-43](#); [12:34-50](#); [20:30-31](#); [Acts 2:22-36](#); [3:17-26](#); [4:25-28](#); [9:22](#); [13:23-25](#); [17:3](#); [26:22-23](#); [28:17-24](#)

## The Messianic Banquet

Through his teaching and miracles, Jesus showed that the messianic banquet was ready. The messianic banquet is a special feast that God promised to prepare when the Messiah came. He invited all people to come and receive God's salvation and become part of God's kingdom.

Jesus compared his ministry to a wedding feast, with himself as the groom ([Luke 5:33-35](#)). The kingdom of God was like a grand banquet. God invited everyone, but some chose not to attend ([Luke 14:15-24](#); see also [Matthew 8:11-12](#)). Jesus often shared meals with a variety of people. This included disliked tax collectors and committed Pharisees ([5:29-32](#); [7:36-50](#); [11:37-41](#); [14:1-6](#)).

He also used the imagery of feasting and banquets in his teachings and parables ([Luke 5:33-35](#); [12:35-38](#); [14:7-14](#), [15-24](#); [17:7-10](#); [22:28-30](#)). Additionally, he fed large crowds with just a few loaves and fishes ([9:10-17](#)).

The Old Testament background for this feast imagery is [Isaiah 25:6](#). It describes God's final salvation as a great feast for everyone: "the LORD of Hosts will prepare a lavish banquet for all the peoples, a feast of aged wine, of choice meat, of finely aged wine" (see also [Isaiah 65:13-14](#)).

Jesus' public ministry began the invitation to the banquet and its beginning. Through his death and resurrection, he brought salvation. Now, everyone can come to God's banquet table and receive the kingdom's spiritual blessings. Yet, this banquet will fully happen in the future kingdom. Then, Jesus' disciples will "eat and drink at My table in My kingdom" and "sit on thrones, judging the twelve

tribes of Israel" ([Luke 22:30](#); see also [Revelation 19:7-9](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 25:6](#); [65:13-14](#); [Luke 5:29-35](#); [6:21](#); [7:36-50](#); [9:10-17](#); [11:37-41](#); [12:35-40](#); [13:24-30](#); [14:1-24](#); [17:8](#); [22:30](#)

## The Mystery of the Good News

In his letters, the apostle Paul often uses the word *mystery* to describe the good news about Jesus (some translations use the word *secret*). Sometimes, Paul uses *mystery* as a way of referring to the good news itself ([Colossians 2:2](#); [4:3](#); [1 Corinthians 2:1](#); [Ephesians 1:9](#); [6:19](#)). Often, as in [Colossians 1:26](#), Paul says, it is "the mystery that was hidden for ages and generations but is now revealed" (see also [Romans 16:25](#); [1 Corinthians 2:7](#); [Ephesians 3:9](#)). Paul does not mean the good news is a mystery that has to be investigated. He also does not mean the good news is a Gnostic idea that only a few people can understand. (Gnostics emphasized special secret knowledge as the key to salvation.)

Instead, Paul adapts the term from Jewish apocalyptic teaching. The term *apocalyptic* comes from a Greek word meaning "uncovering" or "revelation." This is the same word that gives the book of Revelation its name. In the apocalyptic view, God has already created a plan for all of history. This plan exists in God's mind but remains hidden from humans until God chooses to reveal it. For Paul, this secret plan has now been shown to everyone through Christ. It is now being shared throughout the world by his apostles.

In the Old Testament, prophets shared parts of the good news, but God kept some details hidden until the New Testament. These include:

- the full participation of gentiles (non-Jewish people) as fellow heirs with Jews ([Colossians 1:27](#); [Ephesians 3:1-9](#));
- the indwelling of Jesus Christ in believers ([Colossians 1:27](#); [2:2](#)); and
- the union of Christ and his church (this union is shown or illustrated by the union of husband and wife ([Ephesians 5:32](#)).

Some parts of God's plan remain hidden and will be revealed in the future, such as:

- the salvation of all Israel ([Romans 11:25-27](#)); and
- Christians will be transformed when Jesus returns ([1 Corinthians 15:51-53](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Romans 11:25](#); [16:25](#); [1 Corinthians 2:1](#), [7](#); [15:51](#); [Ephesians 1:9](#); [3:1-9](#); [5:32](#); [6:19](#); [Colossians 1:26-27](#); [2:2](#); [4:3](#)

## The New Community

The New Testament emphasizes the importance of the Christian community. Cultures that focus on individuals can miss this emphasis. Although God converts and spiritually rebirths Christians as individuals, he does not want them to remain isolated ([John 3:3](#); [1 Peter 1:23](#)). God intends to unite us as "living stones" in his "spiritual house" ([1 Peter 2:5](#)). God no longer lives in a building on Mount Zion in Jerusalem. He now lives in and among his people through the Holy Spirit.

God promised to rebuild his temple (see [Ezekiel 40-48](#)). He fulfills this promise as he lives among his people (see [John 1:14](#)). Under the new covenant, the people themselves are the "temple." We must unite in worship, praise, and service to fulfill God's purpose. Christians share the blessing of being chosen by God to carry out his mission to the world.

[1 Peter 2:9](#) teaches that the church now has the same special role that God once gave to Israel. The church is a "chosen people" (see [Deuteronomy 7:6](#)). It is "a royal priesthood," "a holy nation" (see

[Exodus 19:6](#)). It is "God's own possession" (see [Exodus 19:5](#)).

With this special status comes the duty to share the truth about God with the nations. By worshiping together and serving in different ministries, we "proclaim the virtues of Him" ([1 Peter 2:9](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:3](#); [Exodus 19:4-6](#); [Deuteronomy 7:6](#); [2 Chronicles 5:13-14](#); [Isaiah 11:1-16](#); [John 1:14](#); [1 Corinthians 3:9-17](#); [6:19](#); [2 Corinthians 6:16-18](#); [Ephesians 2:19-22](#); [1 Peter 2:4-10](#); [Revelation 3:12](#); [21:1-3](#), [22](#)

## The New Covenant

A covenant is a formal agreement or promise made between two parties. In the Bible, covenants are special agreements between God and people.

The old covenant refers to the agreement God made with the people of Israel at Mount Sinai after he rescued them from slavery in Egypt. The main promise of the covenant of Mount Sinai was, "I will take you as My own people, and I will be your God" ([Exodus 6:7](#); see [Jeremiah 31:33](#)). The relationship between God and his people in the Sinai covenant included laws carved in stone and a priestly class who managed all religious institutions and activities.

The new covenant is the agreement God made with people through Jesus Christ. The new covenant would differ from the old in a key way. The new covenant would no longer be external to the worshipers but would be written on their hearts ([Jeremiah 31:33](#)). The old covenant's major weakness was its lack of power to help people obey its commands ([Romans 8:3](#)). The new covenant would be placed inside people's hearts and minds through the power of the Holy Spirit ([Ezekiel 36:24-27](#)).

Because of this, it would become possible for people everywhere (not just a few chosen ones) to fulfill God's covenant plan for life. This plan is summarized in the two "Great Commandments" ([Matthew 22:35-40](#)):

1. "You shall love the LORD your God" ([Deuteronomy 6:5](#)).
2. "Love your neighbor as yourself" ([Leviticus 19:18](#)).

The new covenant would achieve what the old one intended but could not achieve. It would create new individuals and a new community. The goal is a deep transformation of sinners, starting with forgiveness of sins and leading to holiness shown by good works ([Ephesians 1:4](#); [2:8-10](#)).

[Jeremiah 30-33](#) emphasizes a hopeful future for Israel. The key moment is when the Lord God promises a new covenant with his people ([31:31-34](#)). This passage points to Jesus of Nazareth, whose death would confirm this new covenant. Jesus connected the new covenant to himself during the communion ceremony ([Matthew 26:28](#); [Mark 14:24](#); [Luke 22:20](#); see also [1 Corinthians 11:25](#); [2 Corinthians 3:6](#)).

Jesus' death made him the mediator of the covenant for all who trust in him ([Hebrews 8:8-12](#); chapter 9). Christians remember this truth each time they take Communion (also called the Lord's Supper or the Eucharist). According to the New Testament, all Christians will know God directly through the Holy Spirit, made possible by Christ's sacrifice. They will know him personally and experience him powerfully, unlike most people in Old Testament times.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 11:1-9](#); [54:13-15](#); [Jeremiah 31:31-34](#); [Ezekiel 37:24-28](#); [Matthew 26:27-28](#); [Luke 22:20](#); [Romans 11:25-36](#); [1 Corinthians 11:23-26](#); [2 Corinthians 3:6-18](#); [Hebrews 8:8-9:28](#)

## The New Order

Isaiah describes two different ways the world can be. The first way (the *old order*) is how things are now, where people struggle with power and difficulties. The second way (the *new order*) is God's new creation that will come in the future, where everything will be fair and people will live together in peace.

When Isaiah thinks about the old way of life, he remembers:

- sadness ([Isaiah 65:19](#)).
- death ([65:20](#))
- injustice and violence ([65:21-22](#))
- the absence of God ([65:24](#))

In this old way of life, people trust in their own strength and are proud.

Isaiah's vision of the new order focuses on the Lord as the great king in holiness and glory (see [6:1-5](#)).

God's people experience aspects of this new order now, such as:

- God's comfort ([40:1](#))
- salvation ([45:22](#))
- joy ([24:14-15](#))
- righteousness ([24:16](#))
- peace ([26:3](#))
- divine blessing and protection

There are other aspects that we cannot experience yet, such as:

- the end of death ([25:7-8](#))
- resurrection ([26:19](#))
- the end of fighting, wrongdoing, and evil ([60:18](#); [65:25](#))
- full enjoyment of God's presence ([60:19](#)).
- God ruling in his eternal kingdom without opposition (see [Revelation 21-22](#))

Those who trust in God anticipate these things in the future.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 11:1](#); [24:14-16](#); [25:7-8](#); [26:19](#); [30:26](#); [43:18-19](#); [60:18-19](#); [62:2](#); [65:17-25](#); [Jeremiah 23:7-8](#); [31:10-14](#); [2 Corinthians 3:6-11](#); [5:17](#); [Hebrews 12:18-24](#); [Revelation 21:1-22:21](#)

## The Old Life and the New Life

When people become Christians, they unite with Jesus and share in his death and resurrection. Their old life, marked by sin, ends with Jesus. They start a new life through his power within them (see [Romans 6:3-14](#)).

God transforms them by his Spirit. Their minds are renewed (see [Romans 12:2](#)). Their desires and actions change, and their lives begin to show his Spirit ([Galatians 5:22-23](#)). They begin to spiritually grow and become more like Jesus.

Christians have a duty to be "conformed" to Jesus' death and resurrection (see [Philippians 3:10-14](#)). They must turn away from darkness and commit to a life full of light ([Ephesians 4:17-5:20](#)). This means they are to stop living in evil ways and start living in God's good ways. The apostle Paul describes this change using the image of clothing. God calls Christians to remove the old, sinful life influenced by the devil and put on a new, pure life guided by the Holy Spirit ([Ephesians 4:21-24](#); [Colossians 3:1-15](#); see also [Galatians 3:27](#)). In doing so, they acknowledge their dependence on God's grace and power.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Romans 6:3-14](#); [12:1-2](#); [Galatians 5:19-23](#); [Ephesians 4:17-5:20](#); [Philippians 3:12-14](#)

## The Old Realm and the New

The Jewish people in Paul's time saw a clear difference between the "present evil age" and a "glorious age to come." Throughout [Romans 5-8](#), Paul uses these contrasting "realms" or "kingdoms" to explain our experience of salvation.

The rulers of the old realm are:

- death ([Romans 5:12-21](#));
- sin (chapter [6](#));
- the law (chapter [7](#)); and
- sinful nature ("the flesh" in [8:1-11](#)).

The new realm is characterized by:

- life ([Romans 5](#));
- righteous living (chapter [6](#));
- grace (chapter [6](#)); and
- the Holy Spirit (chapter [8](#)).

A person's future depends directly on which of these two realms they belong to.

Each realm has a leader representing its people. Adam, the first man, leads the old realm of sin and death. Christ leads the new realm of forgiveness and life. By nature, all humans belong to the old realm of sin and death, represented by Adam. His sin and death affect everyone's future ([Romans 5:12, 18-19](#)).

Those who have faith in God through Jesus move into the new realm of life. God appointed Jesus Christ as a "second Adam" (see [5:14](#)). By obeying God and fulfilling his will, Jesus achieved a major victory over the realm of sin that Adam started ([5:18-19](#)). By accepting God's gift of grace, people choose Jesus as their leader and hope for eternal life ([5:17](#)).

People in the new realm unite with Christ and enjoy the benefits of this union. They have "died with Christ," been "buried with Christ," and their current new life with Christ is an introduction to the day they will "live with Him" forever ([Romans 6:3-11](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 2:1-10](#); [110:2](#); [145:13](#); [Daniel 2:31-45](#); [7:1-28](#); [Matthew 3:2](#); [6:10](#); [7:13](#); [8:11-12](#); [12:25-28](#); [13:44-52](#); [20:25-28](#); [John 18:36](#); [Romans 5:12-8:39](#); [14:17](#); [1 Corinthians 6:9-11](#); [15:20-28](#); [Galatians 5:16-26](#); [Ephesians 1:3](#), [20](#); [2:6](#); [5:1-20](#); [Colossians 1:13-14](#); [Hebrews 6:4-5](#); [12:18-29](#); [Revelation 11:15](#); [12:10](#)

## The Passover

The feast of Passover became a central part of Israelite religious practice. This festival celebrated God's rescue of the Hebrews from Egypt and his protection from the final deadly plague. God wanted it observed every year, following the instructions in the book of Exodus ([Exodus 12:1-27](#)). Passover was a reminder for future generations of God's saving actions. All the people participated in the feast. They ate only unleavened bread, just as they did when they quickly left Egypt.

During the first Passover, they sacrificed a lamb to save the firstborn son of each Israelite family ([Exodus 12:12-13, 23](#)). Passover represents that we can escape death only through a sacrifice that substitutes for us. Passover was an important event in Israelite history. But the exodus from Egypt did not solve the universal problem of death, which comes from sin ([1 Corinthians 15:56](#)).

Many years later, during the Passover feast, Jesus Christ gave his "life as a ransom for many" ([Matthew 20:28](#); [Mark 10:45](#)). He became "the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" ([John 1:29](#)). While sharing a final Passover meal with his disciples, Jesus explained the symbolic meaning of the wine they shared: "This is My blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for

the forgiveness of sins" ([Matthew 26:28](#)). He represents and begins a new Passover. Jesus completely and finally defeated sin and death through his sacrifice (see also [Isaiah 25:7-8](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 12:1-51](#); [Leviticus 23:4-8](#); [Numbers 9:1-14](#); [Numbers 28:16-25](#); [Deuteronomy 16:1-7](#); [Matthew 26:17-30](#); [Luke 22:15-20](#); [1 Corinthians 5:6-8](#)

## The Plagues

The main purpose of the plagues in Egypt was not to rescue the Hebrew people from Egyptian oppression. If rescue was the goal, one big miracle would have been enough. The plagues intended to show who God is to Israel, Egypt, and nearby nations.

The Israelites likely forgot who God was. They lived for hundreds of years in Egypt, a culture that worshiped many false gods. Whatever they believed about God when they arrived, the Israelites became influenced by pagan views during their time there (see [Exodus 32](#)).

The plagues in the book of Exodus showed the Lord's complete power over all creation. These disasters targeted elements that the Egyptians respected and worshiped:

1. *The Nile Turned to Blood* ([7:14-25](#)): The Nile River, seen as a god that provided life and fertility to Egypt, turned into a symbol of death.
2. *Frogs* ([8:1-15](#)): The Egyptians respected frogs, represented by *Heqet*, the frog-headed goddess of fertility. They thought she had the secret to life after death. Now, frogs covered the land, bringing the smell of death.
3. *Gnats* ([8:16-19](#)): "The finger of God" brought a plague of biting insects from the ground. This showed God's power over *Geb*, the Egyptian god of the earth.

4. *Flies* ([8:20-32](#)): The Lord made a clear difference between Israel and Egypt. Swarms of biting flies filled the land and tormented the Egyptians, including Pharaoh. They revered flies as symbols of life from death.
5. *Death of Livestock* ([9:1-7](#)): The Egyptians saw cattle as holy, believing they controlled life and fertility. They depicted *Amon-Re*, Egypt's chief god, as a bull. "The hand of the Lord" struck the cattle, showing his supreme power.
6. *Festering Boils* ([9:8-12](#)): God gave the Egyptians painful sores. The Egyptian goddess of healing, *Sekhmet*, could not help them.
7. *Hail* ([9:13-35](#)): The Egyptian god *Osiris*, who represented plants, could not stop the Lord from destroying them, because "the earth is the LORD's."
8. *Locusts* ([10:1-20](#)): The Lord sent wind to bring locusts, which destroyed the remaining plants. This ended any hope that *Osiris* could restore Egypt's crops.
9. *Darkness* ([10:21-29](#)): The Lord showed total control over *Re*, the sun god and leader of the Egyptian gods, who was seen as the father of mankind. No power in Egypt could oppose the Lord and his plans.
10. *Death of the Firstborn* ([11:1-12:30](#)): The Lord took the life of each Egyptian family's male heir, which they valued most. Meanwhile, the Lord saved Israel through the Passover blood sacrifice.

Yahweh showed both the Egyptians and the Israelites that he is the only God.

The plagues are often known as "signs," similar to Jesus' miracles (for example, [Exodus 7:3](#); [10:1-2](#); [John 2:23](#); [4:48](#); [12:37](#)). The plagues demonstrate that worshiping created things leads to God's judgment. In contrast, Jesus' miracles show that God can conquer all deadly aspects of creation. This

includes illness, evil forces, unpredictable nature, and even death, through the gift of life.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:15-20](#); [20:1-18](#); [Exodus 7:3-5](#); [7:14-11:10](#); [12:28-33](#); [32:35](#); [Numbers 11:33](#); [12:1-15](#); [16:43-50](#); [1 Kings 13:4](#); [2 Kings 2:24](#); [2 Chronicles 26:16-21](#); [Acts 5:1-11](#)

## The Poor and Needy in the Psalms

Throughout the Bible, God supports those who are poor and needy. These people are often oppressed and treated badly by society or greedy people. The book of Psalms frequently mentions the struggles of the oppressed and God's concern for them. In their distress, the poor and needy can find refuge in the Lord (see [Psalms 76:9](#); [107:4-9](#)). They can call out to him, as he has promised to care for them (see [25:16-18](#); [70:1-5](#); [74:19](#)). They can trust him and wait with hope for him to bring justice ([18:1-50](#); [70:5](#)).

Many people may experience life with sorrow ([Psalms 88:13-15](#); [90:15](#); see [102:1-28](#)). Distress can be a form of discipline that teaches righteousness ([119:71](#), [75](#)). No matter how long, severe, or what causes it, the Lord hears the cries of the poor, as many psalms show ([10:17-18](#); [12:5](#); [22:24](#); [35:10](#); [109:31](#); [113:5-7](#); [140:12](#)). In the end, God will satisfy the poor and the godly will rejoice (see [22:26](#); [132:15](#); [34:1-2](#); [69:32](#)).

God chose the kings from David's family line to bring justice to God's suffering people ([Psalm 72:2, 4, 12](#)). But they did not succeed. Jesus, the Christ king, understands our human struggles ([Isaiah 53:4, 7](#)). He has come to help the poor and oppressed ([Luke 4:17-21](#); see [Isaiah 61:1-3](#)). He is the hope for those who know they need him and who desire righteousness ([Matthew 5:3-12](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 9:18](#); [10:1-18](#); [12:5](#); [22:1-31](#); [34:1-22](#); [35:10](#); [37:14](#); [40:17](#); [41:1](#); [49:2](#); [68:10](#); [69:33](#); [70:5](#); [72:2-4](#); [12-13](#); [74:21](#); [82:3-4](#); [107:41](#); [109:16, 22, 31](#); [132:15](#); [140:12](#)

## The Priestly Blessing

The priestly blessing is a well-known and beloved passage in the Hebrew Bible ([Numbers 6:22-27](#)). For centuries, worshipers have found comfort in its

short yet meaningful lines. This famous text is simple and distinguished.

The priestly blessing calls for the Lord's favor by repeating his name in each request ("the Lord" means *Yahweh*; see study note on [Exodus 3:15](#)). Repeating God's name reminds his people of his care and role in their lives. This blessing emphasizes the bond between God and his people and helps them remember from where their blessings come.

Many Old Testament passages talk about blessings from God and people (for example, [Genesis 12:1-3](#); [27:1-40](#); [Deuteronomy 7:12-15](#); [28:1-14](#)). The Israelites needed God's blessings, his help and favor, as they prepared to leave Sinai. Modern readers often think of blessings in general terms. But, the Israelites in the wilderness understood them as food, water, health, children, protection from enemies, and settling in the promised land. Throughout the book of Numbers, God provided Israel's practical needs.

The Lord blessed Israel through the words of Aaron and his sons, the priests ([Numbers 6:22-23](#)). Besides their work in the tabernacle (and later the temple), the priests played a key role in Israelite life. For example, the priests helped guarantee justice in the land ([Deuteronomy 17:8-12](#)). They supported the king in his duties, following a principle in [Deuteronomy 17:18-20](#). Eli the priest comforted Hannah and guided young Samuel's spiritual growth ([1 Samuel 1:1-3:21](#)). The priests and Levites were active in teaching Israel's spiritual lessons (see, for example, [Deuteronomy 33:9-10](#); [Nehemiah 8:9-12](#); [Malachi 2:5-9](#)).

An important archaeological discovery emphasizes the importance of this ancient priestly blessing. In 1980, excavators found two small silver scrolls in a rock-cut tomb at *Ketef Hinnom*, southwest of Jerusalem's Old City. Scholars date these objects (amulets) to the late 600s or early 500s BC. After a long and careful process, they unrolled the delicate scrolls and found the blessing from [Numbers 6:24-26](#), closely matching the Hebrew Bible text.

In ancient times, people sometimes wore such scrolls as symbolic objects (charms), similar to *tefillin* or "phylacteries" or "prayer boxes" (see [Deuteronomy 6:8](#); [Matthew 23:5](#)). These small scrolls are the earliest biblical manuscripts and contain the earliest reference to *Yahweh*, the Old Testament name of God, found in Jerusalem. These archaeological finds show the lasting appeal of this brief biblical text.

Many New Testament letters conclude with a blessing for the readers. This blessing is similar to the priestly blessing in Numbers (for example, [2 Corinthians 13:14](#); [Hebrews 13:20-21](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:28](#); [9:1](#), [26-27](#); [12:1-3](#); [14:19-20](#); [28:1-4](#); [48:15-20](#); [49:25-26](#); [Leviticus 9:22](#); [Numbers 6:22-27](#); [24:1-9](#); [Deuteronomy 10:8](#); [33:11-29](#); [1 Samuel 2:20](#); [1 Kings 8:55-65](#); [2 Chronicles 30:27](#); [Psalms 115:12-15](#); [128:1-6](#); [Matthew 5:3-11](#); [Luke 11:27-28](#); [2 Corinthians 13:14](#); [Ephesians 6:23](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:23-24](#)

## The Promise of a Second Exodus

God brought the people of Israel back to their homeland from Babylon, just as he had brought them out of Egypt many years before ([Isaiah 48:20-21](#)). (This first rescue from Egypt is called the exodus.) This time, when leaving Babylon, the people needed to be pure and take their time, not rushing to leave ([52:11,12](#)).

The experience in exile and the journey compare to a desert from which the Lord rescues (see [Isaiah 35:1](#)):

- He creates a road through the desert and turns it into a place with water, plants, and animals ([Isaiah 43:19-20](#)).
- He removes obstacles ([42:16](#); [49:11](#)).
- He guides his people ([42:16](#); [58:11](#); [63:13](#)).
- He feeds them ([49:10](#)).
- He protects them from the heat ([49:10](#)).
- He gives them strength ([58:11](#)).
- He changes their sorrow into great joy ([51:3](#)).
- He pours out his Spirit on them ([44:3-4](#)).

Christians also experience an "exodus." They leave behind sin and death through Jesus' death and resurrection. The Holy Spirit helps Christians have a new life. They serve God joyfully while waiting for his kingdom to fully arrive.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 35:8-10](#); [42:14-16](#); [43:18-21](#); [44:3-4](#); [48:20-21](#); [49:9-12](#); [52:11-12](#); [58:8-12](#); [Jeremiah 31:2-17](#); [Joel 3:17-21](#); [Luke 1:78-79](#); [John 7:38](#); [15:19](#); [2 Corinthians 5:17](#); [6:17-18](#); [Ephesians 5:8](#); [Colossians 1:13](#); [Hebrews 13:12-14](#); [Revelation 7:16](#)

## The Promise of Dynasty

God promised King David that his family line would last forever ([2 Samuel 7:11-16](#) and parallel passage in [1 Chronicles 17:9-14](#)). Yet, the writer of Chronicles (called the Chronicler) lived when David's family line seemed to have ended. Although David's descendants continued, no descendant had been king since Judah's exile to Babylon over 150 years earlier (see [1 Chronicles 3:1-24](#)). This situation raised doubts about Israel's future hope.

The Chronicler intended to show that God's promise to David was unconditional and that his throne was indeed "secure forever." Even the possibility of exile does not remove the hope of God's promise of a royal family line. The promise would continue for a future time because a future descendant of David would inherit the throne ([1 Chronicles 17:11](#)).

The Chronicler did not directly write about the Messiah in the strict meaning of the term. He was not mainly focused on the coming of a deliverer chosen by God. Instead, he hoped that kings from David's line would lead the covenant community again (the people of Israel who had a special agreement with God). The Chronicler encouraged the community to anticipate a new king who would improve Israel's condition.

The birth of Jesus, the Son of David, fulfilled the Chronicler's hope for Israel. Jesus met the Chronicler's expectation of a new king (see [Matthew 1:1-17](#)). His kingdom includes all nations ([Isaiah 49:6](#)). It extends "from sea to sea, and from the Euphrates to the ends of the earth" ([Zechariah 9:10](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 49:8-12](#); [1 Chronicles 5:1-2](#); [17:1-15](#); [22:6-13](#); [28:4-7](#); [Psalms 78:67-72](#); [132:11-12](#); [Amos 9:11-12](#); [Matthew 1:1-17](#); [22:41-46](#)

## The Promise of New Life

The resurrection is a key belief in Christianity. Without it, the Christian faith has no value ([1 Corinthians 15:14](#)). God promises that his people will share in this resurrection with Christ ([Colossians 3:1](#)). It is important to plainly understand the new life God promises us.

[Ezekiel 37](#) might seem to suggest that everyone will resurrect with new bodies after death. Yet, the prophet Ezekiel is not asking, "Can human bones come back to life?" Ezekiel and his audience already knew about the possibility of resurrection from the miracles of Elijah and Elisha ([1 Kings 17:17-24](#); [2 Kings 4:31-37](#); [13:20-21](#)). Instead, Ezekiel is asking, "Can *these* bones live?" He is questioning if God can restore the nation of Judah since they are a stripped, broken apart, and dried-up nation.

At that time, the Babylonians had devastated Judah, destroyed the temple, and exiled many people to Babylon. The nation had lost its power, been broken politically, and was spiritually exhausted. Those still in Judah were a small group, only the poorest of the poor (see [2 Kings 25:8-12](#)). Many believed there was no future for God's people. They said, "Our bones are dried up, and our hope has perished; we are cut off" ([Ezekiel 37:11](#)). The question was not whether God *could* revive them, but whether he *would* perform such a miracle for the dry bones representing Israel.

The prophet answered this question with a strong *Yes!* God would bring his people back to life by pouring out his Spirit, responding to the prophet's word. Their death because of their sins was real. But God would not leave them in the grave (see [Psalm 16:10](#)). Instead, he promised that in the future he would give his people life through his Spirit. He would transform them into a new creation, a new Spirit-filled Israel. This new people of God would stand as a mighty army to serve the Lord.

God can bring back to life those who are physically or spiritually dead. He chooses to give new life to sinners who do not deserve it (see [John 3:5-7](#); [Ephesians 2:1-7](#)). Those who suffer from sin also receive the new life God offers through his Spirit, both now and forever (see [Romans 8:5-13](#); [Colossians 3:1-11](#)). He makes people, whom the world sees as beyond saving, acceptable to him through Christ ([1 Corinthians 6:9-11](#)). He also prepares them for meaningful work in his service ([Ephesians 4:12-13](#); [6:11-18](#)).

## Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 17:17-24](#); [2 Kings 4:31-37](#); [13:20-21](#); [Psalm 16:10](#); [Ezekiel 18:31](#); [37:1-28](#); [39:29](#); [Matthew 22:31-32](#); [Romans 8:11](#); [2 Corinthians 5:17](#)

## The Purpose of the Judgments

What is the purpose of God's judgments? Are they meant to bring redemption, or are they just meant to destroy? The judgments in the book of Revelation provide some clues.

At the end of the sixth trumpet, despite all the plagues, people "still did not repent of the works of their hands" ([Revelation 9:20-21](#)). Some people will not change, no matter what happens to them, even under pressure.

The tormented people of the fifth trumpet wanted to die instead of turning to God in repentance ([9:6](#)). Many choose death over admitting their sins.

In the sixth seal, the people asked the rocks to fall on them to hide them from "the wrath of the Lamb" ([6:12-17](#)). Their desire to escape judgment shows fear instead of trust in God.

Revelation emphasizes God's final justice and the idea of retribution or pay back ([16:5-7](#)). Both Christians and non-Christians will get what they deserve (see [2:23](#); [11:18](#); [14:13](#); [18:6](#); [20:12-13](#); [22:12](#)).

The judgments are God's partial response to the prayers of the saints for justice. Judgment happens in God's time, not ours ([6:9-11](#); [8:2-5](#)).

The judgments, similar to the plagues on Egypt, show that earthly gods and God's enemies lack power ([Exodus 7:8-12](#); [12:12](#); compare [Revelation 13:4-17](#); [19:20-21](#); [20:9-10](#)).

The judgments are part of God's mission and provide a final opportunity to repent ([Revelation 14:6-7](#); see [9:20-21](#); [16:9](#), [11](#), [21](#)).

God has made it clear that sin is wrong and judgment is coming ([Romans 2:5-11](#)). Yet, many people still refuse to repent and accept God's grace ([Romans 1:32](#)). Even in the final days, when God sends his witnesses to warn about the coming destruction, many will choose to support evil forces. They will celebrate the downfall of God's prophets ([Revelation 11:3-10](#)). Those who oppose God and turn away from him he will eventually remove from his presence.

Judgment for disobedience and evil actions is certain (see [Romans 1:18-2:11](#)). Yet God patiently waits for people to repent and offers his grace (see [Romans 2:4](#); [2 Peter 3:8-10](#)). Therefore, these warnings about judgment can be a chance for change.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 6:6](#); [12:12](#); [Leviticus 26:25](#); [2 Kings 17:7-23](#); [Psalm 103:6](#); [Proverbs 16:11](#); [Isaiah 13:11](#); [26:21](#); [59:18](#); [Jeremiah 5:1-9](#); [Ezekiel 11:21](#); [39:21-24](#); [Zephaniah 1:12](#); [Malachi 3:5](#); [Luke 12:47](#); [John 5:30](#); [Romans 2:2-11](#); [Hebrews 2:1-4](#); [10:29](#); [Revelation 9:20-21](#)

## The Purpose of the Sinai Covenant

Almost everything the Israelites learned about ultimate reality from the Egyptians was incorrect. There are not many gods. There is only one God. The Creator is completely good, and evil comes from rebelling against him. You cannot gain God's blessings through magic or trying to influence God. God's blessings are free to those who lovingly submit to him.

When the Israelites left Egypt, they did not fully understand God as he intended. Through the plagues and crossing the Red Sea, they learned about God's unique power. In the wilderness, they discovered God's caring provision. Yet, they still did not know God's character. The covenant at Sinai was a special agreement between God and the Israelites. The covenant was designed to teach the Israelites about God's nature and character as they followed his Torah, his instructions.

The covenant used a well-known political form, the *suzerain-vassal treaty*. In this type of treaty, a powerful king (the *suzerain*) made a treaty with a nation he had conquered (the *vassal* people). The conquered people promised complete loyalty to the king and agreed to follow his rules. In return, the king promised to care for them and protect them from enemies. In the covenant at Mount Sinai, God asked the people for complete loyalty to him as their only God. He wanted them to live in a way that showed his will and nature as their Creator and King.

God wanted the Israelites to simply obey him. Yet, since the first human sin, there has been a fundamental problem with the human spirit ([Genesis 3](#)). Simple obedience was impossible for the Israelites because their wills were not obedient.

The covenant was good, but it could not enable the Israelites to follow it ([Romans 7:12](#); [8:3](#)). Without God's Spirit, we cannot do what we must or share the creator's character. But now, Jesus has died as a sacrifice on the cross to remove our sins. So, God empowers by the Spirit those who trust in Christ to fulfill his covenant purpose and share his holy character.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 9:1](#); [19:3-6](#); [Leviticus 11:44-45](#); [Jeremiah 31:33-34](#); [32:40](#); [John 16:5-11](#); [Romans 8:5-14](#); [10:8-17](#); [Galatians 5](#)

## The Remnant

The remnant is a small group of people who remain faithful to God. When foreign armies threatened to invade, and people feared being taken away from their homeland, the idea of the remnant was a source of hope for God's people (see [Micah 2:12-13](#); [4:6-8](#)). The exile of the Israelites to Babylon was God's judgment on his people. But God showed he would not destroy them completely (see [Hosea 11:8-11](#)). Preserving a remnant showed God's mercy and faithfulness.

The idea of a remnant was central to the prophet Isaiah's message. One of his sons was named Shear-jashub, which means "a remnant will return" ([Isaiah 7:3](#); see [10:21](#)). Isaiah prophesied that when God judged his people with destruction, he would save the remnant to be the starting point of a new beginning. This destruction happened when the Babylonians attacked from 605 to 586 BC.

Because the population of Judah would be greatly reduced (as the northern kingdom of Israel had been already), this remnant would be a very small beginning. Isaiah describes the remnant as:

- a "Branch" ([4:2](#)),
- a "stump" ([6:13](#)),
- a community of the "poor" and "needy" ([25:4](#)), and
- grain that "will be gathered one by one" ([27:12-13](#)).

This remnant was to trust in God while waiting for him to establish his rule and reward them (see [3:10](#); [40:10](#)). God promised that this small group would grow into a large crowd from both Israel and other nations ([27:6](#); [60:3](#)).

In fulfillment of prophecy, a remnant of God's people were allowed to return to Jerusalem and rebuild the temple during King Cyrus of Persia's rule ([Ezra 1:2-4](#)). Ezra the priest saw this preservation of a remnant as an act of God's grace. He also knew this grace could be put at risk if the people followed their ancestors in disobedience ([Ezra 9:5-15](#)).

The idea of the remnant encourages people to remain faithful to God, even when others are not. For Israel and Judah, this faithfulness would restore their land and bring the blessings God promised his people.

#### Passages for Further Study

[2 Kings 19:31](#); [2 Chronicles 36:20](#); [Ezra 9:14](#); [Isaiah 1:8-9](#); [4:1-3](#); [6:13](#); [10:19-22](#); [11:10-16](#); [27:12-13](#); [28:5](#); [37:31-32](#); [46:3-4](#); [Jeremiah 6:9](#); [23:3-4](#); [31:7-8](#); [Amos 5:15](#); [Micah 2:12](#); [4:6-7](#); [5:7-8](#); [7:18](#); [Zephaniah 3:11-13](#)

## The Resurrection of Jesus

The Bible clearly describes how Jesus physically rose from the dead through God's power. However, many other explanations have been suggested:

1. Jesus did not actually die. He fainted and later woke up in a cold tomb. Some call this the "the swoon theory."
2. Jesus' disciples stole his body and lied about the resurrection (see [Matthew 28:12-15](#)).
3. The disciples saw things that were not there (called hallucinations) and had dreams, causing them to confuse these experiences with a physical resurrection.
4. The resurrection is a personal faith experience, not a historical event.

These ideas often come from doubt about supernatural or miraculous events. They overlook that for New Testament writers and their audiences, the term *resurrection* meant an actual dead body coming back to life (see [1 Corinthians 15](#)).

There is historical evidence for Jesus' resurrection. The biblical accounts are reliable as well. These proofs include:

1. The empty tomb.
2. Women as witnesses, which was unusual at that time. This is because people then considered women's testimony less reliable than men's.
3. The consistent accounts of Jesus' appearances after his resurrection.
4. How the disciples transformed from fearful to fearless followers.
5. The disciples' ability to accept the shame of following the religion of a crucified man. According to [Deuteronomy 21:23](#), such a death meant being under God's curse.

Judaism had no concept of a Messiah (God's chosen one) who would die and then rise again that could easily be applied to Jesus. Creating a story that no one would find believable would not have made sense. The most reasonable conclusion is exactly what the New Testament declares: Jesus did rise from the dead.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 16:21](#); [17:9](#), [23](#); [20:19](#); [26:32](#); [28:1-10](#); [Mark 14:28](#); [Luke 9:22](#); [14:14](#); [John 2:19-22](#); [5:21](#); [6:39-40](#); [11:1-44](#); [14:20](#); [21:14](#); [Acts 1:21-22](#); [2:22-36](#); [3:15](#), [26](#); [4:2](#), [10](#), [33](#); [5:30](#); [10:39-40](#); [13:29-31](#); [17:18](#), [32](#); [23:6-10](#); [Romans 1:4](#); [4:24-25](#); [6:4-5](#), [9](#); [7:4](#); [8:11](#), [34](#); [10:9](#); [1 Corinthians 6:14](#); [15:4](#), [12-23](#), [35](#), [42-44](#), [52](#); [2 Corinthians 1:9](#); [4:14](#); [5:15](#); [Galatians 1:1](#); [Ephesians 1:19-20](#); [2:5-6](#); [Philippians 3:10-11](#); [Colossians 2:12](#); [3:1](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:10](#); [4:14](#); [2 Timothy 2:8](#), [18](#); [Hebrews 6:2](#); [11:35](#); [1 Peter 1:21](#); [3:18](#), [21](#); [Revelation 20:4-8](#), [11-15](#)

## The Resurrection of the Dead

Jesus spoke about a future resurrection for everyone. God will raise up all people to eternal life or to judgment ([Mark 12:26-27](#); [John 5:28-29](#); [6:39-40](#), [44](#), [54](#); [11:25-26](#); see also [Luke 20:34-36](#)). When Jesus returns, all his followers will resurrect to be with him forever ([1 Thessalonians 4:13-18](#); see also [2 Corinthians 5:1-10](#)).

This strong hope defined the perspective of early Christians. They endured suffering by focusing on the life to come ([2 Corinthians 4:16-18](#); compare [Hebrews 12:2](#)). They expected Jesus to return,

resurrect their bodies, and anticipated living with him forever ([1 Peter 1:3-6](#), [23](#)). They based their faith on the foundation of Jesus' own bodily resurrection ([1 Corinthians 15:12-20](#); [Acts 4:33](#); see also [2 Corinthians 4:14](#)).

Resurrection bodies will be very different from the bodies we have now, which have limits and weaknesses. These new bodies will be like Christ's own resurrection body: glorious, strong, never dying, and spiritual ([1 Corinthians 15:35-58](#)).

Christians are already united to Christ, so they begin experiencing resurrection life now. They "were raised" with Christ and are "alive to God in Christ Jesus" ([Romans 6:4-11](#); [8:10-11](#); [Colossians 2:12](#)). Their lives now focus on spiritual realities of heaven, not worldly things ([Colossians 3:1-4](#)). Christians can experience the transforming power of this new life, which frees them from sin and death ([Romans 8:1-4](#)). In all challenges, they trust in God's resurrection power, not themselves ([2 Corinthians 1:9](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Job 19:25-27](#); [Psalms 16:10](#); [49:15](#); [Daniel 12:2-3](#); [Matthew 16:21](#); [28:1-10](#); [Mark 12:18-27](#); [John 3:13-16](#); [5:25-30](#); [6:39-40](#); [11:21-27](#); [Acts 2:23-24](#); [3:14-15](#); [4:33](#); [10:39-41](#); [17:2-3](#); [24:15](#); [26:22-23](#); [Romans 1:4](#); [4:25](#); [6:4-11](#); [8:10-11](#); [1 Corinthians 15:12-58](#); [2 Corinthians 1:8-9](#); [4:13-18](#); [5:1-10](#); [Ephesians 1:19-20](#); [Colossians 2:12](#); [3:1-4](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:13-18](#); [1 Peter 1:3-6](#), [23](#); [Revelation 20:11-15](#); [21:1-7](#); [22:1-6](#)

## The Return of God's Presence with His People

The descriptions of the Israelite exile include the terrible reality that, as part of his judgment, God removed his presence from his people and from the holy city of Jerusalem. This idea is most obviously present in a vision by the prophet Ezekiel. He saw God's glorious presence leaving the temple ([Ezekiel 10:1-22](#); [11:22-23](#)). The prophets talked about the future return of God's people to the land. They often mentioned the return of God's presence (see, for example, [Isaiah 52:7-8](#); [Ezekiel 43:1-9](#)).

The prophet Zechariah focused on the Lord returning to his people. He believed God would live among them again, and the Lord's glory would be in Jerusalem ([Zechariah 1:16](#); [2:5](#), [10-11](#); [8:3](#), [23](#)). God's presence would return when they rebuilt the temple. This would bring spiritual rebirth or

newness and plenty of crops ([1:17](#); [4:8-9](#); [6:15](#); see also [Haggai 2:19](#)).

In the future, God's presence would save Jerusalem and Israel from enemies. The Lord would be king over the earth. Everyone would worship the one true God ([Zechariah 9:16](#); [10:6](#); [12:9](#); [14:9](#)). Both now and in the future, the Lord's return to Jerusalem linked to the work of God's Spirit ([4:6](#); [12:10](#); see also [Haggai 2:5](#)).

Zechariah's promise of the Lord's presence in Jerusalem prophesied the arrival of Jesus the Messiah (God's chosen one). It emphasized the amazing mystery of God's Word becoming man and living among humanity ([John 1:14](#)).

#### Sections for Additional Review

[Genesis 26:3](#); [31:3](#); [Exodus 3:12](#); [Deuteronomy 31:23](#); [Joshua 1:5](#); [Judges 6:16](#); [Isaiah 7:14](#); [43:2](#); [52:8](#); [Ezekiel 37:27](#); [Joel 3:21](#); [Haggai 2:5](#); [Zechariah 1:16-17](#); [2:5](#), [10-11](#); [4:6](#); [8:3](#), [23](#); [14:9](#); [John 1:14](#)

## The Righteous Suffer

The book of Job invites readers to examine why we have faith in God. Job lost his possessions, family, and friends. This deeply tested his faith. Yet, he kept trusting God and proved that when Satan accused him, Satan was wrong.

Sin causes suffering, but the book of Job shows that suffering is not always because of a person's sin. Human suffering is more complex than just behavior and consequence. Some people today wrongly believe that being godly leads to material wealth, like Job's friends did. This view has problems, as history shows. There are many examples of righteous people who suffer, including Jesus Christ.

Scripture tells us that Christians must also share in Christ's suffering. It says "our present sufferings are not comparable to the glory that will be revealed in us" ([Romans 8:17-18](#)). Being a disciple of Christ means being willing to follow him into suffering (see [Luke 9:23-25](#); [Philippians 3:10-11](#)).

Even in his complaints, Job recognized that only God could provide the answers he needed. When Job wished for death, he sought relief until God could deal him under better conditions ([Job 14:13](#)). When Job wanted "a mediator," it was to help him find favor with God ([9:33-35](#)). When Job complained that God did not listen, it was because

he knew his answers had to come from God (see [19:25-27](#)). This is essential to faith.

We cannot know or understand everything (see [Genesis 2:16-17](#); [Deuteronomy 29:29](#); [Acts 1:7](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:1-2](#)). Some things are for God alone to understand and guide according to his will. We should live by faith. Even when we suffer, we can trust God (see [Romans 8:26-39](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 4:4-8](#); [26:17-33](#); [31:38-42](#); [37:2-36](#); [39:1-20](#); [Exodus 1:8-11](#); [1 Samuel 18:10-11](#), [28-29](#); [19:10](#); [22:1-19](#); [1 Kings 21:1-15](#); [2 Chronicles 24:20-22](#); [Job 9:33-35](#); [14:13](#); [19:25-27](#); [Isaiah 54:17](#); [Jeremiah 11:18-21](#); [26:1-23](#); [38:1-13](#); [Matthew 23:29-37](#); [John 5:24](#); [15:20](#); [Acts 6:8-7:60](#); [Romans 8:17-18](#), [26-39](#); [Hebrews 12:1-13](#); [1 Peter 4:12-16](#)

## The Secret of the Messiah

In the Gospel of Mark, Jesus often tells people not to reveal his true identity as the Messiah (God's chosen one). This includes:

- those Jesus healed or raised from the dead,
- the disciples who knew Jesus was the Christ (the Greek word for Messiah), and
- the demons who understood Jesus' true identity (see [Mark 1:34](#), [44](#); [3:11-12](#); [5:43](#); [7:36](#); [8:29-30](#); [9:9](#)).

This theme (often called the "Messianic Secret") appears less often in the Gospels of Matthew and Luke (see [Matthew 8:4](#); [16:20](#); [Luke 9:21](#)). Why did Jesus command those he healed and those who knew his true identity to keep both his healing miracles and his identity a secret?

One possibility relates to how the Roman authorities would have reacted. During his earthly ministry, Jesus was a very popular preacher who announced the arrival of God's kingdom. He miraculously healed people and allowed his followers to call him Israel's long-awaited Messiah and King.

Roman authorities would not allow this. They would quickly try to stop such a movement. In the Roman Empire, there was no room for another kingdom or messianic rescuer within Roman rule.

Therefore, even though Jesus told his disciples he was the Christ, he did not plan to lead a political revolution against Rome ([Mark 8:27-30](#)).

Another reason Jesus might have wanted to keep his true identity secret might be the widely misunderstood identity of Jesus in the Gospel of Mark. There was a misunderstanding even among his closest followers. Jesus makes it clear that his role as Messiah, the Son of God, is directly related to his suffering and death. This reality did not match Jewish expectations of the Messiah.

Right after the apostle Peter declares Jesus as the Christ (the Messiah), Jesus announces he will suffer and die ([Mark 8:27-31](#)). Peter's response shows he does not understand ([8:32-33](#)). Jesus' miracles and deep teaching were important, but his death as a sacrifice was the most important part of his role as the Messiah.

For these reasons, Jesus found it wise to teach about God's kingdom using parables. Parables are stories that have symbolic meanings (see [Mark 4:1-34](#), especially [4:10-12](#)). This approach helped reduce the excitement caused by his miracles ([1:44](#); [5:43](#); [7:36](#); [8:26](#)). It also allowed him to hide his presence at times from the people ([7:24](#); [9:30-31](#)). He kept his teachings hidden from outsiders ([4:10-12](#), [33-34](#); [7:17](#)). He instructed those who knew his true identity not to reveal it ([Mark 1:23-26](#), [34](#); [3:11-12](#); [8:29-30](#); [9:9](#)). Jesus came "to give his life as a ransom for many" ([10:45](#)). He did not come to lead the nation of Israel in a rebellion against Rome.

But Jesus Christ, the Son of God, could not be hidden ([Mark 1:1](#)). The secret was impossible to keep because Jesus is too important ([7:36](#)). Those who experienced his healing and saw him heal others could not stop sharing what he did. Jesus's identity became clear, and people realized he is truly the Messiah, the Son of God, the one with power over nature, sickness, and death. For readers and hearers of the Gospel of Mark who learn of his identity in the first verse, Jesus proved to be the Messiah because of (not in spite of) his suffering, death, and resurrection.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 8:4](#); [16:20](#); [Mark 1:34](#), [44](#); [3:11-12](#); [5:43](#); [7:36](#); [8:29-30](#); [9:9](#), [30-31](#); [Luke 9:21](#)

## The Servant-Leader

A servant-leader is a person who has a strong desire to achieve a goal by helping and serving others. This type of leader desires to take on the role of a servant rather than focusing on their own authority or status.

The Old Testament describes Moses as the Lord's servant ([Exodus 14:31](#); [Numbers 12:7-8](#)). Moses did not seek power, fame, or material gain. He hesitated to assume his leadership role. He used his prophetic authority with humility ([Numbers 12:3](#)). He knew he was under God's authority (see [Deuteronomy 34:10-12](#); [Hosea 12:13](#)).

From the time God called him, every event in Moses' story shows that he regarded his leadership as service to God. He submitted to God, did not care for himself, and was faithful. The way he acted toward the Israelites showed concern, a desire to persuade, and vision. Moses took a leadership role at a critical moment in Israelite history and often prayed or interceded for the people. He humbly submitted to God, which was the foundation of his great leadership.

Jesus of Nazareth is the perfect servant-leader. The gospels show Jesus as the Lord's "suffering servant" (see [Isaiah 52:13-53:12](#)). This was especially shown through his sacrificial death, the ultimate act of service ([Mark 10:45](#)). Jesus spoke with great authority but with humility. He knew his role was like a shepherd who "lays down His life for the sheep" ([John 10:11](#)).

He spent time with children and used them as examples for those who want to fully follow God ([Matthew 18:4](#)). When James and John asked for important positions in his kingdom, Jesus criticized their worldly ambition ([Mark 10:35-45](#)). He corrected them by teaching them to follow his example as a servant ([Matthew 20:24-28](#); [23:11-12](#); [Mark 10:43-45](#)). As a model for all who want to lead others through a life of service, Jesus knew his purpose was to bring glory to God's name ([John 12:27-28](#)).

The apostles Paul and Peter followed Christ's example and lived according to his ideal of servant leadership. Paul's life of service showed humility and self-sacrifice for others (see [2 Corinthians 11:23-28](#)). He taught Christians to do the same ([Romans 8:17](#); [Galatians 5:13](#); [2 Timothy 1:8](#); [2:3](#)). He praised those who did (for example, [Philippians 2:25-30](#); [Colossians 4:7](#)).

Peter also showed self-sacrificial service for Christ (for example, [Acts 3:1-11](#); [4:13-22](#); [5:12-16](#); [9:32-42](#)). His instructions plainly define the character of a servant-leader ([1 Peter 4:10-11](#); [5:1-5](#)).

### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 13:8-12](#); [14:11-24](#); [30:31-32](#); [Exodus 14:31](#); [Numbers 12:3](#), [7-8](#); [Deuteronomy 34:10-12](#); [1 Kings 12:1-7](#); [Isaiah 52:13-53:12](#); [Matthew 18:4](#); [20:24-28](#); [23:11-12](#); [Mark 10:35-45](#); [John 10:11](#); [12:27-28](#); [Acts 3:1-11](#); [4:13-22](#); [5:12-16](#); [9:32-42](#); [Romans 8:17](#); [2 Corinthians 11:23-27](#); [Galatians 5:13](#); [Philippians 2:25-30](#); [Colossians 4:7](#); [2 Timothy 1:8](#); [2:3](#); [1 Peter 4:10-11](#); [5:1-5](#)

## The Seventy Sets of Seven

The "seventy weeks" (or sevens) in [Daniel 9:24-27](#) have always been difficult to understand. Although it is difficult to connect them to a specific historical period, these "seventy sets of seven" are important. They show God's control over history and emphasize his power to fulfill his plans for his people. The number seventy is seven times ten. This symbolizes completeness. For instance, the seventy years of exile for God's people were enough time to discipline them ([9:2](#)).

Here are the two main ways people understand the seventy sets of seven:

1. **THE RULE OF ANTIOCHUS IV (175-163 BC).** According to this view, the seventy sets of seven is a time period that begins with Cyrus II of Persia and ends with Antiochus IV. Cyrus II (also known as Cyrus the Great) was the king of Persia who ruled from 559 to around 530 BC. In 539 BC, Cyrus allowed the Jewish people to return to their homeland (see [9:25](#); [Ezra 1:2-4](#)). Antiochus IV was a Greek king who ruled over Syria and the surrounding areas from 175 to 163 BC (see [Daniel 8:23-25](#); [11:21-39](#)).

In this understanding of the seventy sets of seven, "the Messiah" (or chosen one) was the high priest Onias III, and the "prince" was Antiochus IV ([9:26-27](#)). Antiochus made a treaty with the people of Judea in 174 BC, allowing them to practice their faith peacefully. But in 170 BC, Antiochus attacked Jerusalem, killed many, and stole from the temple.

Then, in 167 BC, Antiochus ended the sacrifices and offerings. He forced the Jews to abandon their faith under threat of death. He made the temple ceremonially unclean with "the abomination of desolation" (something that showed disrespect for God and his holy temple).

Antiochus placed a statue of the Greek god Zeus on the altar of burnt offering. He also sacrificed pigs on the altar and other ceremonially unclean animals (compare [11:21-35](#)).

God punished Antiochus with a painful disease, and Antiochus died in 163 BC. "The decreed destruction" was "poured out on him" ([9:27](#); see also [8:25](#); 1 Maccabees 1:10-24; 6:7-16; 2 Maccabees 9:1-29).

According to this view, when Jesus spoke of the "the abomination of desolation," he referred to the Jews' experience during Antiochus's time as a model for future events (see [Matthew 24:15](#); compare [Luke 21:20](#);

[2 Thessalonians 2:3-4](#)).

2. **THE DEATH OF JESUS CHRIST (AD 30 or 33).** According to this view, the seventy weeks are a prophecy about Jesus Christ, the Messiah (God's chosen one). People who support this view think the seventy sets of seven began with Cyrus's decree in 539 BC ([Ezra 1:1-4](#)). Or, it may have begun with one of the decrees given to Nehemiah in either 458 or 445 BC ([Ezra 7:8-26](#); [Nehemiah 2:1-10](#)). Jesus may have died at the end of sixty-nine sets of seven (seven plus sixty-two, [Daniel 9:25-26](#)). Or, it may have been halfway through the seventieth year ([9:27](#)).

These two options affect how the seventy sets of seven conclude. In the first option, the seventieth set of seven is a future event not yet fulfilled. In the second option, the seventieth set of seven finished when the Romans destroyed Jerusalem and the temple in AD 70. If Cyrus's decree is the starting point, the 490 years are symbolic. Yet, if the decree given to Nehemiah in 445 BC to rebuild the city is the starting point, then nearly 483 years (69 times 7 years) passed between that date and Jesus' death in AD 30 or 33 (see [Nehemiah 2:1](#); [Daniel 9:25](#)).

Scholars have two different ways of explaining what happened to the seventieth set of seven years:

3. *The Seventieth Set of Seven is Yet to Occur.* Many interpreters believe that Jesus' death happened at the end of the sixty-ninth set of seven. They think the seventieth set of sevens has not yet happened. This means there is a long gap between the sixty-ninth and seventieth sets. The seventieth set is still in the future and links to the antichrist's rule during the final troubles (the tribulation) at the end of history (see [2 Thessalonians 2:3-12](#); [1 John 2:18-22](#); [4:3](#); [2 John 1:7](#); [Revelation 13:1](#), [5](#); [16:13-14](#); [17:11](#); [19:20-21](#); [20:10](#)).
4. *The Seventieth Set of Seven Completed When Rome Destroyed Jerusalem and the Temple.* Some interpreters believe the seventy weeks ended with the coming of Jesus, his death and resurrection, and the destruction of Jerusalem and the temple in AD 70. In this view, Jesus started his ministry at the end of the sixty-ninth set of seven, around AD 28. He ministered for about three and a half years and died in the middle of the seventieth seven. The remaining half-seven concluded when the "prince" (one or more Roman leaders) destroyed Jerusalem and its temple in AD 70. The conflict and suffering between God's people and the world's kingdom continue until the end. This is when Jesus will return, judge the wicked, and establish his kingdom.

[Passages for Further Study](#)

[Daniel 7:8, 11, 20-21, 24-27; 8:9-14; 9:24-27; 11:29-31, 40-45; 12:7, 11; 2 Thessalonians 2:3-12; 1 John 2:18-22; 4:3; 2 John 1:7; Revelation 13:1, 5; 16:13-14; 17:11; 19:20-21; 20:10](#)

## The Shepherd

In ancient Jewish society, shepherds who cared for sheep or goats were important. Shepherding was essential in the ancient Near East. Each morning, the shepherd led the flock out ([John 10:2-4](#)). He found grass and water and protected them from wild animals ([Amos 3:12](#)). He searched for and returned any of the flock that wandered off ([Ezekiel 34:8; Matthew 18:12](#)). He returned the flock to the pen every evening.

The word *shepherd* became a common term for a ruler. People often referred to the kings of Assyria, Babylon, and Egypt as shepherds because they protected their people. This metaphor is also common in the Old Testament ([Numbers 27:17; 1 Kings 22:17; Jeremiah 10:21; 23:1-2; Ezekiel 34:1-10](#)).

The Old Testament regards God as the "Shepherd of Israel," caring for every part of his people's well-being ([Genesis 49:24; Psalms 23:1; 80:1; Isaiah 40:11](#)). God himself would take care of his flock ([Jeremiah 23:3; 31:10; Ezekiel 34:11-22](#)). He promised to provide faithful leaders who cared for his people ([Jeremiah 3:15; 23:4](#)).

When Israel's early leaders were unfaithful, God took action and chose his servant David as a faithful leader. He later promised to establish David's descendants as leaders over Israel (see [Ezekiel 34:23-24](#)). By the time of the prophet Jeremiah, *shepherd* began to refer to the coming Messiah (God's chosen one).

In the New Testament, Jesus called himself "the Shepherd" ([Matthew 25:31-33; Mark 14:27; John 10:1-30](#)). He is the "Good Shepherd" who sacrifices his life for the sheep ([John 10:11-18](#); see also [Hebrews 13:20](#)).

The church leaders are also known as shepherds ([Ephesians 4:11](#), translated as "pastors"). God gives them to the church to care for his people like a shepherd cares for sheep, guiding and teaching them in God's ways. They must remain faithful shepherds until Jesus Christ, "the Chief Shepherd," comes to lead his people directly ([1 Peter 5:1-4](#)).

### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 29:1-10; Numbers 27:16-18; 2 Samuel 7:7; 1 Kings 22:17; 1 Chronicles 11:2; Psalms 23:1-6; 77:20; 80:1; Isaiah 40:11; 44:28; 56:10-11; Jeremiah 10:21; 25:34-36; Ezekiel 34:1-31; Micah 7:14; Zechariah 10:2b-3; 11:4-17; 13:7; Matthew 2:6; 18:12-14; 26:31; John 10:1-16; 1 Peter 2:25; 5:1-4; Jude 1:12; Revelation 7:17](#)

## The Son of God

Jesus' healings, exorcisms (casting out demons), raising the dead, and teachings resulted in wonder, awe, amazement, and fear (for example, [Mark 1:22, 27; 4:41; 5:15, 20, 33; 7:37; 9:15; 10:24, 26, 32; 12:17; 15:5](#)). This amazement emphasizes the miraculous nature of Jesus' ministry. The Gospel writers wanted readers to ask, "What kind of man is this? Even the winds and the sea obey Him!" ([Matthew 8:27; Mark 4:41; Luke 8:25](#)). Mark answers this at the start of his Gospel: Jesus is the "Christ, the Son of God" ([Mark 1:1](#)).

In the Old Testament, the title "Son of God" refers to the people of Israel ([Exodus 4:22; Deuteronomy 32:5-6, 18-19; Psalm 82:6; Jeremiah 3:19; 31:9, 20; Hosea 11:1; Malachi 2:10](#)). It can refer to angels ([Genesis 6:2; Job 1:6; 2:1; 38:7; Psalm 29:1](#)). It also has a special meaning for Israel's king, as they regarded the anointed king as God's "son" ([2 Samuel 7:14; 1 Chronicles 22:10; 28:6; Psalms 2:7; 89:26-27](#)).

The title also appears in Jewish writings between the Old and New Testaments (including the Apocrypha and the Dead Sea Scrolls). It possibly refers to the coming Messiah (God's chosen one). Jews in the first century likely considered the coming Messiah as a "Son of God."

God confirmed Jesus as "the Son of God" at his baptism ([Mark 1:11; Matt 3:17; Luke 3:22](#)). Demons also recognized him during his ministry ([Matthew 8:29; Mark 1:24; 1:34; 3:11; 5:7; Luke 4:34; 8:28](#)). Later, the disciples acknowledged Jesus as the Christ ([Matthew 16:16; Mark 8:29; Luke 9:20](#)). Jesus then began teaching them about his coming death ([Matthew 16:21; Mark 8:31; Luke 9:22](#)).

At the transfiguration, Jesus' appearance changed to reveal his glory as God's Son, and God confirmed what the disciples had said about Jesus ([Matthew 17:5; Mark 9:7; Luke 9:35](#)). As Jesus neared his death, he affirmed his identity as God's Son through

his teachings and during his trial ([Mark 12:1-12](#); [13:32](#); [Mark 14:61-62](#)).

At Jesus' death on the cross, something powerful happened. A Roman soldier (called a centurion) who watched Jesus die was the first person in the story to acknowledge Jesus as "the Son of God" ([Mark 15:39](#)). Earlier in the Gospels, people had seen Jesus was God's Son when he drove out evil spirits, and God himself had announced Jesus as his Son. But it was Jesus' willing death on the cross, and the way he died, that showed most clearly that he was truly God's Son ([Mark 15:33-39](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 4:22](#); [Deuteronomy 32:5-6](#); [2 Samuel 7:14](#); [1 Chronicles 22:10](#); [28:6](#); [Psalms 2:7](#); [89:26-27](#); [Jeremiah 3:19](#); [31:9](#), [20](#); [Matthew 26:63-68](#); [Mark 1:1](#), [11](#), [24](#); [4:35-41](#); [8:31](#); [9:7](#); [12:1-12](#); [14:61-62](#); [15:32-39](#); [Luke 1:32-35](#); [4:41](#); [John 1:18](#); [3:16-17](#), [35-36](#); [5:19-26](#); [17:5](#), [24](#); [20:31](#); [Acts 13:33](#); [Romans 1:4](#); [5:10](#); [8:3](#), [32](#); [2 Corinthians 1:19](#); [Galatians 2:20](#); [4:4-5](#); [Ephesians 4:13](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:10](#); [Hebrews 1:2-14](#); [3:6](#); [5:5](#); [1 John 1:3](#); [2:22](#); [3:23](#); [4:9-10](#), [14](#); [5:20](#); [2 John 1:3](#), [9](#); [Revelation 2:18](#)

## The Son of Man

"Son of Man" was Jesus' favorite way to refer to himself. The phrase is unusual in both Greek and English. It translates the Hebrew phrase *ben 'adam*, which means "human being" or "person" (see, for example, [Ezekiel 2:1-8](#)). Jesus liked this name because it did not cause debates like the titles "Christ" or "Messiah."

The Gospels use the expression in three ways:

1. The background to Jesus' use of the title comes from [Daniel 7:13-14](#). In this passage, a messianic figure "like a son of man" (meaning "like a human") arrives with the clouds of heaven and receives great glory and power. Jesus saw himself as the one who would return to earth in the clouds of heaven (see [Mark 8:38](#); [13:26](#); [14:62](#)). Sometimes, Jesus used "Son of Man" to describe his role as judge, deliverer, savior, and the one who rights wrongs ([Matthew 10:23](#); [13:41](#); [16:27](#); [19:28](#); [24:27](#), [30](#), [37](#), [44](#); [25:31](#); [26:64](#)).
2. Jesus often called himself the "Son of Man" to show he was a suffering redeemer ([Matthew 12:40](#); [17:9](#), [12](#), [22](#); [20:18](#), [28](#); [26:2](#), [24](#), [45](#)). This idea comes from [Isaiah 52:13-53:12](#).
3. Sometimes, Jesus used "Son of Man" to describe himself as a representative of humans ([Matthew 8:20](#); [11:19](#); [12:8](#), [32](#); [13:37](#)). The book of Ezekiel uses "son of man" in a similar way (again see, [Ezekiel 2:1-8](#)).

Jesus did not use "Son of Man" to separate his humanity from his divinity as "Son of God" sometimes does. By using this title, Jesus defined himself as the Messiah or Christ (God's chosen one) on his own terms. He used "Son of Man" to describe his complete identity and implied that those who watched and listened should recognize who he is.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Ezekiel 2:1-8](#); [3:1](#), [4](#), [10](#), [17](#), [25](#); [4:1](#); [Daniel 7:13-14](#); [8:17](#); [Matthew 8:18-22](#); [9:6](#); [10:23](#); [11:19](#); [12:8](#), [32](#), [40](#); [13:37](#), [41](#); [16:13](#), [27-28](#); [17:9](#), [12](#), [22](#); [19:28](#); [20:18](#), [28](#); [24:27](#), [30](#), [37-39](#), [44](#); [25:31](#); [26:2](#), [24](#), [45](#), [64](#); [Mark 2:10](#); [John 1:51](#); [3:13-14](#); [5:27](#); [6:27](#), [53](#), [62](#); [8:28](#); [9:35](#); [12:23](#), [34](#); [13:31](#); [Acts 7:56](#); [Hebrews 2:6](#); [Revelation 1:13](#); [14:14](#)

## The Sovereignty of God

People often think they can control everything that happens in their lives through their own choices and actions. But the Bible teaches us something different. It shows us that God has the highest power and authority over all things (see, for

example, [Deuteronomy 4:39](#); [Psalms 135:5-7](#); [Isaiah 46:8-11](#); [Jude 1:24-25](#)). While our choices and actions have real consequences, God's will (what God wants and plans) is much more important (see [James 4:13-16](#)).

God guides and controls everything that happens. We call this the sovereignty of God. God rules over the lives of all people ([Psalm 135:5-12](#)). God also controls the entire universe and everything that happens in the world's history ([Isaiah 40:15-17](#); [Acts 17:24](#); [Colossians 1:15-20](#)). God directs everything to his planned outcomes ([Isaiah 46:10](#); [Daniel 7:27-28](#); [Matthew 24:14-31](#); [Revelation 1:7-8](#)).

In 2 Kings, God shows his power over nations. He chose and removed the kings of Israel and Judah based on His plans and their obedience. He allowed attacks on his people as punishment for their sins ([2 Kings 8:18-22](#)). God was in control when the Assyrians attacked Samaria and defeated the northern kingdom ([17:1-6](#), [18](#), [20](#)). King Hezekiah succeeded in Judah because of the Lord's blessings ([18:5-7](#)). God's influence is obvious in the complex international events during the rules of Judah's last kings, as he promised ([23:26-27](#)).

God shows his power by answering the prayers and requests of his people. When the Elisha prayed, God answered his faithful prophet. Through Elisha, God allowed the woman from Shunem to have a son and later brought that son back to life ([2 Kings 4:17](#), [32-35](#)). The Lord kindly answered King Jehoahaz's prayers and sent a rescuer for troubled Israel ([13:4-5](#)). He honored King Hezekiah's prayers for Jerusalem and for his own life ([19:1-7](#); [20:1-6](#)).

Paul shows that God decides the path of salvation. Paul often explains the surprising events in salvation history by referring to God's words and actions. Human choices alone cannot explain the situation. God has said, "I will have mercy on whom I have mercy" ([Romans 9:15](#)). Theologians will keep debating God's role and human choice in salvation, but God's control is evident.

Because God is sovereign, his people should try to live in harmony with his will ([Romans 12:1-2](#)). They should use the strength he provides (see [1 Corinthians 1:8-9](#)). We can follow Christ's example in his prayer, "Yet not as I will, but as You will" ([Matthew 26:39](#)). Today, many people ignore God's influence in human affairs. Yet, God's decisions guide the world and the lives of those who trust him.

When we live for God's glory, everything that happens is ultimately for our good ([Isaiah 42:8](#); [Habakkuk 2:14](#); [Jude 1:24-25](#); [Psalm 84:11](#); [Ephesians 3:16-19](#); [Colossians 1:27](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:11-12](#)). We can confidently say that "God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose" ([Romans 8:28](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 8:22](#); [9:29](#); [Deuteronomy 4:39](#); [32:8](#), [39](#); [Joshua 2:11](#); [1 Samuel 2:6-8](#); [2 Kings 13:4-5](#); [17:1-6](#), [18-20](#); [18:5-7](#); [19:5-7](#); [20:4-6](#); [Psalms 24:1-2](#); [84:11](#); [135:5-12](#); [Isaiah 40:15-17](#); [45:7](#); [46:10](#); [Jeremiah 27:5-7](#); [Daniel 7:27-28](#); [Habakkuk 2:14](#); [John 19:11](#); [Acts 17:24-26](#); [Romans 8:28](#); [9:5-24](#); [1 Corinthians 1:8-9](#); [Colossians 1:15-20](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:11-12](#); [Jude 1:24-25](#); [Revelation 1:7-8](#)

## The Spirit of the Law

When King Hezekiah wanted to celebrate Passover, he had a problem. Passover is a feast marking Israel's freedom from slavery in Egypt and is the first feast of Israel's religious year ([Exodus 12:1-2](#)). Hezekiah intended to restore Israel's worship of the Lord. Yet, the time between starting his renewal efforts and the first month of the year was too short. The priests did not have enough time to prepare and gather the people ([2 Chronicles 30:2-3](#)). As a result, he could not celebrate Passover at the usual time.

Hezekiah held the Passover a month late ([2 Chronicles 30:15](#)). He believed celebrating was more important than the timing. By delaying, he gave people time to gather at the temple in Jerusalem. This brought harmony between Judah and the northern kingdom and unified the celebration.

Following precise regulations was less important than guaranteeing everyone could celebrate Passover. When the feast began, many people had not properly purified themselves. So they could not slaughter their own sacrifices as the law required.

Hezekiah decided participation in Passover was more important than strict obedience to regulations. He prayed for the pilgrims who could not prepare properly. Although they could not make sacrifices without being pure, they could still participate in Passover. Having the right attitude and seeking the Lord in prayer led to God's

gracious acceptance ([2 Chronicles 30:18-20](#); see also [1 Corinthians 11:27-34](#)).

Religious leaders often criticized Jesus for not following all aspects of the law. They especially were concerned about the Sabbath and purity. Jesus taught that showing love to others was more important than following every detail of the law. He also criticized religious leaders for focusing too much on the details of the law instead of the principles behind them. While strict obedience to the law was key to Jewish identity, the spirit of the law allowed some flexibility in certain situations.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 12:1-30](#); [2 Kings 5:17-19](#); [2 Chronicles 30:1-27](#); [Matthew 15:21-28](#); [John 8:1-11](#); [Romans 3:23-28](#); [1 Corinthians 11:27-34](#); [Hebrews 9:13-15](#); [James 5:16](#)

## The Spirit's Presence

In the Old Testament, the Spirit of the Lord came to people or groups when God gave them a task or chose them for a role. The Spirit empowered judges like Othniel, Gideon, and Jephthah for their duties ([Judges 3:10](#); [6:34](#); [11:29](#)). Saul and David received the Spirit of God when anointed as kings ([1 Samuel 10:1](#); [9-10](#); [16:13](#)).

The Spirit left when the task ended or the person lost their role. When Samuel anointed David as the next king, the Spirit left Saul ([16:13, 14](#)). This was because he was disobedient and God rejected him as king ([13:7-14](#); [15:10-29](#); compare [28:15](#); [Judges 16:20](#)). After David sinned with Bathsheba, he prayed to avoid the same judgment, "take not Your Holy Spirit from me" ([Psalm 51:11](#)).

In the New Testament, God's Holy Spirit is given to everyone who trusts in Jesus for salvation, not just to those in specific roles (see [Acts 2:14-21](#); [1 Corinthians 12:1-13](#); [Ephesians 1:13-14](#)). The Spirit helps God's servants do the work they are called to do (see [1 Corinthians 12:7-10](#)). The Old Testament story of the Spirit leaving Saul shows why the New Testament warns against sinning against the Spirit and causing him sorrow (see [Mark 3:28-29](#); [Ephesians 4:30](#); [Hebrews 6:1-8](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 41:37-40](#); [Exodus 31:1-6](#); [Judges 3:9-11](#); [Judges 6:34](#); [Judges 11:29](#); [Judges 14:5-6](#); [Judges 16:20-21](#); [1 Samuel 10:1-10](#); [1 Samuel 11:6-7](#); [1 Samuel 16:13-23](#); [1 Samuel 19:19-23](#); [2 Chronicles](#)

[20:13-19](#); [2 Chronicles 24:20-22](#); [Psalm 51:11-12](#); [Isaiah 11:1-5](#); [Jeremiah 31:33-34](#); [Joel 2:28-29](#); [Mark 3:28-29](#); [Acts 2:1-21](#); [Acts 4:31](#); [Ephesians 1:13-14](#); [Ephesians 4:30](#); [Hebrews 6:4-8](#)

## The Stone the Builders Rejected

Jesus continually offended the Jewish leaders and their followers. Although he was from the family line of King David, they questioned his mother's reputation ([Matthew 1:18-25](#)). Jesus came from Nazareth ([Matthew 2:23](#)). This place did not have a good reputation either ([Matthew 13:53-58](#)). He mainly worked in Galilee, far from the center of Jewish authority ([Matthew 4:12-16](#)). His closest friend was John, who became known for baptizing people and boldly speaking against political leaders as a prophet ([Matthew 11:2-19](#); [14:3-12](#)).

Jesus often gave indirect answers ([Matthew 13:10-15](#); [17:24-27](#); [19:3-12](#); [21:23-27](#)). He refused to show miraculous signs to prove his claims ([12:38-42](#); [16:1-4](#)). He spent time with people whom society rejected ([9:9-13](#); [11:16-19](#)). He challenged Jewish customs ([5:17-20](#); [9:14-17](#); [12:1-14](#); [15:1-20](#); [21:12-13](#)). He avoided public recognition ([8:4](#); [12:15-21](#)).

He shared his insights with unexpected people ([Matthew 11:25-27](#); [13:16-17](#); [16:13-20](#)). He spoke about the humiliating death he would suffer ([16:21](#); [17:22-23](#); [20:18-19](#); [26:2](#)). Jesus did not seek attention or make his role obvious. Instead, he chose humility, privacy, and sharing revelations that people could only understand through faith.

In the end, Jesus was proven right. He won arguments ([Luke 20:20-40](#)). He removed demons who had control of people ([Matthew 8:28-34](#)). He healed people in amazing ways ([Matthew 9:1-8](#)). He resurrected people from the dead ([Matthew 9:18-26](#)). Finally, he rose from the dead ([Matthew 28:1-10](#)). His ministry caused division but was effective in beginning God's kingdom on earth ([Matthew 11:2-6](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 3:8](#); [8:14-15](#); [28:12-13](#); [59:9-10](#); [Jeremiah 13:16](#); [20:11](#); [31:7-9](#); [50:31-32](#); [Hosea 4:4-6](#); [5:5](#); [14:9](#); [Malachi 2:7-9](#); [Matthew 11:5-6](#); [13:54-58](#); [17:27](#); [21:42-46](#); [Mark 6:3](#); [Luke 20:17-19](#); [John 6:60-69](#); [Romans 9:30-33](#); [11:7-12](#); [14:12-13](#); [20-21](#); [1 Corinthians 1:21-23](#); [8:9-13](#); [10:31-11:1](#); [2 Corinthians 6:3](#); [Galatians 5:11](#); [1 Peter 2:5-8](#); [1 John 2:10](#)

## The Suffering Prophet

In the Gospels, Jesus has many titles, such as Messiah (or Christ), Son of David, Son of Man, Son of God, and Lord. In Luke, an important title is "Prophet." Jesus is the prophet Moses predicted in [Deuteronomy 18:15](#).

As a prophet, Jesus preached God's word and performed miracles like the great prophets of the Old Testament. When Jesus raised a widow's son, the people exclaimed, "A great prophet has appeared among us!" ([Luke 7:16](#)). The disciples told Jesus that people were calling him a prophet ([Matthew 16:13-14](#)). The disciples on the road to Emmaus described him as "a prophet, powerful in speech and action before God and all the people" ([Luke 24:19](#)).

Like other prophets, Jesus suffered for his message (see [1 Kings 19:1-18](#); [Jeremiah 11:18-19](#); [18:18](#); [20:1-2](#), [7-18](#); [26:7-11](#), [20-23](#); [38:1-6](#)). People connected Jesus' role as a prophet to his miracles and teaching. But Jesus linked it mainly to his suffering. In Nazareth, he stated that "no prophet is accepted in his hometown" ([Luke 4:24](#)). He later accused Israel's leaders of killing their prophets ([11:47-51](#)). As he traveled to Jerusalem, he said, "it is not admissible for a prophet to perish outside of Jerusalem" ([13:33](#)).

In the Old Testament, when Israel ignored God's prophets, divine judgment came. Similarly, God's people would encounter judgment if they did not listen to Jesus (see [Acts 3:22-23](#)).

The revelation that Jesus is the Messiah (God's chosen one) shows he is the savior for all people. His role as a prophet shows his message is from God. His words are truly God's words, which people must hear and follow.

### Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 18:15](#); [Matthew 5:12](#); [23:34-37](#); [Luke 4:22-24](#); [6:23](#), [26](#); [7:16](#); [11:47-52](#); [13:33-34](#); [24:17-21](#); [Acts 3:22-23](#); [7:37](#), [52](#)

## The Superiority of the Son

The book of Hebrews shows why Jesus, the Son of God, is greater than all others in who he is (his nature) and what he does (his ministry).

### Superior in Nature

The Son's superior *nature* is mainly discussed in [Hebrews 1:1-3:6](#). In the book's introduction ([1:1-4](#)), the Son is shown as the creator, supporter, and heir of the universe ([1:2-3](#)). He is "the radiance of God's glory and the exact representation of His nature" ([1:3](#)). He is honored, having cleansed sins and has a status "far superior to the angels" ([1:3-4](#)).

### Superior to Angels

In [Hebrews 1:5-14](#) and [2:5-18](#), the Son is shown to be greater than the angels. He has a special relationship with the Father ([1:5](#)). He is the ruler, creator, and he who changes of the created world ([1:8-12](#)). The angels have a lower status than him, and they worship him ([1:6-7](#)). God the Father raises him to the highest position of honor at his right hand ([1:13](#); [Psalm 110:1](#)). He has authority over everything ([Hebrews 2:5-8](#)).

### Superior to Moses

In [Hebrews 3:1-6](#), the author uses the respect his audience has for Moses to argue for even greater respect for the Son. Like Moses, the Son was faithful in serving God's people. Yet, the Son deserves more glory and praise than Moses because he has the same nature as God the Father. The Son is the ultimate builder of God's house ([3:3-4](#)). The Son is ultimately in charge of God's people ([3:5-6](#)).

### Superior Ministry

#### Superior Priest

The sections highlighting the Son's superior *ministry* are mainly in [Hebrews 7:1-10:18](#). Through his superior role as high priest, Jesus has introduced a "better hope" ([7:19](#)). "A better covenant" guarantees this hope ([7:22](#)). "Better promises" ground this hope ([8:6](#)). This allows him to perform a ministry "more excellent" than that of the old covenant priests ([8:6](#)). The old covenant was the agreement God made with the Israelites through Moses.

#### Superior Sacrifice

Jesus' ministry under the new covenant is a better system because of his "better sacrifices" ([9:10](#), [23](#); see also [12:24](#)). The new covenant is the new agreement God made through Jesus. Jesus' ministry leads new-covenant believers in God to expect "a better and permanent possession" ([10:34](#)). It is a

"better country, a heavenly one" ([11:16](#)). They will "gain a better resurrection" ([11:35](#)). For believers in Jesus under the new covenant, God has "planned something better" that old-covenant believers could only anticipate ([11:40](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 110:1](#); [Hebrews 1:1-14](#); [3:1-6](#); [7:1-10:18](#); [10:34](#); [11:16](#), [35](#), [40](#)

## **The Tabernacle**

The tabernacle was a portable sanctuary where God lived among the Israelite people. From the beginning of creation, God's plan was to share his life with humans and allow people to have a close relationship with him. However, when sin entered the world, it created a serious problem ([Genesis 3](#)). If sinful people were to come into God's presence, God's holiness would destroy them.

The tabernacle provided a temporary solution to this problem. It was a special structure like a tent that allowed the Israelites to enjoy God's presence without being destroyed by it ([Exodus 25:8](#)). It served as a mobile place of worship where Israel offered sacrifices to God and worshiped him.

The tabernacle shows us what is necessary to enter God's presence:

- The altar shows that sin must be removed through a sacrificial death. This was a large bronze structure where animals were sacrificed to pay for people's sins.
- The washbasin shows that having a relationship with God requires removing uncleanness—anything that goes against God's perfect moral standards. This was a large bronze bowl filled with water where priests washed their hands and feet before serving in the tabernacle.
- In the Holy Place, the lampstand and the table show that we must walk in God's light and depend on him to provide what we need. The golden lampstand had seven branches and provided the only light in the Holy Place, while the table held twelve loaves of bread representing God's provision for the twelve tribes of Israel.
- The incense altar represents prayer. The constantly rising incense reminds those who are forgiven and clean, who follow God's guidance and depend on him, that they have complete access to him. This small golden altar stood just before the curtain to the Most Holy Place, and priests burned sweet-smelling incense on it daily.
- The curtain between the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place reminds us that the Almighty, the holy God who invites us into fellowship, must not be approached carelessly. This thick, colorful veil separated the two rooms and protected people from God's direct presence.

- Behind the curtain is the ark of the covenant, over which God's glory appeared. This symbolized God's rule as Israel's king. The central position of the ark reflects God's main purpose for his people—a covenant relationship with the living God. The ark was a gold-covered wooden chest containing the stone tablets of the Ten Commandments, Aaron's rod, and a jar of manna.

Our new covenant relationship with God is possible because of Jesus' perfect sacrifice for sin and his role as our high priest before God (see especially [Hebrews 9–10](#)). He has fulfilled the requirements shown by the ancient tabernacle. We can now approach God's throne with courage and confidence (see [Ephesians 3:12](#); [Hebrews 4:14–16](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 25:1–9](#); [26:1–37](#); [35:4–36:38](#); [38:21–31](#); [39:32–40:35](#); [2 Chronicles 3:1–7:22](#); [Hebrews 9:1–28](#)

## **The Theater and Revelation**

In the ancient world, theater was a form of storytelling through live performances with actors, scenes, and dramatic presentations. Understanding the way ancient performances worked can help us understand [Revelation 4–5](#). These chapters introduce a divine drama (like a play with scenes and actors) and show the importance of God's agent (the Messiah) in world history. This passage prepares the reader for the main message of the book, which is about the world, the reality of judgment, and the victory that comes through the Lamb (Jesus). In these chapters, a series of scenes (like in a play) is used to communicate the message.

[Revelation 4:1–3](#) begins by describing God on his heavenly throne. In ancient theater, a person representing a god sat in a central box or throne high above the stage. This actor explained each scene's importance to the audience with positive and negative comments. Or he resolved script problems too complex for the characters. Similarly, readers of Revelation should look for scenes where God or his messengers interpret or interrupt to explain the message.

The ancient drama developed on the stage beneath the divine figure. Between the stage and the audience, a group of speakers expressed the play's emotions. In Revelation, the four living creatures have a similar role ([Revelation 4:6–8](#)).

The twenty-four elders represent the old and new covenants ([4:4](#)). (The "old covenant" refers to the agreement God made with Israel through Moses, which included the Ten Commandments and other laws recorded in the first books of the Bible. The "new covenant" refers to the agreement God made through Jesus Christ, which the New Testament describes as fulfilling the old covenant and establishing a new way of relating to God based on faith in Jesus.) The twenty-four elders act as a chorus with alternating groups of speakers and provide the historical background for this great drama. They also give the historical context for this great drama. God provides the script, and only his special agent, "the Lamb," can open, read, and perform it ([5:1–5](#); [6:1](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Revelation 4:1–5:14](#)

## **The Thousand Years (The Millennium)**

A millennium is 1,000 years. [Revelation 20](#) describes the 1,000-year rule of Jesus Christ on earth. Christian groups who highly respect Scripture as God's inspired and authoritative word have held three views on how this millennium relates to the second coming of Jesus:

1. *Premillennialism:* The time between Jesus' first and second comings will end when he returns. He will rule on earth for 1,000 years with his holy people. After this, Jesus will bring final judgment and establish his eternal kingdom. This view places Jesus' return before (pre-) the millennium.

2. *Amillennialism*: This is not a literal 1,000-year period. The "1,000 years" is symbolic and represents the current time between Jesus' first and second comings. During this period, Jesus rules spiritually with his people. At the end of this time, Jesus will return, bring final judgment, and begin his eternal kingdom. This view sees no (a-) separate millennium apart from the current church age.
3. *Postmillennialism*: During the time between Jesus' first and second comings, he will extend his rule through the church. This will lead to a long period of peace on earth. This period is the "1,000 years." At the end of this time, Jesus will return, carry out the final judgment, and establish his eternal kingdom. This view places Jesus' return after (post-) the millennium.

These different ideas have caused conflict among Christians. Many have abandoned Christian relations with those who hold different opinions. But Christians should show humility and love, not letting these differences divide them. (see [1 Peter 3:8](#)).

The main message of Revelation is that Jesus Christ will physically return and rule a new heaven and earth. A real spiritual battle is happening. Hell, like heaven, is real, and God will judge everyone by his standards. The prophecies of Revelation give hope to God's people during pain, suffering, and confusion in the world.

Passages for Further Study

[Revelation 20:1-10](#)

## The Unknown God

The apostle Paul spoke to the Areopagus, the high council of the city of Athens ([Acts 17:19](#)). He spoke to people who did not share his belief in the God of Abraham and Moses. This God had revealed himself, "On many past occasions and in many different ways... through the prophets" ([Hebrews 1:1](#)).

Paul's audience thought differently about religion than he did. They had many gods in their culture, and common people still believed in the ancient gods. Yet, many of the people who influenced the culture of Athens no longer believed the gods existed. Instead, they followed either *materialism* (the belief that only physical things exist) or *pantheism* (the belief that the divine is in everything).

They all lacked the belief in one true God who is Lord of all. Their myths described the actions of various gods, but they did not believe that the ultimate reality, God himself, could be known. Instead, they reasoned and discussed the latest ideas, hoping to better understand the nature of things.

When Paul visited Athens, many philosophical ideas were popular. Yet, Stoicism and Epicureanism were the two main schools of thought ([Acts 17:18](#)).

Stoicism was founded by Zeno of Citium, who lived from around 334 to 262 BC. Those who followed the teachings of Stoicism were called Stoics. The Stoics studied nature's laws and believed in the *Logos*, a force that organizes and sustains everything. This force gives life and reason to humans. A good life is one where reason leads, and peace of mind and harmony with nature exist. Many important ancient leaders were Stoics or influenced by Stoicism. This included Cicero, Seneca, and Marcus Aurelius. Some Christians found Stoic ideas appealing because of similarities between the Stoic *Logos* and the divine *Logos* and between natural law and God's law ([John 1:1-18](#)).

The Epicureans were people who followed the teachings of Epicurus, who lived from 341 to 270 BC. They were empiricists, which means they believed knowledge comes from what we can experience with our senses (like seeing, hearing, or touching) rather than from abstract reasoning. Epicureans focused on natural evidence and showed little interest in mathematics. Their main interest was ethics, the study of right behavior (morality). They judged actions or things by the pleasure or pain they caused. Epicurus viewed belief in gods as a threat to peace of mind. He and his followers believed that no one should fear either gods or death.

When Paul spoke, he used their poets to explain complex ideas. He said that the God who created everything is personal and able to be known. God showed himself clearly, in real history, and in a

complete way in Jesus Christ. After death, there is not an end or a journey of the soul, but only coming judgment. The resurrection of Jesus from the dead proves all these things.

Most Greeks in Athens thought it was foolish, but it is the ultimate truth. God can be known through Jesus Christ.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 50:7-15](#); [Isaiah 42:5-7](#); [Acts 17:16-32](#); [Romans 1:18-32](#); [Colossians 1:15-23](#); [Colossians 2:6-12](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:9-10](#); [Hebrews 1:1-4](#)

## The Word

The apostle John begins his Gospel with an extraordinary description of Jesus Christ as "the Word" (Greek *logos*, [John 1:1](#)). In the first century, both Greek and Jewish listeners would understand the deep meaning of this title.

Greeks would think of the fundamental forces that sustain the universe. Jews would remember God creating the world by speaking ([Genesis 1:3-28](#); [Psalm 33:6, 9](#)). In Jesus' time, the "Word" of God had gained creative personal qualities. Jews saw God's "Word" as another way of speaking about God's "Wisdom." Through Wisdom, God entered the universe, to create the world ([Proverbs 8:22-31](#)).

John explains that Jesus shares the same essence or nature as God. The Son existed before time and created everything. John connects the truth that Jesus is God to the ancient Jewish idea of Wisdom. This divine Wisdom, present with God before time, God now reveals in Jesus Christ. In a powerful verse, John writes that this Logos, or Wisdom, became a human person and lived among us ([John 1:14](#)). What God is, the Logos is, and the Logos is Jesus Christ.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:3-28](#); [Psalm 33:6, 9](#); [Proverbs 8:22-31](#); [Isaiah 40:8](#); [John 1:1-18](#); [1 John 1:1](#); [Revelation 19:13](#)

## The World

The book of John often uses the word "world" (Greek *kosmos*). In Greek-speaking Jewish thought, *kosmos* means the heavens and the earth created by God ([Genesis 1](#); see also [John 1:3, 10](#); [17:5, 24](#)). The

apostle John expands this idea to include humanity (for example, [1:10](#); [3:16](#)).

Although God created it as good, the human world now opposes God ([John 1:10-11](#); [3:19-20](#); [12:37-41](#)). People love the darkness and cannot understand the light, actively resisting it ([3:19](#)). The world is without life and needs life ([6:33, 51](#)). Yet, it hates the one who can save it ([7:7](#)). Satan is the "prince of this world" ([12:31](#)). But he will encounter judgment one day.

God loves humanity, even though people often oppose and rebel against him. Jesus died to remove the world's sin ([John 1:29](#); [3:16-17](#); [1 John 2:2](#)). Yet, God's love for his creation exists alongside his need to judge the sin in the world ([John 3:18-21, 36](#); [5:27-30](#); [12:47-48](#)). Followers of Jesus feel this same tension in their mission. God calls us to share his love with the world. But we will encounter conflict because the world may oppose our message (see [15:18-27](#); [17:13-26](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 6:11-12](#); [Psalms 2:1-6](#); [9:8](#); [Isaiah 61:11](#); [66:16](#); [Matthew 5:14](#); [13:38-40](#); [John 1:9-10](#); [3:16-19](#); [7:7](#); [8:12](#); [14:17-19](#); [15:18-19](#); [16:7-9, 33](#); [John 17:5-26](#); [Acts 17:31](#); [1 Corinthians 1:20-28](#); [3:3](#); [6:2](#); [2 Corinthians 5:19](#); [Ephesians 2:2](#); [Colossians 2:20](#); [James 4:4](#); [2 Peter 1:4](#); [2:20](#); [1 John 2:15-16](#); [4:3-5](#)

## The Worship of Angels

Scripture often describes angels as beings that inspire awe or fear (for example, [Joshua 5:13-15](#); [Luke 2:8-10](#)). Yet, angels serve God and he does not allow people to worship them ([Hebrews 1:5-14](#); [Revelation 19:10](#)). Jewish tradition developed the idea of angels as mediators (those who connect others to God). In pre-Christian Judaism, people emphasized God's *transcendence* or "otherness" so much that they believed mediators were necessary to communicate with him. In this context, angels became more important.

For Christians, Jesus has a unique role as mediator between God and humans. Focusing on angels or deceased saints as ways to communicate with God can distract from honoring Jesus as the only necessary mediator ([1 Timothy 2:5-6](#); see also [2 Corinthians 5:19-21](#); [Hebrews 7:24-25](#)). God still uses angelic messengers, but they are creatures serving him, not divine beings to worship. Only God deserves our prayers and worship.

### Passages for Further Study

[Acts 27:23–24](#); [2 Corinthians 5:19–21](#); [1 Timothy 2:5–6](#); [Hebrews 1:5–14](#); [7:24–25](#); [Revelation 19:10](#)

## The Written Word

During the prophet Jeremiah's crisis at his public trial on the temple grounds, friends saved his life ([Jeremiah 26](#)). Yet, King Jehoiakim killed the prophet Uriah and tried to arrest Jeremiah. Would this end Jeremiah's public ministry? Was public speaking the only way to communicate the Lord's messages to Judah's leaders and people?

Killing and silencing the messengers did not stop the Lord's messages. The Lord can also effectively share his message in writing. The Lord told Jeremiah to write down all the messages he had preached ([Jeremiah 36](#)). Jeremiah had a helper named Baruch, who was skilled in writing and making copies.

While hiding, Jeremiah and Baruch bought a scroll (a paper roll made of papyrus) and prepared it to write the messages. When they finished writing, they read the scroll in the temple courtyard and to King Jehoiakim. The king cut up the scroll and burned it. But Jeremiah wrote the messages on a new scroll, adding new material. For the rest of Jeremiah's ministry, he wrote his messages on papyrus. Then he sent them to leaders of various countries and to the Israelite exiles in Babylon (see [Jeremiah 29](#)).

The first instance of writing God's word of course appears in Exodus. God instructed Moses to write the words of the covenant ([Exodus 24:4](#); also see [Exodus 17:14](#)). It specifically states that Moses wrote the book of Deuteronomy ([Deuteronomy 31:9, 24](#)). The existence of the written law likely started a tradition of documenting God's revelations ([Joshua 24:26](#); [1 Samuel 10:25](#); [1 Chronicles 29:29](#); [2 Chronicles 9:29](#); [Isaiah 8:16–17](#); [30:8](#)). It seems that prophets recorded many of Israel's historical writings (see [2 Chronicles 12:15](#); [13:22](#)).

Communities preserved these documents for a long time, especially those written on leather scrolls. They made many copies from one document. These copies were so valuable that people carefully preserved them for centuries. They also translated the copies into many languages.

The book of Jeremiah and the writings of other prophets, wise men, and teachers have become preserved, collected, and handed down to us as the Old and New Testaments. These texts provide a written record of God's messages to his people (see [2 Timothy 3:16–17](#); [2 Peter 1:20–21](#)).

### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 17:14](#); [31:18](#); [34:27–28](#); [Deuteronomy 31:9–13](#); [Isaiah 30:8](#); [Jeremiah 30:2–3](#); [Jeremiah 36:1–32](#); [45:1](#); [51:60–64](#); [Ezekiel 43:11](#); [Daniel 7:1](#); [Luke 1:1–4](#); [John 5:46–47](#); [20:30–31](#); [21:24–25](#); [Acts 1:1–2](#); [Romans 15:4](#); [1 Corinthians 10:11](#); [2 Timothy 3:16–17](#); [Philemon 1:21](#); [Hebrews 13:22](#); [1 Peter 5:12](#); [2 Peter 1:20–21](#); [1 John 1:4](#); [2:12–24](#); [5:13](#); [Revelation 1:11](#); [10:4](#); [21:5](#); [22:18–19](#)

## Tolerance

The apostle Paul urges tolerance (patient understanding) between those weak in faith and those strong in faith. He teaches Christians to accept each other ([Romans 14:1](#); [15:7](#)). He instructs them to stop condemning one another and making each other feel unimportant. Instead, they should worship God with a united voice and spirit ([Romans 15:6](#)).

Paul is discussing whether Christians need to follow certain Old Testament laws and Jewish worship practices. Scholars use the Greek word *adiaphora*, meaning "non-essentials," to describe beliefs or practices that Scripture neither requires nor bans. On these issues, Christians should accept different opinions. Sometimes, Christians may feel free to do certain activities, but doing so might cause problems for others. In these cases, Paul advises Christians to consider others' needs before their own (see [1 Corinthians 8:1–13](#)).

Paul uses a different approach to tolerance when the good news (gospel) is at risk. In the letter to the Galatians, for example, Paul confronts false teachings about the good news by strongly criticizing the false teachers ([Galatians 1:6–9](#)). He warns readers that accepting false teachings will separate them from Christ ([Galatians 5:4](#)).

Today, we must be cautious about what we tolerate and what we oppose. Christians should carefully consider the issues they encounter with other Christians. If we stay true to the basic truth of the good news about Jesus, we should not argue or be divided over less important matters.

Yet, some issues affect the core message of the good news. In these cases, Christians should remain firm and faithful to the good news and to Jesus Christ. Sometimes, it is difficult to determine if an issue is central. It may be important for discussion but not essential for Christian unity. Paul's approach to various issues in his time can guide us in handling conflicts and arguments today.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 133:1-3](#); [Romans 12:9-21](#); [14:1-15:13](#); [1 Corinthians 1:10](#); [6:1-20](#); [8:1-13](#); [10:1-11:1](#); [12:12-27](#); [13:1-8](#); [2 Corinthians 6:14-7:1](#); [Colossians 3:12-15](#); [2 Timothy 2:23-26](#)

### True Justice

The community of God's people in Old Testament Israel had to care for widows, orphans, and foreigners ([Deuteronomy 27:19](#)). God wanted the Israelites to represent his justice (see [10:17-19](#)). He wanted them to always remember that they had been slaves. He wanted them to remember that they were defenseless in Egypt (see [10:19](#); [24:18-22](#)). As those who received God's constant love and faithfulness, how could they ignore the rights and needs of the weakest among them?

Every society has structures that separate the powerful from the weak and the important from the less important people. This was true for Old Testament Israel, even with its special role as "a holy nation" ([Exodus 19:6](#)). Judges and officials were responsible for protecting the law. They might favor those with money, high status, or influence, especially if they offered bribes ([Deuteronomy 16:19](#)). Yet, no one can bribe God and he treats all people fairly ([10:17](#)). To God, the rich and poor, powerful and weak, honored and desperate are all the same.

The prophets of Israel knew the importance of fairness and justice. They often urged these principles in both community and national life ([Isaiah 1:17](#); [10:1-4](#); [59:14-19](#); [Ezekiel 22:23-29](#); [Amos 2:6-8](#); [Habakkuk 1:4](#)). The New Testament also commands for fair treatment of the poor and those without advantages. It mentions that God is not pleased when others ignore them ([Matthew 23:23](#); [2 Corinthians 9:6-10](#); [James 2:1-7](#)).

Justice that does not follow God's standard is not true justice. Those who are unjust will encounter full punishment from the Judge of all the earth (see [Deuteronomy 25:13-16](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 23:3](#); [Leviticus 19:15](#); [Deuteronomy 10:17-19](#); [16:19](#); [24:12-22](#); [25:13-16](#); [27:19](#); [Psalm 82:1-5](#); [Proverbs 11:1](#); [Isaiah 1:17](#); [10:1-4](#); [11:3-4](#); [59:14-19](#); [Jeremiah 22:13-17](#); [Ezekiel 22:23-29](#); [45:9-10](#); [Amos 2:6-8](#); [8:5-6](#); [Habakkuk 1:4](#); [Matthew 23:23](#); [Luke 18:6-8](#); [James 2:1-7](#)

### True Success

God wants his people to fully commit to him ([Deuteronomy 6:4-6](#); compare [Matthew 22:37](#)). True success comes from seeking God and acknowledging him as the ruler, avoiding all false gods ([Matthew 6:33](#); [1 John 5:21](#)). For the people of Israel, success depended on their obedience to God's covenant (see [Leviticus 26:1-46](#); [Deuteronomy 28:1-68](#)). Israel's spiritual condition and its leaders greatly affected whether they would keep God's favor and remain in the promised land.

The author of 1-2 Kings starts each ruler's story with a spiritual evaluation. This often compares each king's devotion to God with King David's example (see [1 Kings 11:38](#); [14:8](#); [15:3-5](#), [11](#)). These books show that the future of Israel and Judah depends on their kings' spiritual leadership. God's people could only succeed in Canaan if they worshipped God faithfully (see [Deuteronomy 12:4-7](#)). The text often criticizes worship of false gods in local places (see, for example, [3:2-4](#); [11:7](#)).

Starting with King Jeroboam I, the kings of Israel (the northern kingdom) consistently practiced false religion and Scripture criticizes them for it ([1 Kings 12:31-32](#); [13:33-34](#); [15:25-26](#), [33-34](#); [16:11-13](#), [25-26](#)). Among these kings, King Ahab was the most evil ([16:30-33](#); [21:25-26](#)). His son Ahaziah followed his example and God condemned him for his worship of false gods ([22:51-53](#)).

The kings of the northern kingdom led their people toward certain exile ([2 Kings 17:21-23](#)). Despite God's repeated attempts to gain their attention, they did not listen ([2 Kings 17:13-15](#), [23](#)). So God gave them the consequences for continuous spiritual unfaithfulness (see [1 Kings 13:33-34](#)).

Some kings of Judah (the southern kingdom) receive praise, but Scripture criticizes many of them. Rehoboam allowed worship of false gods to spread in Judah ([1 Kings 14:22-24](#)). Abijam continued his father's sins ([15:3](#)). Scripture even criticizes the good kings Asa and Jehoshaphat for allowing popular local worship sites to remain (see

[15:14](#); [22:43](#)). Failing to give God his rightful place led to disastrous results.

The kings and people of the northern kingdom were stupid for doing what they wanted. Yet, the Lord will bless and give true happiness to those who respect and live by his commands ([Psalms 33:12](#); [119:1-2](#); [144:15](#)). True success comes from recognizing and trusting God as the ruler of one's life ([Matthew 6:33](#)). As shown by Jesus and his early followers, success does not always mean having material wealth. Joy and peace come from living by God's will and trusting in him (see [Philippians 3:8-14](#); [1 Peter 4:12-19](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 6:1-8](#); [12:4-7](#); [Joshua 1:7-8](#); [1 Samuel 18:14](#); [1 Kings 11:38](#); [12:26-33](#); [13:1-3](#); [33-34](#); [14:8-11](#); [2 Kings 17:13-23](#); [Psalms 33:12](#); [119:1-2](#); [144:15](#); [Matthew 6:33](#); [Luke 10:25-28](#); [1 John 5:21](#)

## Trusting God in Isaiah

The prophet Isaiah knew that humans can be unreliable ([Isaiah 2:22](#)). When in trouble, the people of Judah often asked other nations like Egypt or Assyria for help. Yet, Isaiah explained that Judah's success and safety depended on trusting God (see [Isaiah 8:9-17](#)). The Assyrian army made fun of King Hezekiah for trusting God, but this trust led to a great victory for God's people ([Isaiah 36:1-37:37](#)).

Those who trust in the Lord feel deep respect for him and do not fear ([29:23](#); [35:4](#)). This is because they know the Lord is with them ([51:12](#)). They praise him because they trust him ([12:1-2](#); [25:9](#)). They show their trust by obeying him ([26:8](#)).

The faithful people of God may experience the effects of his judgment on his enemies as they wait for the Lord's salvation. Yet, they gain new strength each day ([40:31](#)). They consider themselves citizens of God's city, Zion (see [26:1-3](#)). Those who trust in the Lord have true and lasting inner peace ([26:3](#); [12](#); [32:17-18](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 2:22](#); [7:4-9](#); [8:16-20](#); [12:1-2](#); [26:2-3](#); [12](#); [32:17-18](#); [35:4](#); [40:9-11](#); [28-31](#); [51:12](#)

## Trusting God in the Psalms

The Lord's love inspires people to trust him ([Psalms 13:5](#); [17:7](#); [21:7](#); [32:10](#); [36:7](#); [52:8](#); [143:8](#)). His name and reputation also build trust ([9:10](#); [20:7](#); [33:21](#)). Godly people avoid worshiping false gods and anything that makes their complete trust in the Lord weak ([31:6](#); [14](#); [44:6](#); [49:6-13](#); [52:7](#)). Trusting the Lord is wise. It rejects what is stupid and evil and follows the spiritual way of the Lord ([31:19](#); [37:3](#); [5](#); [115:11](#)).

For godly people, every challenge in life is a chance to grow in trust ([Psalms 9:9](#); [25:2](#); [46:1](#); [55:23](#); [57:1](#); [59:16](#); [62:8](#); [78:7](#)). Godly people do not fear life's situations ([56:3-4](#); [11](#); [112:7](#)). Instead they become more confident during them ([112:7](#); [125:1](#)).

The Lord saves, cares for, and rewards those who trust in him (see [Psalms 7:1](#); [16:1](#); [25:20](#); [26:1](#); [31:1-2](#); [4](#); [19](#); [34:22](#); [37:39-40](#); [86:2](#)). God blesses them as they hope for God's redemption ([2:12](#); [22:4-5](#); [34:8](#); [40:4](#); [84:12](#); [37:7](#); [34](#); [38:15](#); [40:1](#); [119:166](#); [130:5-6](#)). Faith in the Lord brings joy and reasons to praise him ([5:11](#); [18:30-36](#); [28:7](#); [40:3](#); [56:4](#); [64:10](#)).

#### Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 7:1](#); [9:9](#); [11:1](#); [18:30-36](#); [22:4-5](#); [8-9](#); [25:1-3](#); [20](#); [26:1](#); [28:7](#); [31:1-6](#); [34:8-10](#); [37:3-9](#); [40:1-4](#); [46:1](#); [56:3-4](#); [11](#); [62:1-12](#); [64:10](#); [78:7](#); [84:12](#); [86:2](#); [112:7](#); [115:9-11](#); [119:42](#); [125:1](#); [130:5-6](#); [141:8](#); [Proverbs 3:5](#); [22:19](#); [Isaiah 26:4](#); [40:31](#); [Jeremiah 17:7](#); [Hebrews 10:35](#)

## Trusting in Human Strength

God often showed his power to his people throughout their history. He made an elderly couple, who could not have children, the ancestors of a great nation. He saved this nation from the powerful ruler of Egypt. He performed many miracles to help them survive in the wilderness.

He also won victories over their enemies many times during the conquest, the time of the judges, and the period of kings. Yet, throughout their history, the people of Israel often did not trust the Lord. They chose to rely on human strength instead.

Once, Asa, King of Judah, asked the king of Aram for help. Aram was a long-time enemy of God's people. Asa gave him treasures from the temple and palace so he would attack Baasha, King of Israel ([2](#)

[Chronicles 16:1-6](#)). The prophet Hanani criticized Asa, warning that Aram would remain an enemy to Judah. Past battles showed that Asa only needed God as support ([16:8](#)).

Asa's dependence on the king of Aram showed a deeper spiritual issue. Asa forgot that "the eyes of the LORD roam to and fro over all the earth" ([2 Chronicles 16:9](#); see also [Zechariah 4:10](#)). When Hanani showed Asa his mistakes, Asa quickly put the prophet in prison. The angry king also unfairly harmed the people ([2 Chronicles 16:10](#)).

Asa shows how people often rely on their own resources and get angry when corrected (see [Proverbs 11:7](#); [Isaiah 31:1](#); [Jeremiah 17:5-6](#)). Even those who have seen the Lord's power can act this way. This was true for the Israelites rescued from slavery in Egypt. It is better to trust the Lord and accept his guidance (compare [Psalms 33:18](#); [37:7](#); [Isaiah 50:10](#); [Jeremiah 17:7-8](#); [Acts 13:43](#)).

Life teaches us to trust God. We might start by doing good and right ([2 Chronicles 14:1-6](#)). But our spiritual impact is not complete until our last action (see [Romans 2:6-11](#); [1 Corinthians 4:1-5](#)). We must not let personal ambitions make weak our faithfulness to God's kingdom.

#### Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 13:4](#); [2 Kings 6:15-18](#); [2 Chronicles 16:1-10](#); [32:7-8](#); [Psalms 20:6-8](#); [37:3-7](#); [60:11-12](#); [Proverbs 11:7-8](#); [18:10-12](#); [Ecclesiastes 3:14](#); [Isaiah 31:1-5](#); [Jeremiah 17:5-8](#); [Matthew 10:26-31](#); [Romans 2:6-11](#); [1 Corinthians 4:1-5](#); [Revelation 2:8-11](#)